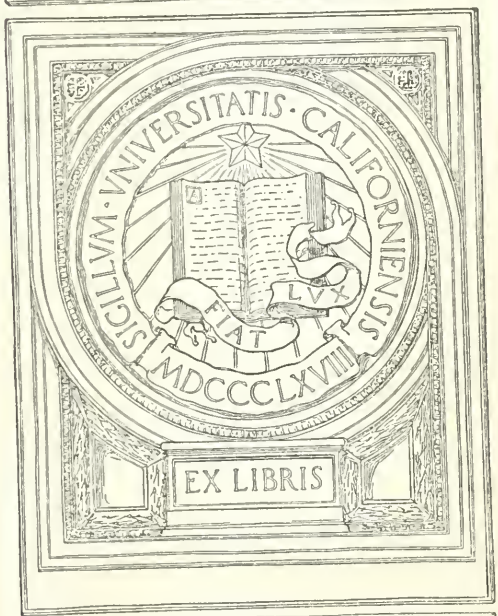
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA
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From the author.

Jan: 23rd 1885. Faridpur.

# THE DISTRICT OF BÁKARGANJ.

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DISTRICT
BAKARGANJ
REVENUE SURVEYS.
BAY OF BENGAL
TIPPERAH
NOAKHALI
BAGHAIAT
BARISAL
BAKARGUNJ
PIROJPUR
JHALAKATI
NALCHITI
BHOLA
PATUAKHALI
BARGUNA
DAKHIN SHAHBAZPUR
Bhairab and Tentul
Barhamudi
Hewladar
Dakhin Shahbazpur
Patang
Rangabali
Kakchira
Mirzaganj
Tetulia
Kalmegha
Sandwip
Hatia
Kachua
Chandpur
Madaripur
Shibchar
Gosairhat
Kotwalipara
Sarupkathi
Nalchiti
Bakarganj
Mirzaganj
Tati Bandar
Patuakhali
Galachipa
Kalaikhali
Bauphal
Dashmina
Kalkini
Dasar
Mathbaria
Nazirpur
Sadipur
Shikarpur
Shahebganj
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Shahebganj
Sandwip
Hatia
Kachua
Chandpur
Madaripur
Shibchar
Patang
Rangabali
Tetulia
Kalmegha

THE

# DISTRICT OF BÁKARGANJ

## *ITS HISTORY AND STATISTICS*

BY

H. BEVERIDGE, B.C.S.

MAGISTRATE AND COLLECTOR OF BÁKARGANJ

LONDON

TRÜBNER & CO., LUDGATE HILL

1876

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THE INHABITANTS OF THE DISTRICT

WHICH IT ATTEMPTS

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Dawson's

357104

# PREFACE.

This work is the result of nearly five years' experience in Bákarganj, and of subsequent researches in the India Office and the Library of the British Museum. My primary object has been to write a book which would be useful and interesting to the officers of Government and the inhabitants of the district, and therefore there is much in it which can have no attraction for the general reader. It is pleasing to think that so many district-histories are now in print, and that we are beginning to have for Bengal some such statistical account as the industry and patriotism of Sir John Sinclair caused to be prepared for Scotland.

Among older works we have the accounts of Rangpúr, Dinagepúr, and Purneah, by Francis Buchanan; that of Cuttack, by Mr Stirling; and the excellent description of Dacca, by Dr Taylor.[1] Among the more recent we

[1] This work was published by Government in 1839, and is now out of print. It is much to be desired that Government would correct and reprint it.

have the reports on the districts of the Dacca Division, Mr Brown's report on Tipperah, Colonel Gastrell's reports on Jessore, Faridpúr, and Bákarganj; Mr Hunter's description of Birbhum in his "Rural Annals," and the same author and Mr Toynbee's books on Orissa, Mr Glazier's account of Rangpúr, and, above all, Mr Westland's admirable report on Jessore. The reports on the Dacca districts owe their origin, I believe, to the forethought and public spirit of Mr Buckland, but more than three-fourths of the work was executed by competition-civilians; and I am proud to think that four of the other books I have mentioned have been written by members of the same class. In other parts of India this new class of civilians has not been idle, and I have been told on good authority that one of the best district-histories is the account of Ghazipúr, by Mr Oldham, B.C.S.

It will perhaps be thought that I have written too much about such an obscure district as Bákarganj, but my own consciousness is that I ought to have written a great deal more, and that I have often been very meagre in my treatment of important subjects. The truth is, no one man can write an exhaustive district-history, and still less can a foreigner adequately depict a district of Bengal. What I have chiefly laboured have been the descriptions of the parganas and the official history of the district. I did this not because they were the most important, but because they were less likely to

be done by others. My idea always has been that the proper person to write the history of a district is one who is a native of it, who has lived all his life in it, and who has abundance of leisure to collect information. It is only a Bengali who can treat satisfactorily of the productions of his country, or of its social condition—its castes, leading families, peculiarities of language, customs, &c. I have not attempted to go minutely into these matters, but my hope is that I have done enough to stimulate discussion, and that I may serve to ring the fuller writer in. I have said very little about the mode of cultivating rice or other agricultural methods, both because I do not think that there are any which are peculiar to the district, and the ordinary practices have been repeatedly described already, and because I have observed that such parts of a book are always the first to become out of date.

In the chapter entitled "General Remarks" I have indulged in the luxury of making some observations of wider scope than were admissible in the earlier part of the book. Perhaps some may think that these observations are out of place in a district-history, but I hope they have some connection with it, since they presented themselves to me while writing this book. I do not think that there is anything singular or novel in the observations. Indeed, I should be the first to allow that they had no value whatever if I thought that they expressed nobody's opinions but my own. The only

value, or at least the only practical value of opinions about India, or perhaps about any subject, is that they are shared by numbers of people, and are such as naturally suggest themselves to fair and reasonable persons who are conversant with the subject-matter. With regard to the question of the gradual abandonment of India, which is mooted by me in a note to the General Remarks, I am glad to be able to fortify myself with the following remarks by my late father at the conclusion of his "History of India:"—

"To the attempts made to christianise India, it has been objected that the inevitable result of their success would be to destroy the British rule. The inhabitants made aware of their natural rights, and become capable of self-government, would throw off our yoke and declare their independence. Unquestionably they would. But what then? Is it meant that, for the purpose of perpetuating our empire in the East, we must endeavour to keep our subjects there in a state of semi-barbarism, and discountenance all endeavours to raise them to our level in respect of intelligence, religion, and general civilisation? The time has been when such selfish and heartless policy would have been looked upon with favour, but a better spirit now prevails; and the determination, as announced in the Queen's proclamation, and cordially acquiesced in by all classes of society, is to do justice to India, and more than compensate her for all the wealth she has bestowed upon us by furnishing her with the means of

rising above her present degraded state, and attaining to the highest form of European civilisation. Should the effect be to enable her to dispense with our tutelage, we shall have the satisfaction of feeling that we ourselves have been the willing instruments of her emancipation, while she, even in severing the political ties by which she is now bound to us, will not forget how much she shall then owe to us for the enlightened and generous policy which gradually prepared her for freedom. Should the day ever come that India, in consequence of the development of her resources by British capital, and the enlightenment of her people by British philanthropy, shall again take rank among the nations as an independent state, then it will not be too much to say that the extinction of our Indian Empire by such peaceful means sheds more lustre on the British name than all the other events recorded in its history."

In the above passage my father speaks of christianising India.[1] I should have preferred the word "civilise," unless, indeed, the term christianise be used in a different sense than it is at present. I have not the slightest expectation that the inhabitants of India will ever become Christians in the ordinary sense of that

[1] Much of my father's history was written against time and in failing health, but the vigour of his mind becomes apparent whenever a suitable subject for discussion presents itself. Few pieces of writing, for example, can be more vigorous than his reflections on the administration and trial of Warren Hastings. See also his remarks on the Permanent Settlement and the annexation of Oude.

word, nor do I suppose that any well-informed person believes that missionary efforts are making progress in India.

The plan of my book is first to give an account of the land. Thus I begin with the physical features, and then go on to a description of the parganas, the Sundarbans, and the Government estates. After that I notice the various kinds of tenures, and I have endeavoured to give some information about the numerous under-tenures of the district.

The chapter on antiquities and early history has been placed third in the book, in order to lead up to the constitution of the parganas and the financial history of the district.

In Part II. I have described the people and the natural productions, &c.; and in Part III. I have given a history of the administration, and chapters on detached points, such as the town of Barisál, the jail, &c.

The question of the correct spelling of the proper names is one I have taken some trouble with, but I am aware that I have omitted the accents in many places, and that also the spelling is often wrong. It is not in every case easy to know the etymology of a proper name, and in the absence of this knowledge we are very apt to make mistakes in spelling.

A considerable part of the book is taken up with the Appendices, and I trust that whatever judgment be passed on the rest of the work, it will be found

that the Appendices contain something of value. I regret that I have been obliged to print the letters of Messrs Douglas and Massie from the imperfect copies in the Barisál office, and that there are therefore some passages in them which are probably incorrect. The reports of the Collectors at the time of making the Permanent Settlement are the most important documents in the history of each of the districts of Bengal, but it appears that very few of them have yet been printed. They are fast mouldering away in our record-rooms, and I hope that before it is too late Government will publish a volume containing all the correspondence about the Permanent Settlement of each district.

Since writing the note about early travellers in Bengal (Appendix, p. 444) I have seen the first volume of Ramusio's "Collection of Travels" (Venice, 1550), and I am almost convinced that the lost city of Bengala is neither more nor less than the famous city of Gour, in the Maldaha district. One of the most valuable accounts of early India appears to be the narrative of Edward Barbessa or Barbosa, who was a native of Lisbon, and finished his book in 1516. He afterwards sailed with Magellan on his voyage round the world, and was killed at the island of Zebu in 1521 (Biographie Universelle). Barbessa gives a description of the city of Bengala (p. 330), and it appears from it that it was a Mahomedan town—at least the king of it was a Mahomedan, and he appears to have resided in it. The

narratives of Varthema, and of the anonymous author of the "Summary of the People of the East," &c., appended to Barbessa's account, also describe the king as being a Mahomedan, and this fact appears to me to render it almost certain that Bengala is Gour, as the latter was the only great Mahomedan city in Bengal. If Bengala had been a Hindu city, and governed by a Hindu king, we could understand its disappearance; but if there had been any large Mahomedan city in Bengal except Gour, it would certainly have been mentioned by the Mahomedan historians. The anonymous author above referred to says that the king of Tripura was tributary to the king of Bengala, and that Bengala was a port two days' journey from the mouth of the Ganges. This was written in the beginning of the sixteenth century, when Gour must have been much nearer the sea than it now is. What the origin of the name Gour is I do not know, but I believe that, like Bengala, it was a name given to the country as well as to the town. We find it in other places than in Maldaha; for example, some years ago there was a village called Gournadi—*i.e.*, the river of Gour—in the northern part of Bákarganj.[1]

[1] Dr Wise has referred me to a passage in Ortelius which says that Appian considered Bengala to be the emporium of Barakoura mentioned by Ptolemy, and that Gastaldi thought Barakoura was Bacala. (See the "Thesaurus Geographicus," under "Baracura.") Perhaps this name Barakoura is the origin of Le Blanc's remark about Batacouta. Appian is properly Apianus, and this again is the Latin appellation of Peter Bienewitz (both *apis* and *biene* signifying a bee), who was professor of mathematics at Ingolstadt in 1520, and published a cosmography. If Gour be thought too far

There is an interesting remark made by Barbessa which bears on the question of the conversion of the Hindus of Eastern Bengal to Mahomedanism discussed by me at p. 247. He says that the king of Bengala being a Mahomedan, many of his Hindu subjects are every day becoming Mahomedans in order to get favour with the king and his governors. The anonymous author of the summary tells us that the kings of Bengala had been Mahomedans for three hundred years, and this statement nearly corresponds with the date of Bakhtyar Khilji's conquest of Bengal (1203). The statement in my Appendix that Varthema was the first traveller in Bengal is incorrect, as Nicolo de Conti preceded him by nearly a hundred years. Conti was a Venetian, and his travels are printed in the first volume of Ramusio.

In conclusion, I wish to say that the Indian Government is in no way responsible for any of the opinions expressed in my book, and that these must not be regarded as having any official value whatever. I trust, however, that I have not said anything rashly, or which is other than a fair expression of opinion, and I do not think that I have said anything which could give just cause of offence to any one.

inland for Bengala, then Hugli, which was early a Mahomedan town, may be the place meant. (See the dictionary of Bruzen de La Martinière (1730), under the word "Bengale.") This writer says, "Dans le grand nombre de voyages de l'Indoustan que j'ai lus je n'en ai jamais trouvé où il soit parlé de Bengale comme d'une ville dont on ait dit quelques particularités capables d'en certifier la position ni même l'existence.

I have to express my obligations to the report on Bákarganj by Mr Sutherland, to Mr Westland's Jessore, to Colonel Gastrell's report, and to the disquisition of Professor Blochmann on the geography and history of Bengal. I have also been assisted by the Bengali account of Bákarganj by Naba Kanth Chattanji, which is a very good little manual, though I am sorry that the author has not acknowledged how much he has borrowed from Mr Sutherland. Finally, I have to declare how much assistance I have derived from the native officials of Bákarganj, and especially from the Collectorate Peshkar, Babu Koilas Chandra Ganguli.

The map prefixed to the work is a reduction from the Revenue Survey map, and I have made some alterations in it in order to bring it more into accordance with the existing state of the country, and also to exhibit the names mentioned in the book. I am indebted to the Indian Government for permission to make use of the Revenue Survey map.

H. BEVERIDGE.

London, 23*d March* 1876.

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THE

# DISTRICT OF BÁKARGANJ.

## *PART I.*

## CHAPTER I.

### *INTRODUCTION.*

The district of Bákarganj is situated in Eastern Bengal, and is one of the four collectorates which compose the Division or Commissionership of Dacca. It lies in the lower portion of the delta which has been formed by deposits from the united waters of the Ganges or Padma, the Bráhmaputra, and the Meghna, and falls within latitudes 21° to 23° N., and longitudes 89° to 91° E. The boundaries of the district of Bákarganj are given in detail in the "Calcutta Gazette" of 16th September 1874. Briefly it may be described as bounded on the north by Faridpúr, on the west by Faridpúr and the Baleshwar river (which separates it from Jessore), on the south by the Bay of Bengal, and on the east by the Meghna and its estuary. Its length from north to south is about 85 miles, and its breadth, including the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, is about 60 miles. Its area is about 4300 square miles. It is thus more than half the size of Wales, the area of which is 7397 square miles,

and it is slightly larger than the two counties of Somerset and Devon, the united area of which amounts to 4225 square miles (1636+2589). The area of Yorkshire, to which also it may be compared, is 5983 square miles.[1] It must, however, be confessed that the area of Bákarganj is not quite accurately known. The figures which I have given are derived from the Topographical Survey, but that survey was made in the years 1860 to 1863, and considerable changes must have taken place since then in an alluviating district such as Bákarganj. Also, I do not know the precise alteration of area which has been made by the transfer of the greater part of the Mádaripúr subdivision to Faridpúr.

The population of Bákarganj, according to the census of 1872, and after exclusion of the transferred portion of the Mádaripúr subdivision, is 1,878,144, of whom about two-thirds (1,254,429) are Mahomedans. The remaining third is composed of Hindus, with the exception of a few thousand Buddhists and Christians.

Bákarganj was made a *zila* or district for magisterial purposes in 1797 by Regulation 7 of that year, but it did not become a Collectorate till 1817. Barisál is the chief town, and the seat of the courts. It is about 180 miles east of Calcutta. The number of villages or townships in the district appears to be 3312. The land revenue is about thirteen lacs and seventy thousand rupees (£137,000), and the total revenue from all sources may be stated as sixteen lacs.[2] The cost of the local administration is under three lacs.

[1] The area of 4935 square miles which is assigned to Bákarganj in the Bengal Administration Report for 1872–73, includes the subdivision of Mádaripúr, which is now part of Faridpúr.

[2] In the Bengal Administration Report for 1873–74, p. ix. of the Statistical Returns, the land revenue of Bákarganj is given at Rs.1,511,278, and the gross revenue at Rs.1,905,464, but this includes Mádaripúr.

# CHAPTER II.

## *PHYSICAL FEATURES.*

### I. GENERAL DESCRIPTION.

The whole district of Bákarganj is an alluvial formation, and the most general observation which can be made concerning it is that the ground is everywhere flat. There is not a hill in any part of it. The general slope is from north to south, but it is very slight. From the Ganges to the Bay of Bengal (this description includes Farídpúr) the difference in level is only about 22 feet over the whole distance of 150 miles, or an average slope of 1·8 inch per mile. There is also a general depression towards the centre of the district (*vide* Colonel Gastrell's Report). The western part of the district and the central and southern portions down to the Sundarbans might almost be described as forming one vast rice-field, sprinkled with trees and villages, and intersected by numerous watercourses. The northern and eastern portions are higher, and produce large quantities of cocoa and betel nuts, sugar-cane, *pán*, and some jute and cotton.

The district consists partly of mainland, and partly of islands in the estuary of the Meghna. The islands are quite flat, but are for the most part well raised above the level of the sea; and as there are no rivers in them, they are generally less swampy than Bákarganj Proper. Commonly they present the appearance of a low table-

land, of a rich soil, and yield many kinds of crops. Two or three are, however, uninhabited and uncultivated, and are for the most part covered with tree jungle. The largest island is Dakhin Shahbázpúr, which is the seat of a subdivision, and has an area of about 800 square miles, and a population of about 220,000 persons. The other principal islands are Kali, also called Panchkháli, Kázal, Bara Baisdia, Chota Baisdia, and its adjuncts Koralia and Rangabali, Kalmi, Chopa, Kúkri Múkri, and Manpúra. The last of these has a population of about 4500.

The proper Bengali word for an island is *upadwip*, and in legal phraseology the Persian word *jazira* is employed, but the word in common use is *char*. This name is applied indifferently to large islands, and to mere shoals and sandbanks, even though the latter fringe the mainland. Many chars are submerged at every tide; hence the aspect of the rivers varies much during each day. At flood, the estuary of the Meghna presents the appearance of a vast expanse of water, tempting one to think that it might be a highway for all the ships of the world. But the ebb shows the deceptiveness of this waste of waters, for then long lines of sand gradually emerge even in mid-channel. The navigation is so uncertain that the native boatmen, sailing in flat-bottomed country boats which draw only one or two feet of water, do not like to set out much after slack-water, lest they should ground as the ebb advances, and so expose themselves to being caught by the bore; if they have a fair wind, a man called the *goliya* or bow-man is continually thrusting a bamboo into the water ahead of the boat to ascertain the depth. English-built ships have, I believe, never ascended the Meghna, but sloops from Chittagong sail up it in the cold weather to

Narainganj, and also cross over to Dakhin Shahbázpúr, laden with earth-oil, and bringing away in exchange cocoa and betel nuts.

I have said that the district is an alluvial formation. In fact, it may be looked upon as a conquest won by the Ganges and the Meghna from the Bay of Bengal. With its central depression, and its deeply-indented southern boundary, it has somewhat the appearance of the outstretched palm of the hand. Thus a fanciful eye might regard it as a glove flung down by the Ganges to the ocean, in gage of battle, and as an augury of future victories.

As might be expected from its flatness, the scenery of Bákarganj is somewhat monotonous and uninteresting. As most of the district is of comparatively recent origin, it has not many fine trees, nor are there any ancient buildings to give picturesqueness to the landscape. In fact, there is something peculiarly unromantic and prosaic about the first impressions of Bákarganj. It strikes one as being a sort of agricultural Manchester, producing bread-stuffs instead of cotton cloth, but without the art culture for which Manchester is so justly famous. There is no ancient history of Bákarganj: no battles have been fought in it, or at least no traces of them now remain; there are hardly any resident aristocracy; and there are no art products of any kind. Other districts have their workers in ivory and silver, their shawlmakers, &c., but Bákarganj has none of these. Committees for International Exhibitions can get nothing from it to show in Europe as trophies of Indian skill or taste. It must be confessed, too, that there is something depressing in the air of Bákarganj, and in the continual prospect of swamps and muddy rivers. One longs for a dry tract of country, dotted with mango topes and tamarind-trees,

across which one could ride or walk without being brought to a stand every three or four hundred yards by the slimy bank of a *khál*. Boats are all very well, and one acknowledges that there is no other mode of conveyance which is so economical, or so effectual for the transport of heavy or fragile goods, but one wishes that it could be dispensed with occasionally. It is fatiguing to find that you cannot reach a place only ten miles off on the map in less than eight or nine hours, and that if wind and tide be against you, you may not reach it in less than a day and a half.

Yet, in spite of all these disadvantages, the district is not without its interest and its beauty. A writer in the "Calcutta Review" endeavours to conjure up a feeling of admiration for a Bákarganj river, by suggesting that its muddy waters have come down from the magnificent valleys of the Himalayas; but I am afraid that this is an idea which will not readily come home to men's bosoms, at least except of that small minority which has seen Gangotri, &c. I would rest the claims of Bákarganj to the possession of some beauty and interest on more tangible and more human grounds, and would especially insist on the greenness and freshness which characterise its scenery. There is at least nothing arid or barren about the Bákarganj landscape; and one who has seen the weary plains of Cawnpore or Delhi must, I think, turn with delight and refreshment to the waving palm-trees, the wide sheets of green rice spreading without let or hindrance of hedge or wall almost as far as the horizon, and the full and flowing rivers, which meet the eye in Eastern Bengal. The Mahomedans called Bengal the Paradise of countries; the Englishman, panting in the heat, and longing for a sight of something more inspiriting than a uniform plain, is inclined to question

the justice of the epithet. But there is a sense in which it is justifiable, and that too one which is perhaps higher than any mere sentimental feeling for fine scenery can be. As Macaulay teaches us, the love of rocks and mountains is a product of civilisation; so that we may utter the paradox, that the love of nature is an artificial taste. But no apprenticeship, and no study of poets and painters, are required for the admiration of a field of standing corn, or of a wide plain of rice. Such things appeal to our sympathies as men, and are lovely, as the face of a friend may be dear to us, not because of its mere beauty, but because of its associations. If we look at the homesteads of the Bákarganj peasantry, standing like "moated granges" embowered in bamboos, *ják* fruit and plantain trees, tamarinds and palms, and surrounded by luxuriant rice-fields, we cannot help feeling that the inhabitants enjoy a considerable amount of physical wellbeing, and that they are just objects of envy to the residents of other countries. The general character of Bákarganj scenery is that of open plains, called *kholas* (opens), of various sizes, separated from each other by ribands of fruit-trees, and traversed by numerous watercourses. The ribands represent the villages, the houses being always scattered and shrouded in trees. There are hardly any towns in Bákarganj, and every house in it has the appearance of a detached villa, and is, with its orchard, a sort of *rus in urbe*. The houses are literally "moated granges," for every ryot's house in Bákarganj is surrounded by a trench, the earth from which is used for raising the foundation of the homestead and the garden-ground. With the same object, it is common to dig a tank whenever a homestead is made. The lines of villages are like living walls, the bricks and lime being replaced by tree-stems

and green leaves; and when the sunlight falls on them, or they are seen in the calm moonlight, the effect is very beautiful.

Rivers are always objects of interest in a landscape, and though those of Bákarganj are wanting in the picturesqueness of mountain streams, yet some of them are noble bodies of water, and their banks are often well-wooded and pleasant to the eye. There is, perhaps, not a more graceful sight in nature than a group of areca palms standing on the bank of a river. The spreading banyan, the sacred fig with its wealth of acuminated leaves, the *gáb*, conspicuous by its somewhat dome-shaped habit, and its massive, dark-green foliage, and the clumps of feathery bamboos, have all their attraction; but perhaps the most beautiful tree is the tamarind, which often attains a large size, and has a peculiarly elegant appearance, from its pinnated leaves and its air of ease and freedom. The branches are long and drooping, and fall about the stem with the luxuriant and unstudied grace of a woman's hair escaped from a fillet. The banks of some of the smaller rivers are exceedingly pretty. For example, the khál at Rahamatpúr, commonly called the Rajah's Moat (from a tradition that it was dug as an entrenchment for the palace at Madhabpásha), is very picturesque, both banks being richly clothed with fruit-trees, flowering creepers, &c.

The rivers frequently present an animated appearance from the number of boats which traverse them, and there is something cheering and inspiriting in the sight of a fleet of white-sailed boats trooping through a long reach of one of the larger rivers. Such a sight is often seen to great advantage in the cold weather at Barisál, when boats of many shapes and districts come

sailing down under the north wind, and sweep past the town on their way to Bákarganj and other rice-marts. The traffic on the rivers is no doubt very large, but their tidal nature may sometimes make it appear greater than it really is. Boatmen are very gregarious in their habits, and like to keep near other boats as much as possible. This is partly from a desire for companionship, and partly is a reminiscence of the times when it was not safe to travel alone in Bákarganj on account of the dacoits; but independently of this, it is easy to see that if rivers are tidal, and boatmen have to trust chiefly to their oars and towing-ropes, the boats must keep a good deal together. Cargo-boats never row against the tide, and though they will tow against it, the river-banks are not always, or even generally, provided with towing-paths; so that unless there is a particular reason for hurry, they come to a halt with the turn of the tide. It is not always the same tide which is required throughout a single journey. Boat-travelling is very circuitous, and the tides run up and down the rivers and kháls in a very perplexing manner. Thus the journey from Barisál to Calcutta is far from being an ebb journey throughout. It is ebb as far as Jhalukátti, then flood, then ebb again; and there are one or two changes before the Baleshwar is reached and ascended with the flood. A boat arriving at a place where a change of tide is required, before the tide which has brought it has run out, moors or casts anchor, and thus gives time to other boats to come up. Hence the sight so frequently seen of a crowd of boats anchored at some turn of the stream. As soon as the required tide commences they set off together, and the river appears to be covered with boats; but if we were to return to the place in another hour, we

might perhaps not see a single boat. The river now appears deserted, and will remain so till a turn of the tide bring a fleet of boats from the opposite direction.

## II. CLIMATE.

The climate of Barisál, the headquarters of Bákarganj, and of most of the cultivated tracts, may be said to be good. The temperature is decidedly lower than that of most places in Bengal. In a report for 1871, the Civil Surgeon (Dr Bensley) writes as follows: "The climate of Barisál, though cool, is very relaxing, and recovery from any severe disease is extremely tedious, often necessitating a change. The past year (1871) has been remarkably cool; the average temperature during the three seasons was 67·835° in the cold season, 75·932° in the hot season, and 78·895° in the rainy season. The rainfall, as measured by the standard gauge, was 89·41, being 15·41 in excess of the previous year. The prevailing winds are south-west and north-west—the former about eight months of the year; it is generally cool and refreshing.[1] Barisál, being about fifty miles from the bay, and having a large river, the wind is thereby further cooled and purified before reaching the town. Our north-west is not similarly protected, and during the prevailing winds from that quarter, the town suffers considerably from malarious diseases." The months of March, April, and May, which are usually so hot in Calcutta and in Western Bengal, are comparatively cool in this district. The rains commonly set in about the middle of June, and continue

[1] It is observable that the breeze generally comes in with the tide, and dies away with the ebb.

into October. The worst time of the year, and also the hottest, is the period between the rains and the setting in of the cold weather. The sun is exceedingly powerful in the month of October, and even up to the middle of November. Perhaps the most disagreeable period of the whole year is that from the 15th of October to the 15th of November. This is the time of sudden changes of temperature—*sardi garmi* (cold and hot), as the natives call it—and the result is a large amount of fever. The dampness and steaminess of the climate also make themselves felt most at this time. An officer (Mr Wintle) describing to Government, in 1801, the climate of the station of Bákarganj, writes, "The atmosphere depresses the spirits in such a manner as to cause a sensation as if a person was only half alive." The cold weather is pleasant, but it is not so bracing as that of the more northern districts, and does not last more than four months. It is said that the proximity of Bákarganj to the sea prevents its climate from ever being very cold. The general complaint against it is of its dampness. This depresses vitality, and is also most injurious to furniture, books, &c. It is impossible to keep a house dry unless it is built on arches. Many of the native government officials and professional men, and even many of the traders, belong to other districts, especially to Dacca. They complain of the salt air (*lona howa*) of Bákarganj, and say that it gives them fever and indigestion. The healthiest place in the district used to be Mádaripúr, and police constables and others used to be transferred there when in bad health. Mádaripúr is now in Faridpúr, and probably the most healthy parts of the present district are the portions of Gournadi thana which face the Arial Khan, and the islands in the estuary of the Meghna. Dakhin Shah-

bázpúr and its chief town, Daulat Khan, seem to be healthy, except when, as happened in May 1869, a cyclone passes over the island and destroys the tanks. Cholera is endemic in the district, usually occurring in the beginning of November, and again in April and May; for several years, however, it has not been very severe. Fever and dysentery appear to be the most deadly diseases. Dyspepsia, spleen, and rheumatism are common. As a remedy for rheumatism many of the inhabitants are in the habit of keeping an open issue (seton) in the arm or leg. Dyspepsia often assumes the form called *pítshul*. Dysentery and diarrhœa prevail throughout the year, the mortality being greatest at the termination of the rains, and during the cold season. During September and October a slight scorbutic tendency is often observed, owing to the absence of sufficient fresh vegetables, the country being at the time more or less under water (*vide* Bensley's Report for 1871). Cutaneous diseases—ringworm, itch, &c.—are very common. The first is seen especially among boatmen and others who work in water, the soles of their feet being often drilled with holes like a sponge.

In 1860 there was a great mortality from fever in the islands of Kali, Kázal, &c., and in 1869 there was a similar but more widely-spread epidemic of fever in Dakhin Shahbázpúr. It is noteworthy that the Barisál jail has always been unhealthy. The same was true of the old jail at Bákarganj, and Mr Wintle writes (7th September 1801) that 242 prisoners had died within the past twelve months.

The only meteorological observations made in the district are those of the rainfall. There are four rain-gauges—viz., one at Barisál, and one at each of the three

subdivisional stations. The following table shows the rainfall for three years :—

| Jan. 1 to Dec. 31. | Barisál. | Peroz-púr. | Daulat Khan. | Patuyakháli. |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Inches. | Inches. | Inches. | Inches. |
| 1871 | 93·04 | 92·45 | 113·26 | No observation. |
| 1872 | 82·14 | 62·53 | 81·49 | 90·73 [1] |
| 1873 | 61·71 | 57·18 | 101·08 | 91·73 |

In connection with the subject of climate it is necessary to notice the curious phenomenon called the Barisál guns. This is a sound, resembling the discharge of cannon, which is heard in Bákarganj and part of Dacca, Farídpúr, and Jessore at the beginning of the rains—that is, in May and June. At Barisál the sound comes from the south and south-west, and is generally heard in a south wind and before rain. It is sometimes heard only for a minute or two; sometimes it continues for one or two hours, at intervals of two or three minutes between each discharge. It seems to be heard usually in the evening and at night, but perhaps this is only because the attention is more drawn to it when there are fewer other noises. It has been supposed by some that the sounds are merely those of guns fired at marriages; by others, that they are caused by the falling in of the river-banks. But they are heard away to the south, among the Sundarbans, where there are no marriages, and where there are no high river-banks to fall in. They are heard down at Kúkri Múkri, the most southerly island in the district, and the Mugs there assured me that they are distinct from the noise of the breakers or of the tide coming in. The natives

[1] From the 13th of May 1872.

poetically account for the sound by saying that it is caused by the opening and shutting of Ravan's gates in the island of Lanka (Ceylon). This fiction is valuable, in so far as it shows that the sound generally comes from the south. The Mahomedans say that it is caused by the firing of cannon to announce the approach of their Imam. It is not altogether impossible that it originates in that curious submarine depression in front of Jessore and Bákarganj, which is known by the name of the Swatch of No Ground.[1]

### III. CYCLONES.

The most destructive hurricane which has ever occurred in the district of Bákarganj was that which began on the 6th of June 1822, and lasted till the 9th idem. (For an account of its ravages see Chapter XIII.) On the 1st of November 1867 there was a cyclone which injured the crops in the eastern part of the district, especially in the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, then under Noakháli. The next cyclone occurred on the 16th of May 1869. It did much damage to the roads and villages generally, and carried away the station road on the east side of Barisál. Many cattle were drowned, and the *owsh* crop was injured. The cyclone was followed on the 8th, 9th, and 10th of the next month by an inundation, which did great damage in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, as it destroyed most of the fresh-water tanks. In consequence, probably, of the scarcity of

[1] Vol. liii. of the Philosophical Transactions for 1763 contains two interesting accounts of the Chittagong earthquake of 2d April 1762. In that given by Mr Gulston is mentioned the curious circumstance that "at the time of the first shake great explosions were heard like the noise of cannons, of which Mr Plaisted and others counted fifteen."

good drinking water, an epidemic of fever broke out in the island, which is said to have decimated the population.

### IV. TIDES.

The subject of the tides in the Meghna is very interesting, but I am not competent to discuss it, and can only state a few facts concerning it. There are two tides in its estuary, which are known by the names of the Chittagong and the Daula tides. The Chittagong tide passes up between Sandwip and the Chittagong coast, turns west, round the north of Sandwip, and then flows south along the east coast of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. It meets the Daula tide about half-way down the latter island, overpowers it, and drives it back. The Daula tide flows up between Dakhin Shahbázpúr and Hattia, coming in about three-quarters of an hour before the Chittagong tide. Its waters are comparatively fresh, so that inundations by it are much less dreaded by the peasantry than those of the Chittagong tide. The bore occurs at new and full moon. It is only felt in shallow water, where it rushes up in a white wall, said to be twenty or thirty feet in height. Boatmen do not like to put out on the days of the bore, and especially object to setting out with the ebb, lest they should ground on a char, and there be overtaken by it. It is called the *bán*, also the *shar*, both words, in Bengali, signifying arrow.

### V. RIVERS.

The rivers of Bákarganj are very numerous, but all draw their waters, directly or indirectly, from the Ganges or the Meghna. Three great rivers flow through or past

the district in a southerly direction—viz., the Meghna, the Arial Khan, and the Baleshwar.

1. The Meghna flows down the east side of Bákarganj, and opens out into an estuary at the head of the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. At the north-east boundary of the district, the Meghna many years ago broke through to the westward by an opening called the Naya Bhangni or New Opening. Tradition says that the new channel was formed in a single night. It is not known in what year this took place, but it must have been less than a century ago, for the passage is not marked in Rennel's map. In a report by Babu Dinu Bandhu Maulik, a Deputy-Collector, it is stated that the channel was formed in B.S. 1200 (A.D. 1793). It is also called the Harinathpúr river, and is the channel south of Haturia.[1] In successive parts of its course the Meghna is called the Satbaria, the Ilsa (*i.e.*, Hilsa), and the Títulia.[2]

2. The Arial Khan is a branch of the Ganges or Padma. It enters the district east of Palardi (the site of the Gournadi police station), and pursues a south-easterly course till it joins the estuary of the Meghna, by the Máskátta and Kalinga channels. In the lower part of its course it is called the Dakaitia and the Jahapúr river. An offshoot from the Arial Khan flows past Barisál, and is therefore called the Barisál river.

[1] The name Naya Bhangni is not given to the Muladi river, although it is marked as such in the survey map.

[2] Wilford, Asiatic Researches, vol. xiv., says that the Meghna is the Magone of Megasthenes as cited by Arrian, and mentioned as one of the rivers which fell into the Ganges. It is the Meghanád or Meghabahana of Sanskrit writers, and derives its name from *megha*, a cloud, in allusion to the obscurity of its origin. This is in contradistinction to the Bráhmaputra, whose existence of course is accounted for by his being the son of Bráhma.

3. The Baleshwar is formed by the junction of the Madhamati and the Saldaha. It flows past the west side of Bákarganj, is joined, at some distance below Perozpúr, by the Kacha, and enters the sea under the name of the Haringháttá.

There is considerable difficulty in enumerating the Bákarganj rivers, on account of their frequent change of name. At every ten miles of its course, or at an even less interval, the name of a river is generally changed. The names, too, are commonly insignificant, and are merely those of the principal bazárs or villages on the bank. Thus we have the Barisál river, the Nalchiti river, and the Bákarganj river. This frequent change of name is common enough throughout East Bengal, but it is especially marked in Bákarganj, probably because there are more rivers in it than in any other district, and because its rivers have less appearance of continuity—are, in short, less like rivers than those of districts farther from the sea. In many places the so-called rivers are rather marine creeks or arms of the sea. All of them are tidal, and it is only in the height of the rains that their waters do not turn with the tide. In March and April the waters of most of the rivers south of Barisál are salt, or at least brackish.

After the three already mentioned, the following are the principal rivers of Bákarganj :—

4. The Barisál river flows west by Nalchiti and Jhalukátti. Part of its waters then go down by the Dhánsiddhi into the Kaukháli and Kacha rivers. Another part flows into the Bishkháli. About three miles below Barisál a branch of the Barisál river flows southward by Ranihát and Bákarganj, under the name of the Khairábád river.

5. The Pándab, in the east of Bákarganj thana.

6. The Kárkhána, in Bákarganj and Baufal.

7. The Dhulia, in the north of Baufal thana.

8. The Khairábád. (See No. 4.)

9. The Nohalia, in Bákarganj and the Patuyakháli subdivision. In the lower part of its course it is commonly called the Galachipa, on account of its flowing past the Galachipa bazár and thana.

10. The Bishkháli is a very large river, flowing past Niamati and Kala Megha, east of and parallel to the Baleshwar and Haringháttá.

11. The Bighai is in Mirzaganj and Gúlsakháli, and is probably the widest river in the district.

12. The Andarmanick, a large and wide river in the Gúlsakháli thana.

13. The Barishar, which may be considered a continuation of the Bighai.

14. The Kacha is formed partly by the Kaukháli river and partly by the Káliganga, which issues from the swamps of the Kotwalipara and Sarupkátti thanas. It is a very deep river, and joins the Baleshwar below Perozpúr.

15. The Sápleza (snake's tail), in Matbária thana, the Agunmúkha, the Kázal, between the island of Kázal and the mainland, the Dárchíra (destroyer of oars), between Big and Little Baisdia, and several others, are rather arms of the sea than rivers.

Nearly all the above-named rivers have a southerly course. The cross-rivers which connect them, and which generally flow in an easterly or westerly direction, are commonly called *dōnes*. The word *dōn* is applied rather loosely, but it generally means a channel which is larger than a khál, but not sufficiently wide or long to deserve the name of river. It is also distinguished from a khál or river by the fact of its having no source, pro-

perly so called. It generally has two mouths, one at each end of its course, and both may be equally large. Perhaps this characteristic may be the origin of the name dōn, which seems to have its root in the Bengali word for *two*.

The following are the principal dōnes :—

*a*. The Bishkháli, which connects the Bishkháli river (at Niamati) and the Khairábád river (near Kótarhát).

*b*. The Amua dōn, in Matbária thana, connects the Bishkháli and the Baleshwar rivers.

*c*. The Muradia dōn begins at Kadamtolli Hát, in the Bákarganj thana, and joins the Nohalia, north-east of Patuyakháli. It is the chord to a loop of the Nohalia.

*d*. The Damuda connects the Kacha and the Baleshwar, and is on the steamer route from Calcutta to Barisál.

*e*. The Patuyakháli, between the Nohalia and the Bighai.

*f*. The Aila, and its continuation, the Khák dōn, are deep and wide, and connect the Bighai and the Bishkháli rivers.

*g*. The Bagi, between the Andarmanick and the Aila rivers.

*h*. The Gajalia, between the Bishkháli and the Kaukháli. It is the usual steamer route, being preferred now to the Dhánsiddhi.

*i*. The Kalijiri is sometimes called a river. In the upper part of its course it is called the Sugandha, or the Fragrant, in allusion to the tradition that when the goddess Kali was cut in pieces her nose fell into it.

It would be an endless task to enumerate all the kháls of Bákarganj. Many of them exist only during the rains, when every village has its khál, and often two or three. The following are the most important, not

on account of their size or length, but for their usefulness :—

(1.) The Jóbkháli khál, on the Barisál river.

(2.) The Jhalukátti khál, on the same river. These two kháls are important on account of their shortening the distance to Calcutta. The Jhalukátti was widened and deepened by the Public Works Department some years ago, at a cost of 11,000 or 12,000 rupees.

(3.) The Lakutia khál flows through the town of Barisál, where it is generally called the Jail khál. It is about six miles long, and shortens the journey to Dacca and the north of the district. It was originally made in a great measure by the liberality of the Lakutia zamindar, Babu Raj Chandra Rai. The Road Committee has since spent several thousand rupees in deepening it.

(4.) The Agarpúr khál.
(5.) The Shikarpúr khál.
(6.) The Turki khál.
} These three are in the north of the district.

(7.) The Srimantapúr khál, also called the Sibpúr khál, flows past Bákarganj and Sibpúr.

(8.) The Rajar Ber, at Rahamatpúr, so called because of a tradition that the Rajah of Chandradwip had it cut as a moat to his palace at Madhabpásha.

(9.) The Bhola khál, in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, extends across the island, and has been widened and deepened at a considerable expense.

Many of the kháls and dōnes have a double tide—that is, the tide flows in from each end and meets in the centre. This makes them apt to silt up. All the rivers and kháls wear away their banks, and often do much damage to the adjacent lands; but the most destructive in this respect are the Arial Khan and the Meghna. They often change their course, and carry away great tracts of country. It is true that they

restore the land farther down; but this seldom compensates the proprietor, especially as the new formations remain for many years as barren sandbanks. At the present time the Ilsa — *i.e.*, the Meghna—is cutting away its west bank very rapidly in thana Mendiganj, and the estuary of the Meghna is doing the same with the east side of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. The Arial Khan has for many years been diluviating its east bank, and throwing up large chars at Kalkini and Gournadi. The old village of Gournadi, which was the seat of a police station, has been altogether washed away, and the station is now at Palardi. New chars have, however, now formed on part of the old site of Gournadi village and east of Palardi. Close to the Palardi police station there is a curious mark of the changes which have taken place. This is the abutment of an old bridge, which must have been made at a time when there was much country to the east of the police station. The river came and swept away the country to the eastward and the bridge which at that time spanned a narrow khál. Palardi char has now formed opposite to the remains of the bridge, and the passage has become a khál once more. Three or four years ago the Arial Khan cut across the long neck of land at Kewaria, east of Palardi, and the appearance of the country is now in consequence very different from that represented in the survey map. There is something very desolate in the appearance of the country near these large rivers, when the force of the stream begins to be directed against any particular tract. The peasants make haste to remove their houses, and to cut down their groves of betel and cocoa nut trees; as the diluviation advances, nothing is to be seen near the bank but stumps of trees, the earthen foundations

of houses, and the broken walls of tanks. The irruption of the Meghna into the tanks is perhaps the most melancholy of such sights; for Dakhin Shahbázpúr and Hattia have many large tanks, which must have been constructed at much expense and labour. They are surrounded by high walls of earth in order to keep out the salt water, and when a breach is made in them they become useless, and whole villages suffer in consequence. When the peasants are thus driven away by the rivers, they sometimes merely move farther inland; but when they cannot get fresh land there, they are obliged to go to new chars, or to distant parts of the country. They are sometimes expressively called *nadi-bhanga lôk—i.e.*, river-broken people.

Generally it may be remarked of Bákarganj rivers, that they are deep on one side and shallow on the other. It also seldom occurs that they have high banks on both sides. The most common case is that one bank is high and wooded, and the opposite bank low and sandy. The high bank is always the one which the river is cutting away, but it does not always remain on the same side of the river. On the contrary, the general appearance is a high bank on, say, the right side, and a char on the left; then in the reach lower down a high bank on the left side, and a char on the right. The high bank of a river is commonly higher than the country farther inland, hence these river-banks are often useful as roads and towing-paths. They are also frequently the sites of villages, and are used for the cultivation of crops which require high land, such as sugar-cane, pán, betel-nut, &c. The volume of water brought down by the Ganges and Meghna must be very great; perhaps nothing can give

a clearer idea of this than the fact that in October, and even, I believe, up to December, the water surrounding Kúkri Múkri is perfectly fresh. A reference to the map will show that this island is almost in the Bay of Bengal.[1]

## VI. LAKES AND SWAMPS.

During the rains most of the country is a swamp, and the rice-fields do not dry up till January or February. There are also extensive depressions, in which the water remains all the year round, and which are generally known by the name of *bíls*. Of these, the principal are the Jhanjhania bíl, in Gournadi and Sarupkátti; Rampúr Cheehari bíl, in Matbária; and Dharandi, Adampúr, and Kala Rajah bíls, in thana Baufal. The Kotwalipara bíls have for the most part been transferred to Faridpúr. The large bíls yield fish in considerable quantity, and there is some export trade in this article from the Sarupkátti and Kotwalipara bíls to Calcutta. They are also valuable for the large quantities of reeds they produce, which are extensively used in making mats, and are also exported. The Kala Rajah bíl is supposed to derive its name from one of the Chandradwip Rajahs.

Small bíls are common all over the district, there being one in almost every large village. They are valu-

[1] In speaking of the amount of soil brought down by the Ganges, Lyell remarks that "it is scarcely possible to present any picture to the mind which will convey an adequate conception of the mighty scale of this operation, so tranquilly and almost insensibly carried on by the Ganges. It may, however, be stated that if a fleet of about 2000 ships, each freighted with 1400 tons of mud, were to sail down the river every hour of every day and night for four months continuously, they would only transport to the sea a mass of solid matter equal to that borne down by the Ganges in the four months of the flood season."—*Principles of Geology*, p. 282.

able from their yielding reeds and cattle-grass, and also because they afford convenient ground for the herding of buffaloes. Shells abound in the bíls, and in many places are collected and converted into lime.

The name Sundarbunds, or more correctly, Sundarban, is said to derive its origin from the sundari-tree (*Heritiera minor*), and this again is said to be called *sundari*, or the beautiful, on account of the red colour of its wood. Probably this etymology of the word "Sundarban" is correct; but it is a singular fact that the sundari-tree is by no means common in many parts of the Bákarganj Sundarbans. Thus, in the island of Kúkri Múkri, which is covered with tree-jungle, there is apparently not a single tree of sundari; and in the neighbouring island of Chopa I was able to find two or three trees only, and these very young.[1] The prevailing tree in these and other chars is that called the *kerua*. In the neighbourhood of Chapli, also, the sundari is not so common as the *goma* and other trees. The Mugs, however, who live there, account for its comparative scarcity by the greater demand for it in the market. The area now covered by the Sundarbans is much less than it was in former years, and cultivation is still advancing. Many tracts—such as Ramna-Bamna, Aila, and Tushkháli—have been reclaimed, and now bear luxuriant crops of rice. Even now, however, there are extensive forests along the southern face of the Bákarganj mainland. The aspect of these forest-tracts is by no means cheerful. The woods are dark and silent; the trees are seldom tall

[1] The name may possibly be connected with Sundarkúl, which was the old name of a tract of country in Bákarganj. It may thus mean "the forest of the river Sunda;" or the word may, after all, be Sundarbund, and mean "the embankment of the Sunda."

enough to be handsome; and the rivers and creeks are sullen and muddy, and suggestive of fevers and alligators.[1]

[1] An interesting article on the physical characteristics of Bákarganj was published by Mr Pellew in the "Calcutta Review," and I have taken the liberty of transferring a long extract from it to my Appendix. This extract refers to the drainage system of Bákarganj. I do not feel competent to discuss the subject, but I am sure that whether Mr Pellew's views are correct or not, his remarks are worth reading.

## CHAPTER III.

### *ANTIQUITIES AND EARLY HISTORY.*

THERE is not much to be said about the antiquities or the early history of Bákarganj. It has always lain remote from the stream of Indian history, and has been happy in having no annals.

According to one tradition, much of the present district was formerly the bed of a large river, called the Sugandha or Fragrant. This river threw up chars or alluvial formations on either side, the lands on the east receiving the names of Bákla and Bákla-Chandradwip, and those on the west the name of Selímábád. The name Sugandha is still preserved under the shortened form of Sunda, in the name Sundarkúl—*i.e.*, bank of the Sunda—which is applied to a village in the neighbourhood of Nalchiti.

It is certain that the general name for much of the present district was Bákla, and that the territory was ruled over by a Hindu family. This family was one of the twelve *bhuyas* or rulers of Bengal, who were also poetically known as the twelve suns of Bengal. Its members are generally known by the name of Rajahs of Chandradwip, and their history has been given by me under that *pargana.*

Bákla is mentioned by the traveller Ralph Fitch, who visited it in 1586. He says, "From Chatigam, in Bengala, I came to Bacola, the king whereof is a Gentile

[*i.e.*, Hindu], a man very well disposed, and delighteth much to shoot in a gun. His country is very great and fruitful, and hath store of rice, much cotton cloth, and cloth of silk. The houses be very fair and high builded, the streets large, the people naked except a little cloth about their waist. The women wear great store of silver hoops about their necks and arms, and their legs are ringed about with silver and copper, and rings made of elephants' teeth."—*Quoted by Blochmann.*

This Bacola has entirely disappeared, and it is only a conjecture which identifies it with Kachua, the ancient seat of the Chandradwip Rajahs. Fitch does not mention how he came to it from Chatigam—*i.e.*, Chittagong—nor is there any local tradition of there ever having been a town called Bacola or Bákla. If a town so large and flourishing as that described by Fitch ever existed in Bákarganj, it must have been washed away by the Meghna very many years ago. Bákla was famous amongst the Hindus as the seat of a school of pandits, who it is said ranked higher than those of Nuddea. Mr Taylor, in his history of Dacca, speaks of an astrological almanac which used to be drawn up by the Bákla pandits. There are still several pandits at Nalchira, in Gournadi.

In the "Ain i Akbari" (Gladwin's translation) there is the following notice of Bákla: "Sarkár Bákla is upon the banks of the sea; the fort is situated among trees. On the first day of the moon the water begins to rise, and continues increasing till the 14th, from which time to the end of the month it decreases gradually every day. In the twenty-ninth year of the present reign, one afternoon at three o'clock, there was a terrible inundation which deluged the whole *sarkár*. The Rajah was at an entertainment, from which he embarked in

a boat; his son, Pannanand Roy, with many people climbed to the top of a Hindoo temple, and the merchants betook themselves to the highlands. It blew a hurricane, with thunder and lightning, for five hours, during which time the sea was greatly agitated. The houses and boats were swallowed up, nothing remaining but the Hindoo temple on the height. Near 200,000 living creatures perished in this calamity."

This inundation appears to have taken place in 1583 or 1584, and it is a very extraordinary circumstance, that Fitch, who visited the place two or three years afterwards, says nothing about it.[1]

We should have expected that such a catastrophe would have left, for many years, conspicuous marks of its occurrence, and that the country would not after so short an interval have worn an aspect of richness and prosperity.

The next reference to Bákla occurs in the letters of Nicholas Pimenta, who was a Jesuit priest stationed at Goa, at the close of the nineteenth century. These letters are referred to in "Purchas's Pilgrimage" (London, 1625), book v. p. 513, and the name Bacola occurs there; but for fuller information it is necessary to consult the original work. Pimenta's letters were written from Goa in the year 1600, to Claude Aquaviva, who was then general of the Jesuit Order. There is, properly speaking, only one letter, but it is a comprehensive one, describing the success of the mission, and containing

[1] Professor Blochmann (Asiatic Society's Journal for December 1868) gives a somewhat different translation of this passage. He says the merchants got upon a *tálar* (not highlands), and explains that a tálar is a wooden house built on four pillars, and used by musicians as an orchestra —a *naub at-khana*, in fact. He gives 1585 as the date of the inundation—*i.e.*, only one year before Fitch's visit. I have recurred to this subject in the chapter on the Sundarbans.

extracts from the letters of the missionaries. In fact, it is a missionary report. The letter was originally published in Italian at Venice, and was reprinted at Constance in 1603. It was then translated into Latin, and published at Mayence. The title of this edition is as follows: "De felici statu et progressu rei Christianæ in India Orientali Epistola R. P. Nicolai Pimentæ Societatis Jesu ibidem visitatoris ad admodum R. P. Claudium Aquavivam ejusdem Societatis Jesu Præpositum Generalem, Calendis Decembri anno MDC. data."

Pimenta commences by giving a short sketch of the history of Bengal, and states that the government of it was at that time in the hands of twelve princes who had formed a secret league among themselves, and had got the better of the Moghals. He adds that the most powerful of the twelve were the lords of Sripúr and Chandecan, but above all the Maafaddin or Masanddin (?). Perhaps this is Ísá Khan Masnad i Ali of Khizrpúr, described by Dr Wise as the most celebrated of the twelve bhuyas. Nine of the twelve, says Pimenta, are Mahomedans, and this circumstance very much retards the work of conversion.[1] He then goes on to describe the success attained by the missionaries who were sent into Bengal in 1598 and 1599.

These missionaries were Francis Fernandez, Dominic da Sosa, Melchior da Fonseca, and Andrew Bowes. The first two left Cochin for Bengal on 3d May 1598, and the other two in the following year. Fernandez appears to have been the chief of the four, and he wrote to Pimenta from Sripúr on the 22d December 1599,[2] giving an account of the proceedings of himself and his comrades. They appear to have sailed first from Cochin to

[1] According to Du Jarric, the three Hindu princes were those of Sripúr, Chandecan, and Bacalu.

[2] There is also a letter from him, dated Sripúr, 16th February 1599.

Chittagong, or Porto Grande, as the Portuguese called it, and then to have gone on to Dianga. Fernandez writes as follows: "Shortly after our arrival at Dianga, Melchior de Fonseca departed for Ciandeca, in accordance with the instructions of your Reverence, and while he was travelling through Bacola, the Portuguese who lived there, and also the other Christians, being inflamed with a desire to obtain a priest from whom they might receive the sacrament (for whole years pass away without ever one priest coming), took care that he should be brought before the King. The latter received the father gladly, and honourably entreated him, and even gave him a letter of authority (*literæ patentes*), which I here subjoin.

"'Ego Rex Bacolæ potestatem facio Societatis Jesu patribus hactenus in regna Bengalæ admissis et aliis quotquot veniant ecclesias erigendi in ditione mea universa et annunciandi veri Dei legem omnesque ad Christum quotquot potuerint trahendi citra fortunarum, officiorum, vel dignitatum quas gerunt detrimentum. Immo omnem honorem, favorem, et benevolentiam deferem illis tanquam subditis, mandaboque omnibus Præfectis et Dominis ut cum omnibus novellis Christianis idem faciant; et si quando ex patribus cognovero quempiam huic meo mandato non obsecundasse severe sciat se mulctandum.'"

On 20th January 1600, Melchior Fonseca wrote himself from Ciandeca, and gave an account of his success. He says that he left Chittagong in the month of October, and that he passed through the kingdom of Bacola at the request of the Commander (Il Capitano) and the other Portuguese, who for two years had been without any administration of the holy sacraments: "And it appeared to be by the disposition of our Lord that

when I was about to go to Arracan in the place of Fernandez, who was ill with fever, I too should fall ill, and should be transferred to Ciandeca; so that in this journey the Company gained a residency in the kingdom of Bacola. I had scarcely arrived there, when the King (who is not more than eight years old, but whose discretion surpasses his age) sent for me, and wished the Portuguese to come with me. On entering the hall, where he was waiting for me, all the nobles and captains rose up, and I, a poor priest, was made by the King to sit down in a rich seat opposite to him. After compliments, he asked me where I was going, and I replied that I was going to the King of Ciandeca, who is 'the future father-in-law of your Highness;' but that as it had pleased the Lord that I should pass through his kingdom, it had appeared right to me to come and visit him and offer him the services of the fathers of the Company, trusting that his Highness would give permission to the erection of churches and the making of Christians. The King said, 'I desire this myself, because I have heard so much of your good qualities,' and so he gave me a letter of authority, and also assigned a maintenance sufficient for two of us."

Fonseca then told the Portuguese that Fernandez would soon come to receive their confessions, and that in the month of May fathers would be sent to commence a residence. Fonseca goes on to give a description of the route from Bacola to Ciandeca, which I give in the original Italian: "Il viaggio di Bacolà sin a Ciandecan è il più fresco, delitioso ch' io mai vedessi, per i varii fiumi con alberi alle rive ch' irrigano il paese, e per vedersi da una parte correre numerose schiave di cervi, per l' altra pascere moltitudine di vacchi; lascio le campagni spatiose di riso, e li molti canneti de canne

mele, gli sciami d' api per gli alberi, e li simi andar saltando da uno albero al' altro e altri particolarita di grande ricreationi a viandanti. Non mancono però tigri e crocodili che si pascono di carne humana per transcuragine e peri peccati d' alcuni. Sono ancora per quelle silve rinoceroti ma io non ne hò visto verruno."

This description of Bákarganj and the Sundarbans is interesting, both on account of its liveliness and because it makes it not so improbable after all that the word "Sundarban" may really mean beautiful wood, and may have been applied in this sense to the forests by the Bráhmans. For if a poor Roman Catholic priest could see the beauty of these woods in spite of the tigers and crocodiles, why might not a Bráhman priest do so also ?

Fonseca arrived at Ciandeca on the 20th November 1599, and was there received by Father Sosa and others. Sosa's being there is explained by Fernandez, who says that after he returned to Sripúr (from a visit which he seems to have paid to Ciandeca) he found that the regulus in Ciandeca, called Rajah, was displeased because they did not return to him, and so to pacify him it was necessary to send Dominic Sosa to him. A passage descriptive of Fernandez' proceedings at Sripúr may be here quoted: "I held discourses with the people every Sunday, and also on festival days, after the manner of the Goa College, and this thing being new in Bengal, wonderfully attracted everybody. Little, however, was done towards conversion, from the fault of the people, and also from my ignorance of the language."

Fernandez, in describing Fonseca's success at Bacola, adds that he had wished to visit Bacola before the departure of the Indian fleet, and to obtain more accurate and personal information which he might send to Pimenta. He had, however, been prevented by his

having had to wait for a reply from the King of Arracan. He then says that he had now heard of Fonseca's arrival at Ciandeca, and that he had been received with much honour and kindness by the King and people, and that he had a church in which mass could be celebrated. This was the first church of the Company in Bengal, and was on that account called by the holy name of Jesus. "It now remains that the necessary workmen be obtained, and that so noble a vineyard may be fervently commended to the Lord."

From the work of Pierre du Jarric,[1] who was also a Jesuit, and who wrote a book entitled "Histoire des Choses plus memorables advenues tant aux Indes Orientales que autres Pays de la Decouverte des Portugais" (Bordeaux, 1608), we learn that Ciandeca was the first church in Bengal, Chittagong the second, and Bandel the third. He adds that the latter was built by Diego Mugnes de Villalobos, and that it was finer than that of Chittagong.

The favourable hopes entertained by Fernandez and his companions were doomed to be speedily disappointed, and the mission came to a melancholy end. War broke out, as Du Jarric tells us, between the Portuguese and the King of Arracan about the possession of Sandwip; and a tumult arose at Chittagong, where Fernandez then was. The immediate cause of this outbreak was a dispute about port dues. The Arracanese apparently took advantage of this tumult to try and carry off into slavery some children whom Fernandez

[1] Pierre du Jarric was born at Toulouse in 1565, and was for fifteen years professor of theology in that town. He died in 1616. His information was partly derived from a Spanish work written by one Felix da Guzman, and published at Alcala in 1601. Du Jarric's book, however, is the more valuable of the two, and contains nearly everything that is to be found in Pimenta, &c. It has been translated into Latin.

had under his instruction. Fernandez interfered on behalf of the children, and was severely beaten and blinded in one eye. He was then put in prison, and on the 14th November 1602 the poor old priest, says Du Jarric, "changed the miserable prison of this earth for a celestial mansion." Andrew Bowes buried him in the church, which was now in ruins. Bowes was in prison too, with chains on his legs and neck; and though his jailers took the chains off his legs, they retained that on his neck when they allowed him to bury Fernandez. What grieved Bowes most of all was to see the holy chalice in the possession of the Arracanese chief, and used by him as a spittoon. After Fernandez' death, the priests left Chittagong and took refuge in Sandwip; but they soon afterwards left that island, and with the other Christians dispersed themselves over Sripúr, Bacola, and Ciandeca. At Ciandeca, Carvalho, the commander of the Portuguese, was treacherously murdered by the Rajah, who hoped thereby to make his peace with the King of Arracan. This was the end of the Bengal Mission; for of the four fathers who remained, two were ordered off by their Superior to Pegu, and two returned to Cochin.

Du Jarric also tells us the fate of the boy-king of Bacola who had entertained Fonseca, and gives what is probably the true account of the downfall of the Chandradwip family. His words are: "The King of Arracan was proud of having taken the island of Sandwip from the Portuguese; and desiring now to pursue his design of conquering all the kingdoms of Bengal, he suddenly threw himself upon that of Bacola, of which he possessed himself without difficulty, as the King of it was absent and still young." I may add here, that,

according to Wilford, "the King of Arracan assumed the title of lord of the twelve *bhuniyas, bhatties,* or principalities of Bengal. The kings of Arracan and of Commillah," he says, "were constantly striving for the mastery, and the former even conquered the greatest part of Bengal. Hence to this day they assume the title of lord of the twelve bhuniyas, bhatties, or principalities of Bengal."— *Wilford, Ancient Geography of India,* vol. xiv. *of Asiatic Researches.*

Although the island of Sandwip does not belong to Bákarganj, yet its history is in some measure mixed up with that of Bákla, and I shall therefore state some facts about it which I have collected from Du Jarric and others. Sandwip is evidently a very old island, and seems to have been of more importance three hundred years ago than it is now, because it was one of the chief sources from which Bengal was supplied with salt. The first notice of it apparently is that given by Cæsar Frederick, a Venetian merchant, who stayed in it for more than a month. He commenced his travels in 1563, and after travelling in many parts of the East, left Pegu on his homeward journey in 1569. He went from Pegu to Chittagong, as small ships sailed thence for Cochin. On the way to Chittagong, in August 1569, his ship was caught in a typhoon. After having been tossed about for some days, an island was discovered at no great distance, on which they landed to see what land it was. "We found it a place inhabited, and, to my judgment, the fertilest island in all the world; the which is divided into two parts by a channel which passeth between it. With great trouble we brought our ship into the same channel, which parteth the island at flowing water." I have quoted this sentence on account of its giving some description of the configuration of the

island. Cæsar Frederick's description of the fertility of the island, &c., may be seen in Blochmann, p. 22. Du Jarric devotes a chapter (cap. 32 of book vi.) to a description of Sandwip. He tells us that it is opposite Sripúr, and that it supplies all Bengal with salt. The island belonged of right to Kedar Rai of Sripúr, but for several years he had not had possession of it, because the Mogores (Moghals) had taken it from him. However, in 1602, Carvalho, a Portuguese, and a native of Montargil, who was in the service of Kedar Rai, took possession of it. As, however, he was not strong enough to keep it, Emmanuel de Mattos came from Chittagong to help him, and then he and Carvalho divided the island between them. Afterwards Philippe de Brito built a fort on it. The King of Arracan was offended at these proceedings, consequently the Portuguese either left it, or were driven out by him.

Afterwards, however, Sebastian Gonzales, a Portuguese adventurer, landed on the island in 1018 H., or A.D. 1609, and took possession of it.

"This Sebastian Gonzales," says Stewart in his "History of Bengal," "became absolute sovereign of the island of Sandwip, and was obeyed by the natives and Portuguese as an independent prince. In the course of a short time his forces consisted of 1000 Portuguese, 2000 Indian soldiers, 200 cavalry, and 80 sail of vessels of various sizes, and well mounted with cannon; and as his government was conducted with equity, many merchants resorted to the island, and by their commerce contributed much to increase his revenue. The neighbouring chiefs, astonished at the prodigious success of Gonzales, sought his friendship, and deprecated his wrath; but as he was of a violent and covetous disposition, he listened not to their friendly overtures; and

although he was under great obligations to the Rajah of Batecala [a mistake for Bákla], who had first given refuge to the Portuguese in their distress, he ungratefully seized upon the lands of Shahbázpúr and Patelbanga [?], which belonged to that chief, by which means his territories became as extensive as those of some independent prince, and consisting entirely of islands, was secure from the attacks of any enemies so long as the Portuguese were masters of the sea."

Stewart derived his information chiefly from the work of Manuel de Faria y Sousa, called "Asia Portuguesa," and published at Lisbon in 1666. An English translation of this work was published in 1695 by Captain John Stevens, and appropriately dedicated to the Dowager Queen of England, Catharine of Braganza. I have gathered the following additional particulars from Faria y Sousa's work. "Sebastian Gonzales Tibao was," he says, "a man of obscure extraction, as born in the village of St Antony del Torzal, near Lisbon, a place which never yet produced any worth note either for parentage or worthy action. In the year 1605 he embarked for India, went on to Bengal, enlisted himself as a soldier, and then fell to dealing in salt, which is a great merchandise in these parts. Thus by this trade he soon got as much as purchased a *jalia*—that is, a sort of small vessel. In this vessel he went to Dianga, a great port of the kingdom of Arracan. . . . Tibao stipulated with the King of Bacola that he would give him half the revenue of the island of Sandwip if he assisted him to conquer it. The King sent some ships and 200 horse. Afterwards, however, instead of giving the King of Bacola half the revenue of the island, he made war upon him."

Faria y Sousa adds that Emmanuel de Mattos, commander of Bandel, had been lord of Sandwip, and that

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Fatteh Khan had held it for him, but that on Mattos's death Fatteh Khan had kept the island for himself.

In the end Gonzales was ruined, for after the unfortunate issue of a battle in 1615, "the King of Arracan fell on him in his island, took it, and reduced him to his former miserable condition. So his sovereignty passed like a shadow, his pride was humbled and his vileness punished." Such are the unsympathising remarks of the Portuguese historian about a man who at least possessed vigour and ability, and who owed his fall in great measure to the impetuosity of the Portuguese officer who was sent from Goa to assist him, but who was too proud or too rash to co-operate fully with him. The Viceroy was also to blame, for he directed his officer not to wait for Gonzales. We cannot but think that if Gonzales had been an Englishman, and his historian of the same nationality, we would have heard a great deal about Anglo-Saxon energy, the Berserker-spirit, and the Vikings.

Sandwip was finally taken by the Mahomedans from the Arracanese in 1666. I may here note that according to some the proper name of the island is Soma-dwipa—*i.e.*, island of the moon. Much information about the history of Sandwip will be found in the article on the Feringhies of Chittagong, "Calcutta Review," vol. liii. for 1871. See also article "Mofussil Records," in vol. liv. for 1872, of same Review, p. 216, for reference to an important petition by zamindars of Sandwip dated 1789.

In the Asiatic Society's Proceedings for January 1838 an account is given of a copperplate inscription found in the pargana of Idilpúr. The inscription records that three villages were given to a Bráhman in the third year of Keshab Sein—*i.e.*, 1136 A.D. These three villages cannot now be identified, and though it is possible enough that they have been long ago washed away by

the Meghna, which flows past Idilpúr pargana, it may also be that they never belonged to the district of Bákarganj. The fact of the inscription having been found in a Bákarganj pargana does not necessarily imply that the villages belonged to that neighbourhood, and there does not appear to be anything in the inscription to connect it with Idilpúr. Another copperplate inscription (*sásanam*) was found about three years ago near Mádaripúr, and has been presented to the Asiatic Society, but it has not at present been deciphered.

The only clear memorial of the ancient times of Bákarganj is a mosque in the Sundarbans, which bore an inscribed slab (now removed to the Asiatic Society's Museum) purporting that the building had been erected in 1465. This mosque is built of brick, and is situated in a place called Masjidbari, near a tributary of the Bighai, and a few miles west-north-west of Gúlsakháli police station. It thus lies in the Patuyakháli subdivision, and in the southern part of the district. It was discovered at the time of the Sundarban Resumptions, and was, when found, surrounded by jungle. Mr Reilly, who was the Commissioner of the Sundarbans, wrote[1] an account of the mosque, and a translation of the inscription was furnished by Colonel Lees. The translation is: "The Prophet of God (on whom be peace, &c.) said, 'Whoso buildeth a mosque, God shall build for him seventy palaces.' This mosque was built in the reign of the Sultan, the mighty pillar of the Church and State, Aboo-al-Mozaffar Barbek Shah, son of the Sultan Mahmood Shah, by Khan Moazzam Ozyal Khan, year of Hijira 870" (= A.D. 1465).

I visited this mosque in 1874, and found it in good preservation. It is, however, quite devoid of architec-

[1] A. S. J., vol. iv. of 1860, p. 406.

tural interest or beauty. The woods which once surrounded it have been cleared away, and it now lies in the midst of rice-fields. A faqir has assumed the charge of it, and is supported by the gifts of occasional visitors.

There is another old mosque in Sialghuni village, thana Bákarganj, which is said to have been built by one Nasrat Ghazi. It appears to have been at one time richly ornamented, and still has some carved flowers and arabesques. The inhabitants told me that there had once been an inscription, but that it had fallen down and disappeared. Near it there is a village called the Fílkhana or elephant stables, which would seem to indicate that elephants had once been kept in it. There is, however, no tradition to this effect. There are, as far as I am aware, only two other old mosques in the district, one is in the village of Bíbí Chini, near the Niamati outpost, and is said to have been built by a lady named Bíbí Chini, sister to the Niamat who founded the village of Niamati. The other is in the village of Ramsiddhi, thana Gournadi, and is said to have been built by Sabhi Khan. It is a much handsomer building than that in Bíbí Chini, and has four stone pillars. Two of the pillars are slender, and are said to have been worn away by devotees clasping them, in the hope of thereby obtaining fulfilment of their wishes.

Sujábád. — About five miles south-west of Barisál, and on the north bank of the Nalchiti river, there is a small village called Sujábád, which derives its name from Shah Suja, the ill-fated brother of Arangzeb. In it there are the remains of a fort, which appears to have been erected by Shah Suja when he was Viceroy

of Bengal, and had to defend the country against the incursions of the Mugs or Burmese. The fort was rectangular and surrounded by an earthen wall, with a mound at each corner. Inside were four small tanks separated by roads, and in the centre of the inner space, where the four roads met, was the prince's dwelling-house. A great part of the wall has fallen into the river, the tanks inside are nearly choked up and most of the space is covered with jungle. The whole village contains only 77 acres, and there is an interesting document in the Collectorate record-room showing that it was given rent free by Shah Suja to the families of some Afghans who had fallen in battle against the Mugs. It is further said that the fight lasted two days, and that Shah Suja's force was victorious. It is said that four forts were built, and this probably refers to the fortifications at each corner of the rectangular space. In 1845 it was proposed to resume the grant, and an *amín* went out to make a map of the locality, from which it appears that there was then more of the earthen wall standing than is now visible. The land was then in possession of the descendants of the Afghans, who succeeded in obtaining its release though they had lost the original grant or *sanad*, which they stated had been destroyed in the great inundation of 1822. None of them now reside on it, and their rights have passed by purchase into other hands. There is a tragical story told of Asman Singh, one of the last Afghan residents in Sujábád, which has been made the subject of a popular ballad. He had a wife who was unfaithful to him. News was brought to him, while away at Nalchiti, that his wife's paramour (a Mahomedan) was in his house. He armed himself with a sword, and rushed home to avenge himself. On pretext

of illness his wife delayed to open the door, and thereby gave her lover time to escape. At last Asman Singh burst open the door and aimed a blow at his wife, but she had her child in her arms, on whom the stroke fell, and who was killed. Asman Singh was tried for the murder, and having been found guilty, was hanged in chains on the river-bank, near the scene of his crime. The ballad adds that his brother in Calcutta succeeded in obtaining a pardon for him, and hurried with it to Barisál, but that he arrived just too late to stay the execution.

There are the remains of two forts in the Jhalukátti thana—viz., one at Rupashia, near Jhalukátti, and another at Indrapásha, near Rajapúr outpost. Nothing appears to be known of their history.

In Major Rennel's map,[1] made from surveys in 1764 and 1772, two mud forts are shown in the southern part of the district. They had been built to repel the Mugs. No trace of them now exists, but there is a village called Sónárkót, near Adampúr, in the Baufal thana, which stands near the site of one of them, and seems by its name to indicate that it was once a fort (the word *kót* often meaning a fort). There is also a place near it which still goes by the name of the Killaghátta, or landing-place of the fort.

The map above referred to, which has been reproduced by Colonel Gastrell in his statistical report, is an interesting record of the former state of the district.[2]

[1] Though the map generally bears the name of Rennel, it appears from Markham (Indian Surveys) that the credit of the Sundarban and sea-coast portion is chiefly due to Captain Ritchie, who was hydrographical surveyor from about 1770 to 1785. Ritchie's work is still in MS. in the India Office. The glory of making the first correct map of India seems due to the French, whose great geographer D'Anville preceded Rennel.

[2] Professor Blochmann has given a reduced copy of De Blaev's map.

An inspection of it shows that Barisál, the present headquarters, was already a place of note, and that a great part of the Sundarbans had been depopulated by the Mugs. At that time Bákarganj was the headquarters of the district, and a road led from it to Kótarhát and thence to Sitaluri, which is near the modern Jhalukátti. From Sitaluri it proceeded to Madhabpásha, and thence by Idrakpúr, in Gournadi, across the swamps to Maxadpúr. The tract of country called Sundarkúl is represented in this map.

The history of the Chandradwip Rajahs, and notices of the old buildings at Kachua and at Raikátti, will be given in the accounts of the Chandradwip and Selímábád parganas.

Aga Bákar.[1]—The district of Bákarganj derives its name from one Aga Bákar, who was a servant of the Nawab of Murshidábád, and was proprietor of pargana Buzurgumedpúr, and of 11½ anas of Selímábád. He apparently founded the mart of Bákarganj, which was situated in his zamindari of Buzurgumedpúr, and was formerly the headquarters of the district. He is said to have taken possession by force of the 11½ anas of Selímábád, and to have retained them until his death in 1160 B.S., when he was executed for rebellion (Thomp-

There is a very interesting old map by Van den Broucke in the fifth volume of François Valentyn's work (ed. 1724–26) which ought to be reprinted. Bacola is marked on it, but only as an island. There is a place marked as the "Hoek" or Cape of Sancraan, and from its position I think this must be Sangrám, which was an old Moghal fort in the Mendiganj thana (see Wintle's account in Appendix). Van den Broucke marks the whole of the Sundarban coast as unknown, and states that the "Ter Schelling" was wrecked in this neighbourhood. Sangrám Fort is referred to in the Alamgirnáma, quoted in article on the Feringhies of Chittagong, "Calcutta Review," vol. liii. p. 73. It was fortified in 1665.

[1] Bákar is an Arabic word, and the correct transliteration of it is Baqir; hence some write Báqirganj.

son to Board, 28th December 1793). (See account of Selímábád.)

Dr Taylor, in his "Topography of Dacca" (p. 83), has the following notice of Aga Bákar and his son: "Shamat Jung Nowazish Mahomed Khan, the nephew and son-in-law of Aliverdi Khan, was next invested with the government in succession to Sarferaz Khan. Like his predecessor, he resided at Murshidábád, and acted in the twofold capacity of Imperial Dewan and Deputy Nazim, appointments which he held for many years prior to the British conquest of the country. He employed as his deputy at Dacca, Hosein Addeen Khan, the nephew of Hosein Kuli Khan, his minister at Murshidábád. When Aliverdi Khan declared in favour of his adopted son Seraja Daulah as his successor to the Masnad, feuds arose between the heir-apparent and Shamat Jung, which ended in the assassination of Hosein Addeen Khan at Dacca, and that of his uncle at Murshidábád. Aga Sadoc, the son of a wealthy zamindar in the Bákarganj district, was employed by Seraja Daulah to carry his plans into effect at this place. This person, who had proceeded to Murshidábád to appeal against a decision of Hosein Addeen, instead of obtaining the redress he expected, was detained a prisoner there by Hosein Kuli Khan. He was soon induced, therefore, to listen to the proposals of Seraja Daulah. Effecting his escape from Murshidábád, he returned to Dacca, where his father Mahomed Bákar was now residing, and prevailing on him to join in the conspiracy on the promise of being made Nawab, the party contrived to get admission into the palace at dead of night, and murdered Hosein Addeen. When the assassination became known the following morning, the inhabitants of the town rose in a body and attacked

Mahomed Bákar and his son. The former, on being required to produce the sanad for his appointment to the Neabat, pointed to his sword, and was immediately killed, but Aga Sadoc, though severely wounded, contrived to escape."

The accounts of this affair in Mr Scrafton's "Reflections," and in the "Siyar al Mutakhereen," may also be inserted, as they contain one or two additional particulars. It will be seen that, according to Mr Scrafton, Aga Bákar held the office of governor of Chittagong: "The conduct of this affair was left to Surajah Doulah, who chose for his instrument one Aga Sadoc, whose father was governor of Chittagong, but resided at Dacca. The son, an extravagant, debauched youth, was then under confinement at Nowazis Mahomed Khan's palace, being left there as hostage till he paid a large sum due for the revenues of his government. Surajah Doulah assisted him to escape. He landed at Dacca the 1st of December 1755, and engaged his father in the enterprise, deluded probably by the promise of Surajah Doulah to make him governor of Dacca. The father and son, with twelve of their dependants, surprised the governor in the dead of night, and after some little resistance, in which the father was wounded, they cut off his head and proclaimed it to be done by the order of Surajah Doulah. But the next day an order arriving from Nowazis Mahomed Khan to seize Aga Sadoc, the great men of the city immediately assembled their forces and attacked him. The son, with some of his desperate followers, cut their way through their opponents and made their escape, but the father and the rest of their party were killed. This news reaching the capital, the different parties were immediately in arms; but the old Soubah assuring his nephew that Aga Sadoc had made

this attempt entirely in revenge for his confinement, the weak, timid Nowazis was appeased, and the consequence was that Surajah Doulah, a few days afterwards, murdered Hosein Kuli Khan in the street of Muxadabad."—*Scrafton's Reflections on the Government of Hindustan*, p. 49, London, 1763; reprinted 1770.

See also "Siyar al Mutakhereen," vol. ii. p. 646, Calcutta, 4th edition, 1789: "To ensure success to his [Surajah Daulah's] design he made use of some art to gain the heart of a young man, who, having had disputes with the officers of Hosein Kuli Khan, deputy-governor of the province of Dacca, had found means to lay his case before Nowazis Mohamed Khan, who concerned himself on his behalf. His name was Aga Sadoc, and his title Sadakut Mohamed Khan, son of Aga Bákar, a considerable zamindar of these parts. Surajah Daulah engaged him to return to Dacca in order to kill Hosein Addeen Khan, the nephew of Hosein Kuli Khan, and the latter's deputy at Dacca, a young man who for some reasons had fallen into a melancholy that had disordered his senses. The man did exactly as he was bid. Such a murder committed so openly struck terror and consternation into the minds of all the inhabitants of that great city, who concluded that an action of that high nature would never have been perpetrated had not some person of the first rank afforded it countenance, so that every one remained silent and thoughtful until it became known that the perpetrator had no order and no evidence in his hand. He was therefore set upon by the inhabitants and by the friends of Hosein Kuli Khan, who missed the murderer, but by mistake killed his father, Aga Bákar. The son having escaped so great a danger, fled to Murshidá-

bád, and by such a step [the assassination ?] threw away both his peace of mind and safety of his person."

There is a curious reference to an Aga Bákir in Paton's "Arracan," vol. xvi. of "Asiatic Researches." He says that in 1113 of the Mug era (1751 or thereby), Aga Bákir, the Dacca Nawab, having been worsted in a contest near Dacca by a chief named Umed, applied to the King of Arracan for assistance. He sent a Sardar named Laya Murari with one thousand war-boats to the assistance of the Nawab, and enabled him to gain the victory.

I do not know if this be our Aga Bákar or not, but if he is, there is some mistake in describing him as Nawab of Dacca. Our Aga Bákar was Governor of Chittagong, which of course renders his connection with the King of Arracan probable enough.

Besides Bákarganj bazár there is a small village, called Bákarkátti or the clearing of Bákar, near Kótarhát, which probably also owes its name to Aga Bákar.

It will be observed that most of the parganas bear Mahomedan names, showing that the country was not portioned out till the Mahomedan dynasty. The names are probably derived from the first grantees. Thus we have Sultanábád, Shaistábád, Selímábád, Shahbázpúr, &c. The Selímábád pargana is the largest and most important of these, and extends over a great portion of the Perozpúr subdivision, and also westwards into Baghahát in Jessore.

Probably Bákarganj and its neighbourhood were the first places where the Mahomedans settled, for it is hereabouts that we find most traces of them. Thus there is a large tank near Bákarganj called Boran Khan's Tank, and Niamati and Bíbí Chini are not far off. In the latter

there is the old mosque already noticed, which is chiefly remarkable for the height of the mound on which it is built.

There is also a mosque at Mendiganj, near Bákarganj, which bears an inscription purporting that it was built by one Mahomed Shuffee in 1161 B.S. (A.D. 1753.)

In the northern part of the district the most conspicuous name is Sabhi Khan, who has immortalised himself by the roads and bridges which he constructed. According to one account, he was a Kótwal, and Kotwalipara is said to derive its name from him. The following story is told to account for his beneficence. He was, it is said, the son of a wealthy merchant, but was stolen from his home during his infancy, and brought up in the forests. In course of time he grew up to man's estate and became a hunter. Meanwhile his father's house was attacked by enemies, who killed his father and drove his mother out into the jungles. There Sabhi Khan found her one day while he was hunting, and, in ignorance of their relationship, he took her as his wife. They lived together for awhile, but one morning the mother observed a spot on the sole of Sabhi Khan's foot, and knew thereby that he was her son. She told him the miserable discovery she had made, so Sabhi Khan went to a holy man, and asked him how he should expiate the terrible sin he had involuntarily committed. The answer was, that he should atone for it by doing works for the public good, and hence he set about making roads and building mosques. His roads traverse parts of the Gournadi and Kotwalipara thanas, and are still in use. They are known by the name of Sabhi Khan's *jangáls*. They have been obliterated in many places, but where they exist they are broad

and remarkably well raised. There is also a village called Sabhi Khan's Pár,[1] which owes its name to him. The word *pár* refers to the village being situated on the side of an old tank which is said to have been excavated by Sabhi Khan.

[1] It is commonly spelt Chobikapár.

# CHAPTER IV.

## *FINANCIAL HISTORY AND DESCRIPTION OF THE PARGANAS.*

### I. HISTORICAL SKETCH OF THE LAND SETTLEMENTS.

The materials for the early financial history of Bákarganj are very scanty. The following facts have been gleaned from Mr Grant's "Analysis of the Finances of Bengal," printed in Appendix No. 4 to the Fifth Report of the Committee of the House of Commons, 1812, and from Professor Blochmann's monograph. As has been already stated, the name Bákarganj is of comparatively recent origin, and it does not occur in Mr Grant's work. At the time of Rajah Todar Mal's Settlement in 1582, the greater part of the present district appears to have been included in the ancient zamindari or pargana of Chandradwip, which belonged to sarkár Bákla, also called Ismáilpúr. Bákla was one of the nineteen sarkárs into which the Khalsa or Exchequer lands of Bengal Proper were divided by Todar Mal, who was Finance Minister to the Emperor Akbar. Sarkár Bákla contained only four *mahals* or parganas, the names of which are given by Professor Blochmann as Ismáilpúr or Bákla, Srírámpúr, Shahzádpúr, and Adilpúr. The three last still exist, and I suppose that Bákla was identical with Chandradwip. This pargana is still occasionally called Bákla-Chandradwip. The following account of Bákla is taken from Mr Grant's work: "Bákla or Ismáilpúr, east-

ward of Khalífatábád, chiefly on the western bank of the Padma or great Ganges, and extending to its mouth near the island of Rabnábád, which forms the south-east angle of the Bengal delta, as also the further extremity of the lowlands of Bhatty, commencing on the west from Hidjili. Two years subsequent to the date of this account (1582), fixed for convenience at the commencement of Todar Mal's financial operations, though not completed before his death in 1589, the whole sarkár now described was overwhelmed and laid waste by an inundation, and from the succeeding ravages of the Mugs continues to this day in great part depopulated."

The revenue of the four parganas in it was Rs.178,266 (sicca).

The eastern portions of the district, including North and South Shahbázpúr, belonged to sarkár Fathábád. Selímábád, in the west of the district, part of which now belongs to Jessore, was also included in this sarkár. Buzurgumedpúr, another large pargana in Bákarganj, was probably formed at a later period. It was included in sarkár Bazuha.

In 1658 another Settlement of Bengal was made by Sultan Suja, one of the sons of Shah Jehan. In this Settlement the Sundarbans were included under the name of Muradkhana or Jeradkhana. Perhaps the village and river of Muradia, in the northern part of the Patuyakháli subdivision, are parts of this Muradkhana.

In 1722, or 1128 B.S., a third Settlement was made by Nawab Jaffar Khan in the reign of Mahomed Shah. On this occasion the old sarkárs were included in *chaklas*, and sarkár Bákla, and portions of sarkárs Fathábád and Bazuha were included in chakla Jehangirnagar—*i.e.*, Dacca. A few years before this—namely, in 1717—the

seat of Government had been removed from Dacca to Murshidábád.

Jaffar Khan's Settlement was improved and confirmed by his successor Suja Khan in 1728, or 1135 B.S. He divided the *suba* or province of Bengal into *ihtimams* or zamindaries, and the greater part of Dacca, Faridpúr, and Bákarganj appears to have been included in the ihtimam of Jalálpúr.

A fourth Settlement was made by Mir Kasim in 1763.[1]

The next Settlement of which we need take account is the Decennial or Permanent Settlement of A.D. 1790, or 1197 B.S. With regard to this Settlement the Fifth Report observes that "a medium of the actual produce to Government in former years, drawn from the scanty information which the collectors had the means of procuring, was the basis on which the assessment on each estate, whether large or small, was ultimately fixed."

The Permanent Settlement of the Bákarganj district was made during the collectorship of Mr William Douglas, who was then Collector of Dacca. At that time the Dacca Collectorate was called Dacca Jalálpúr.[2]

[1] From Warren Hastings' letter of 23d November 1773, about Provincial Councils, &c., printed in Judicial Papers, 1774, India Office Library, we find that Dacca, which then included Bákarganj and Faridpúr, was put into the Fifth Division. This was composed of Dacca, Sylhet, Attia, Kagmari, and Barbazu. The first members of the Council were Barwell, Purling, Thackeray, Shakespeare, and Holland. Barwell was Chief, and drew Rs.3000 a month, but, on the other hand, he was not allowed to trade, while the other members were allowed this privilege.

[2] There were formerly two jurisdictions—viz., Dacca Jalálpúr and the city of Dacca. These were amalgamated by Reg. 5 of 1833. Jalálpúr is the name of a large pargana in Faridpúr and Dacca, and Dacca Jalálpúr district included Faridpúr. There was a *Diwani Adálat* for Dacca Jalálpúr and another for the city of Dacca. The jurisdiction of the latter extended over the city and the places adjacent (Reg. 3 of 1793, section 4). It appears, however (section 3 of Reg. 7 of 1797), that the Court of Dacca Jalálpúr was situated in the city of Dacca. It was removed to Faridpúr apparently in 1812 (Bengal Administration Report for 1872–73, p. 45).

The districts of Farídpúr and Noakháli were not then in existence, nor was Bákarganj, which was included, along with Farídpúr and Dacca, in Dacca Jalálpúr. The arrangements with the zamindars were made at the Revenue Court of Dacca, and not in this district.

The first reference to the Decennial Settlement which I have been able to find is contained in a letter, dated 6th April 1790, from Mr Douglas to the Board of Revenue. He mentions in it that he has received the Board's letter of the 18th March, and its enclosed copy of the resolutions of his Lordship in Council. I have thought it advisable to print this letter in the Appendix. It appears from it that the proposals for the Settlement were supplied by Mr Douglas's predecessor, Mr Day, in accordance with a circular which had been issued on 10th August 1787. It appears from a letter of Mr Day's, printed in an appendix to the Governor-General's Minute of 3d February 1790 (Fifth Report), that he was Chief of Dacca in 1786, and that he had resided for fifteen years in various parts of the district. It might therefore have been expected that Mr Day would have been well qualified to assess the revenue on the zamindars. It appears, however, from Mr Douglas's reports, and also from subsequent occurrences, that many of Mr Day's assessments were extravagantly high. I may add here that the early correspondence appears to show that Mr Douglas was a man of good sense and humanity, and possessed of a breadth of view which has never been very common among officials. Take, for example, his remark in a letter of 29th March 1790, about the administration of justice by the zamindars: "The zamindars also had the privilege of administering justice in their respective jurisdictions, acting something like justices of the peace in our own country, settling

trifling disputes, and rendering easy and speedy redress to the injured party, which would have been rendered very difficult indeed if a poor man had to travel to the *Hazoor* and prefer his complaint through a regiment of corrupt *matsadies* [clerks], every one of whom must have been bribed before he could obtain what a respectable zamindar could have granted him on the spot in a day's attendance."

The making of the Settlement occupied a year or two, and it was not until 31st July 1792 that Mr Douglas sent up the papers "of the proposed Novennial Settlement, commencing with the Bengal year 1198 (A.D. 1791) and ending with 1206." The Settlement was called Novennial because, in consequence of the delay in making it, it commenced one year later than the Decennial Settlement. From a letter of Mr Massie, dated 31st March 1801, it appears that the Board's instructions on the subject of the Settlement were issued on the 30th December 1790, and that the formal tender of the Settlement to the landholders commenced on 20th May 1791. In the same report Mr Massie points out that sufficient regard was not paid at the conclusion of the Settlement to the ascertainment and record of the names of the real owners of the land, and he goes on to observe that a practice has prevailed in the district (Dacca Jalálpúr) from time immemorial, of conducting all the affairs of an estate from generation to generation in the name of the original proprietor, or of some fictitious name formed by him. As the letter gives several specimens of the manner in which the Settlement was made, I have printed it in the Appendix.

In another report, dated 7th March 1801, Mr Massie refers to certain abuses which were committed at the time of the Permanent Settlement: "The first is the

frauds committed by zamindars at the time of the separation of the independent *taluqdars,* in causing *taluqs* that had never existed, or had been before consolidated, to be separated at a certain *jama* from their estates. The second is the frauds committed by zamindars subsequently to the separation of the independent taluqdars, in causing the lands of separated taluqs, of which they were the proprietors, to be clandestinely annexed to their zamindaries, leaving only small parcels of waste or jungle lands as the separated taluqs. The third is the frauds committed by the independent taluqdars, after their separation from the zamindars, in causing fictitious or unproductive taluqs to be separated from their taluqs, and inserted gradually in the accounts of the ziladars. This last species of fraud, your Board will observe, must have been committed with the connivance of the ziladars, and though I fear it has been carried to a great extent, it appears hitherto to have escaped detection, owing to the immense number of separated taluqs in this district, and the impossibility of the Collector himself entering so minutely into the details of the accounts of them." From the same letter it appears that the district of Dacca Jalálpúr was divided into ten zilas or collecting circles, and that Mr Massie proposed to increase their number to thirteen. These ziladars were liable to imprisonment, and on 11th January 1800, Mr Massie reports that he had put seven of them into jail for not giving up their papers. He adds that three of them immediately resigned.

The great number of separated taluqs is a peculiarity in the land settlement of Bákarganj and Dacca. In fact, the larger portion of the land revenue of this district is paid by taluqdars. There are 3232 estates—*i.e.*, lands —subject to the payment of revenue, for which separate

engagements to Government have been executed (No. 8 of 1800, section 13), and no less than 2700 of these are independent or separated taluqs. The total revenue paid by zamindars is under four and a half lacs (444,107), whilst that paid by the taluqdars is over five lacs (507,714). *N.B.*—This does not represent the whole of the revenue of the district, there being also farms and also estates held under direct or *khas* management.

The difference between a zamindar and an independent taluqdar is nowadays merely nominal. The revenue paid by both is equally fixed, and their other rights and privileges are the same, and the difference of title is only important as a matter of social consideration. The nominal distinction even is not always observed, for sometimes the same landholder is called indifferently a taluqdar and a zamindar. The distinction, however, as generally made is as follows. If a landholder owns a pargana, or an aliquot portion thereof, he is called a zamindar, and also generally receives by courtesy the title of *chaudhari;* but if his estate bears no relation to a pargana or its divisions, he is merely a taluqdar. The districts of the British administration are a modern arrangement. The old divisions appear to have been into sarkárs and parganas for revenue purposes, and into thanas for purposes of police. The word *zila* is now taken as equivalent to district, but the zilas at or about the time of the Permanent Settlement were not districts in the modern sense, and were, as we have seen, merely collecting circles. Among the common people the word *zila* is at the present day very frequently employed to signify the headquarters of a district. Parganas are divided in the first instance into sixteen parts, corresponding to the divisions of a rupee, and if a landholder holds one-half or one-quarter of a pargana, he is described as the

holder of eight anas, or four anas, as the case may be. But the subdivision does not stop here, for each ana, or even fraction of an ana, may be assumed as the unit and again divided into sixteen parts, and so on. Thus it is common to describe a person as the holder of eight anas, or one-half of a one-ana share of a pargana considered as a sixteen-ana property, and such a person is, I believe, always entitled to be called a zamindar. A taluqdar's estate generally consists of one or more *mozahs* or villages, or of portions of them. These portions are also divided into sixteen parts, and it may be mentioned here that this mode of dividing property is universal in Bengal. A man is never described as the holder of so many *bighas* or acres, but as the holder of two anas, or one pie, or five gandas, or two cowries, and so on, of such a taluq or *howala*, or other tenure. The taluqdars of the Permanent Settlement are of two sorts, first, the independent or *hazuri* taluqdars, who had already paid direct to Government; and secondly, those who were then separated for the first time from the zamindars. The separation of the taluqs was not a part of the original scheme of the Permanent Settlement, but it was a favourite idea with Lord Cornwallis, and was eventually carried out. In his minute of 3d February 1790 his Lordship remarks, "The proprietors of the smaller zamindaries and taluqs in general conduct their own business, and I make no doubt would improve their lands were they exempted from the authority of the zamindars, and allowed to pay their revenue immediately to the public treasuries of the collectors." In another place he says, "When the demand of Government upon the zamindars is fixed they can have no plea for levying an increase upon the taluqdars, for I conceive the taluqdars in general to have the same property in

the soil as the zamindars, and that the former are to be considered as proprietors of lesser portions of land, paying their revenues to Government through the medium of a larger proprietor, instead of remitting them directly to the public treasury. The pernicious consequences which must result from affording to one individual an opportunity of raising the public revenues assessed upon the lands of another at his own discretion, and for his own advantage, are evident; and on this account I was desirous that all proprietors of land, whether zamindars, taluqdars, or chaudharies, should pay their rents immediately to the European Collector of the district or other officer of Government, and be subject to the same general laws. The number of names upon the rent-roll will add little to the business of the Collector, provided that the sum to be paid by each proprietor of land is fixed. In support of this opinion I have annexed some extracts from the proceedings of the Committee of Circuit, the members of which must have been well acquainted with the customs and practices of the Mogul Government."

"These extracts afford convincing proofs of the proprietary rights of the inferior zamindars and taluqdars, and that their being made to pay their rent through the superior zamindar of the district was solely for the convenience of the Government, which found it less difficult to collect the rents from one principal zamindar than from a number of petty proprietors."

The following remarks from the same minute may be quoted as showing the materials with which the Permanent Settlement was made, and the Governor-General's views of their sufficiency: "Twenty years have been employed in collecting information. In 1769 supervisors were appointed; in 1770 provincial councils were established; in 1772 a Committee of Circuit was

deputed to make the Settlement, armed with all the powers of the Presidency; in 1776 amíns were appointed to make a *hastabud* of the country; in 1781 the provincial councils of revenue were abolished, and collectors were sent into the several districts, and the general control and management of the revenues was lodged in a Committee of Revenue at Calcutta under the immediate inspection of Government. Like our predecessors, we set out with seeking for new information; and we have now been three years in collecting it. Voluminous reports have been transmitted by the several collectors on every point which was deemed of importance."

His Lordship goes on to say, "I must declare that I am clearly of opinion that this Government will never be better qualified, at any given period whatever, to make an equitable settlement of the land revenue of these provinces, and that if the want of further information was to be admitted now, or at any other future period, as a ground for delaying the declaration of the permanency of the assessment, the commencement of the happiness of the people and of the prosperity of the country would be delayed for ever."

The data on which the assessments at the Permanent Settlement were fixed are clearly stated in the Bengal Special Orders, published at section 68 of Regulation 8 of 1793. "The jama—*i.e.*, revenue—of the preceding year, compared with the account and information supplied by the collectors, and the recommendations of the Board of Revenue founded thereon, is to be the standard." Certain qualifying sections follow, and it is expressly ordered (section 70) that no abatement from the revenue of the preceding year is to be allowed without the special sanction of the Governor-General in Council. Section 75 of the same Regulation observes that the

statement above referred to is inapplicable to the separated taluqs, or to any instances where the actual produce may have been ascertained. In such cases the assessment is to be regulated so as to leave the proprietors a provision for themselves and families equal to about ten per cent. on the amounts of their contributions to Government. But taluqdars who had paid at a fixed rent for the last twelve years were allowed to settle at this revenue.

It has been often said that the Permanent Settlement ruined those who accepted it. This statement is probably true of the larger zamindars, but it is not applicable to the taluqdars, many of whom got their lands on easy terms, and have handed them down to their descendants to the present day. No doubt the rule, that if they had paid a fixed rent for twelve years it was not to be enhanced, proved the safety of many of them. The smallness of their estates, and the great number of them, must also have enabled them to escape, for the collectors could not know, or even guess at the real value of their properties, and were obliged to take what they offered, or what they had been paying hitherto. It may generally be said that the owners of the backward and less known zamindaries fared better than those of which the resources had been developed, and were supposed, at least, to be accurately known. Thus, Rajnagar and Chandradwip were probably over-assessed, and the owners were ruined, whereas Arangpúr and Selímábád were somewhat lightly assessed, and are to this day in the hands of descendants of the original proprietors. This remark applies to more districts than Bákarganj, and perhaps accounts for the light assessment and great prosperity of the zamindars in such remote districts as Mymensing and Eastern Bengal generally. It was not

merely, or even chiefly, that the collectors knew less about the eastern districts than they did about Burdwan or Nuddea, but because cultivation was much more backward in the former districts. Hence the burden on the zamindars in these districts got lighter every year as cultivation advanced and more ryots came in, whereas in Burdwan or Nuddea the zamindars had not the same margin for making profits.

On the other hand, the zamindars in Eastern Bengal were much more exposed to loss from diluviation, owing to the great rivers which flow through or skirt their estates, and many flourishing parganas have in this way almost disappeared. For example, pargana Srírámpúr in this district, which was one of the four original parganas of sarkár Bákla, has been nearly all washed away by the Meghna, and the zamindars of it have long since disappeared. Pargana Dakhin Shahbázpúr has also suffered much from the same cause. I do not know whether it is to this cause, or to the abuse of the practice of subdivision, that the zamindars of Kotwalipara owe their poverty, but the fact is certain that the Kotwalipara zamindars (they now belong to the Faridpúr district) are among the poorest and pettiest, if not the very poorest zamindars in Bengal. As the rivers wash away estates, so also do they form new ones, and it might have been thought that the new formations would compensate the zamindars for their losses, but this has been far from the case. Not only do the new formations remain unproductive for many years, so that the zamindar may be ruined by the loss of his old lands and sold up before he can get any benefit from the substitutes for them, but also the chars, or new formations, are, or at least were, in general resumed by Government and assessed anew. The above is somewhat of a digression, but I

have been led to enter upon it in order to counteract a common impression that all zamindars are wealthy men. In fact, there are more poor zamindars than there are rich ones—*i.e.*, comparing them with other classes, such as traders, and even professional men—and there are many taluqdars, both independent and dependent (*kharija*, or *hazuri*, and *shikami*), who are richer than their zamindar.

Mr Westland remarks that the zamindars, in accepting the Settlements, set the seal to their own ruin. This is true, but the fact is that they had not much option in the matter. If they did not accept the Settlements, they were ousted, their lands were managed by officers called *Kurak amíns*, or *Kurak sazawals*, or were let in farm, and though they were supposed to be allowed ten per cent. on the net collections, it was practically very difficult for them to get the allowance. A letter from the Collector, dated 20th February 1794, shows that no proprietors of estates held khas—*i.e.*, under direct management—had got the *mashahara*, or allowance sanctioned by the Regulations, except the proprietors of the three divisions of Selímábád. In short, it may be said that by not accepting the Settlements the zamindars were ruined at once, and by accepting them they were ruined after some interval. In some cases the acceptance of the Settlement appears to have been even less voluntary than the reluctant acquiescence in a hard bargain. One zamindar—he was a descendant of the great Rajah Raj Ballab—complained in 1797 that the Collector (Mr Thompson) demanded agreements from him and his partners, and that when he refused to give them he was confined under a guard of sepoys, and prevented from bathing, praying, or eating, and thereby driven to sign an application for settlement. The technical word for

the zamindar's agreements is *tahút*. Many of them are preserved in the Collectorate, and are small, insignificant pieces of brown country paper, containing little except the obligor's name, the amount of the annual revenue, and the instalments in which it is to be paid. The agreements are in Persian, and are surmounted by the Collector's signature or initial.

The troubles of the collectors did not end with the general completion of the Permanent Settlement. The arrangements about the separated taluqs took time, and on 12th August 1793 the Collector reported that there were nearly 4000 taluqs (this is in all Dacca Jalálpúr) which had been separated but of which no settlement had been made. Some zamindars, as we have seen, would not come to terms, and the collectors had to manage their estates directly, or to grant temporary leases of them; and in other cases, although the zamindars accepted the Settlement, they fell into arrears, and their estates had to be sold, or the revenue of them to be collected by special officers.

SAYER DUTIES.—Besides the revenue from land, the Mogul Government was in the habit of levying taxes upon professions, and each tax was called a *mahal*, and let out in farm, just as if it had been a landed property. Thus there was a tax on washermen, which was called the *Gázar-mahal*, and yielded about Rs.60 a year. There were also the *Dhúmdari-mahal*, which was collected from bird-catchers, snake-charmers, &c., and yielded about Rs.1450; the *Bajantri-mahal*, collected from musicians, and yielding about Rs.310; the *Mahai-mahal*, collected from the dealers in dried fish; *Charmokundia*, levied on sellers of vegetables; *Chappa-jamdanny*, levied on weavers, &c. I do not find that there

was any tax on the sale of spirits in the Dacca division, and probably there was none, on account of the aversion of the Mogul Government to derive any profit from this source.

Mr Douglas, in his report of the 5th May 1790, objected to the abolition of the above taxes on the broad ground that professional men should contribute their quota to the general income of the country. He writes: "As far as I have been able to learn, they [the taxes] are in general of the same nature as taxes on the same articles in other countries, and I am inclined to think they are not considered as oppressive even by the natives themselves. . . . I shall not, therefore, take on me to recommend their discontinuance, whereby the Honourable Company must sustain considerable loss, while at the same time the benefit arising to individuals would scarcely be a compensation for giving up so much revenue, which is necessarily appropriated to the general defence of the State, and in the benefits of which every individual participates. I therefore see no reason why professional men, tradesmen, and artificers of every kind should not contribute their quota to such a useful and necessary purpose as well as the ryot or husbandman, more especially in times of pressing exigencies." It is perhaps to be regretted that these views did not prevail, and that a tax to which the people had got accustomed should have been allowed to fall into desuetude. However, the Government of the day took another view, and abolished these miscellaneous taxes. They also abolished the taxes levied at bazárs and markets from shopkeepers and market-vendors, and gave the zamindars compensation for the loss of them in the shape of a deduction from the land revenue. In fact, however, the zamindars did not cease to levy such taxes,

and probably it never was intended that zamindars should be prevented from establishing such bazárs and markets and deriving revenue therefrom. Nearly all the markets, and probably most of the bazárs in Bengal, have been established since the Permanent Settlement, and on zamindars' land, and it seems legitimate that the zamindars should get at least ground-rent from those who make use of them. I have printed Mr Douglas's letter about the bazárs and markets in the Appendix.

## II. TERRITORIAL DIVISIONS OF THE DISTRICT AND THEIR HISTORY.

The subordinate divisions under a sarkár or chakla are variously called *parganas*, *tappas*, *tarafs*, *girds*, and *joárs*. The pargana is the largest and most common of them, and it is generally understood that the word *tappa* prefixed to the name of a tract of country implies that it has been formed out of part of a pargana. Thus, tappa Nazirpúr and tappa Sultanábád are supposed to imply that they were formed out of pargana Chandradwip. The unit in the division of tracts of land is generally the mozah or village, though this is sometimes divided into *kismats* or *paras*—*i.e.*, hamlets. A pargana consists of a number of mozahs, but their number and size are quite uncertain, and hence parganas vary greatly in size and importance.

The number of parganas, &c., in Bákarganj is reckoned at forty-seven. They are of very different ages and importance, and in some cases the divisions appear to have no better foundation than the notions of the *Taujihnavis* — *i.e.*, the officer of the Revenue Roll Department. They are also far from being compact, and it has been found quite impossible to make them the basis of

administrative divisions. Still they are well known to the natives, every ryot being able to tell to which pargana his village belongs, and there is little likelihood of the names of the chief parganas becoming obsolete. Pargana rates of rent no longer exist, nor do even the same weights and land-measures always prevail over a whole pargana; but still the word *pargana* is used by the public as a rough means of classification, and the rate of rent commonly, though not invariably, prevailing in a pargana is often appealed to as the standard. I have, therefore, resolved to take up the parganas one by one, and give a short history of each, more especially as this gives a convenient opportunity for noticing the principal native families, as their history is for the most part connected with that of their parganas.

In the following list I have arranged the parganas chiefly according to their geographical position, though I have deviated somewhat from this arrangement in order that I might begin with the four great parganas of Chandradwip, Buzurgumedpúr, Selímábád, and Idilpúr. Some of the parganas also are so scattered—*e.g.*, Baikanthpúr—that it is difficult to find a place for them.

The number of parganas (forty-seven) on the list appears large, but many of them really belong to other districts, and are only represented in Bákarganj by a few outlying taluqs. Thus Rajnagar and Kasimpúr Selapati substantially belong to Faridpúr, and Bikrampúr and Jalálpúr to Dacca; and by far the greater portion of their revenues is paid in those districts. But at the time of the Revenue Survey, and on other occasions, it was found that some taluqs which had been separated from the zamindaries were geographically situated within this district, and therefore their revenues were made payable at the Bákarganj treasury. I have not thought

it necessary to give any account of these extraneous parganas, and have relegated them to the end of the list. The first thirty-seven names on the list comprise all the parganas which are territorially important, and even many of these are very small and insignificant. Speaking generally, it may be said that the north of the district belongs to Bangrora, Birmohan, Idrakpúr, and Chandradwip; the eastern portion to North and South Shahbázpúr, Idilpúr, Sultanábád, Nazirpúr, and Ratandi Kalikapúr; the central portion to Chandradwip, Selímábád, Buzurgumedpúr, and Arangpúr; and the western portion to Selímábád and Syedpúr. The south of the district belongs for the most part to the Sundarbans, and is not included in any pargana. If we study the subject, we find that the positions of the parganas are by no means so arbitrary as they appear at first sight, and we can recognise the fact that most of them were originally tolerably compact. Indeed it is reasonable to suppose that they were so, as the parganas were divisions of the country made for revenue purposes, and each of them was probably originally in the hands of a single individual or family. The most irregular are the parganas which were composed chiefly of taluqs, such as Buzurgumedpúr. The absence of maps and the want of local knowledge among the officers of the distant courts of Delhi and Dacca of course prevented the divisions from being quite regular. Much of Bákarganj also was in old times covered with jungle, and determinate boundaries were therefore impossible. Thus the great pargana of Buzurgumedpúr appears to have been very vaguely defined towards the south, and was considered to comprise many of the lands which are now classed as the Sundarbans. It has been said that Jeradkhana and Muradkhana were the old names for the Sundarbans, but as regards

the Bákarganj Sundarbans, it appears to me that it would be more correct to say that they were included in Buzurgumedpúr. Some of the present irregularities of the parganas are interesting as showing the physical changes which have taken place in the district. Thus, when we find the parganas of Uttar Shahbázpúr, Ramnagar, Nazirpúr, and Ratandi Kalikapúr on both sides of the Títulia and Ilsa, some portions being in thanas Mendiganj and Baufal on the mainland, and some on the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, we are reminded of a time when that island was only separated from the mainland by a narrow channel. So also we have an illustration of the action of the rivers in the parganas of Srírámpúr and Idilpúr, one of which has almost disappeared, while the other is neither so large nor so fertile as in old times. It should be noted that the land revenue shown in the list of parganas does not represent the revenue of the whole district. It only shows that of the parganas and of the taluqs separated from them, and does not include the revenue from the Sundarban grants, from Government estates (*khas mahals*), from resumptions, or from fisheries. The list only shows a revenue of about ten lacs, but the total revenue of the district is upwards of thirteen and a half lacs (Rs.1,367,770).

LIST of the PARGANAS, &c., in BÁKARGANJ, showing the Revenue of each, and the Proportion in which that is paid by the Zamindaries and by the Taluqs.

| No. | Name of Pargana, &c. | Revenue of Zamindaries. | No. of Taluqs. | Revenue of Taluqs. | Total Revenue. | Remarks. |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Chandradwip | 82,562 14 4½ | 73 | 58,104 10 8½ | 140,667 9 1 | |
| 2 | Gird-i-Bandar | ... | 1 | 53 5 4 | 53 5 4 | |
| 3 | Buzurgumedpúr | 34,546 8 11¾ | 407 | 265,894 14 5 | 300,441 7 4¾ | The Buzurgumedpúr zamindari consists of the farm (No. 1406), the Dari char (No. 1447), and the Chakran (No. 1437). The fractions are chiefly the result of the conversion of sicca into Government rupees. |
| 4 | Selímábád | 98,227 0 1 | 20 | 4,798 4 1½ | 103,025 4 2½ | |
| 5 | Tappa Havili Selímábád | 11,055 11 5 | 9 | 3,323 0 6 | 14,378 11 11 | |
| 6 | Tappa Havili | 644 8 10 | 5 | 480 0 1½ | 1,124 8 11½ | |
| 7 | Idilpúr | 65,904 4 11 | 119 | 8,637 5 9 | 74,541 10 8 | |
| 8 | Tappa Nazirpúr | 28,783 1 4½ | 4 | 14,687 9 11 | 43,470 12 3½ | |
| 9 | P. Ratandi Kalikapúr | 25,237 11 4 | 6 | 3,314 1 6 | 28,551 12 10 | |
| 10 | Uttar Shahbázpúr | 7,645 12 9½ | 294 | 10,899 9 10½ | 18,545 6 8 | |
| 11 | Dakhin Shahbázpúr | 44,413 15 5 | 4 | 15,531 10 6½ | 59,945 0 0 | |
| 12 | Kistodebpúr | 816 0 0 | ... | ... | 816 0 0 | |
| 13 | Alinagar | 1,578 5 5 | ... | ... | 1,578 5 5 | |
| 14 | Ramnagar | 5,187 6 6 | 15 | 3,676 12 5½ | 8,864 2 11½ | |
| 15 | Ram Hari char | ... | 1 | 119 4 6 | 119 4 6 | |
| 16 | Kalmi char | ... | 1 | 1,846 10 8 | 1,846 10 8 | |
| 17 | Sultanábád | 21,128 13 5 | 10 | 5,646 13 1 | 26,775 10 6 | |
| 18 | Kasimnagar joár Dáspára | 1,633 9 11 | ... | ... | 1,633 9 11 | |
| 19 | Khanja Bahadur Nagar | 64 8 6½ | 59 | 6,598 11 6 | 6,663 4 0½ | |
| 20 | Srírámpúr | 441 4 1½ | 84 | 4,797 9 4½ | 5,238 13 6 | |
| 21 | Tappa Abdulapúr | 3,551 11 6 | 1 | 798 0 0 | 4,349 11 6 | |
| 22 | Tappa Kadirábád | 962 15 10½ | 1 | 598 9 3½ | 1,561 9 2 | |
| 23 | Tappa Azimpúr | 2,749 6 8¼ | 41 | 7,732 10 0¾ | 10,482 0 9 | |
| 24 | P. Jahapúr | 853 11 10 | 2 | 42 15 11½ | 896 11 9½ | |
| 25 | Idrakpúr | 3,278 11 10 | 52 | 2,060 7 10½ | 5,339 3 8½ | |
| 26 | Rasulpúr | ... | 47 | 984 0 9½ | 984 0 9½ | |
| 27 | Bangrora | 365 6 9½ | 939 | 20,724 2 9 | 21,089 9 6½ | |
| 28 | Birmohan | ... | 69 | 272 13 9½ | 272 13 9½ | |
| 29 | Tappa Birmohan | 13 5 4 | 27 | 295 7 10 | 308 13 2 | |
| 30 | Habibpúr | 878 14 11¼ | ... | ... | 878 14 11¼ | |
| 31 | Maizardi | 345 0 6 | 23 | 427 6 10½ | 772 8 4½ | |
| 32 | Jalálpúr | 365 6 4¾ | 1 | 1,113 0 1½ | 1,478 6 6¼ | |
| 33 | Shaistábád | 1,040 14 0½ | 5 | 991 15 0 | 2,032 13 0½ | |
| 34 | Shaistanagar | 1,537 1 6 | 161 | 14,927 14 10½ | 16,495 0 4½ | There is also a pargana called Amrapúr, but as it is represented only by a khas mahal with a revenue of Rs.7-2, I have not included it in the list. |
| 35 | Shahzádpúr | 6,897 3 3½ | 26 | 850 4 6½ | 7,747 7 10 | |
| 36 | Tappa Bahadurpúr | 4,913 1 1 | 2 | 304 0 0 | 5,217 1 1 | |
| 37 | P. Arangpúr | 14,364 7 6 | 22 | 9,604 12 9½ | 23,969 4 3½ | |
| 38 | Syedpúr | 6,570 13 9 | 4 | 21,341 3 3 | 27,912 0 0 | |
| 39 | Baikanthpúr [1] | ... | 32 | 7,216 10 11 | 7,216 10 11 | |
| 40 | Tappa Lakshirdiya | ... | 27 | 1,251 3 6 | 1,251 3 6 | |
| 41 | Rajnagar | ... | 9 | 471 1 10 | 471 1 10 | |
| 42 | Tappa Safipúr Kala | ... | 62 | 877 1 11½ | 877 1 11½ | |
| 43 | Amirábád | ... | 1 | 336 0 0 | 336 0 0 | |
| 44 | Bikrampúr | ... | 1 | 34 3 8 | 34 3 8 | |
| 45 | Gopalpúr | ... | 5 | 4,675 0 0 | 4,675 0 0 | |
| 46 | Durgapúr | ... | 1 | 4 14 11½ | 4 14 11½ | |
| 47 | Kasimpúr Sekapati | ... | 27 | 731 12 8½ | 731 12 8½ | |
| | | 478,654 0 2 | 2700 | 507,714 6 0¼ | 986,368 6 2¼ | |

[1] Baikanthpúr is remarkable for its lands being so much scattered. There is part of it in Dakhin Shahbázpúr.

I now proceed to describe each pargana separately, and begin with Chandradwip, which is at once the oldest and the most interesting in the district.

## 1. Chandradwip.

### (*a.*) *Its History.*

Chandradwip was one of the four mahals or parganas into which sarkár Bákla was divided at the time of Todar Mal's settlement. At that time it seems to have been known by the name of Ismáilpúr or Bákla, and it appears from Professor Blochmann's work that Abul Fazl uses the term Bákla as synonymous with Chandradwip. The zamindar of Bákla, who had in 1583 a son called Parmanand Rai, was evidently one of the Chandradwip Rajahs, and probably was Rajah Krishna Ballab.

It appears from traditions, and from official records, that Chandradwip belonged from early times to a Hindu family of the Kayast caste, and that they enjoyed the title of Rajah. The name Chandradwip appears to mean the island of Chandra, whether Chandra be taken as the name of a man, or in its literal signification of the moon. The name, therefore, appears to date back to a time when a great part of the district was covered by the sea. According to tradition, much of Bákarganj was formerly the bed of a large river called the Sugandha or Sunda; and the name of Sugandha, or "the Fragrant," is, as already stated, said to be derived from the fact that when the goddess Bhagabati was cut in pieces, and the fragments scattered over the earth, her nose fell into this river. The name Sugandha is still applied, I believe, to the upper part of the Kalijiri river, and the name is perpetuated, under the abbreviated form of Sunda, in the name Sundarkúl, or bank of the Sunda, which is borne

by, I think, two villages, one near Panchakaran, and another near Nalchiti.

The following romantic story is told in connection with the name Chandradwip: There was once a Bráhman in Bikrampúr pargana of the name of Chandra, whose tutelary deity (Ishtodebta) was Bhagabati or Kali. He married a young Bráhman lady, but it was not until he brought his bride home that he knew what her name was. He then found out that she bore the same name as his patron goddess, and was greatly distressed by the coincidence, "for," he said to himself, "how can I pray to the goddess in my wife's name? It will seem as if I were worshipping my wife. Or again, how can I treat as my wife one who bears the name of my goddess? It were better that I should kill myself than that I should run the risk of committing acts of impiety." Under these feelings of perplexity he got into a boat and resolved to sail on until he was lost. It was then all open sea to the south of Bikrampúr, and he sailed on for a day and a night without meeting any one. Next morning, however, he was surprised to observe a little boat, rowed by a solitary fisher-maiden. He addressed her, and asked her how she had the courage to be there all alone. "Oh," she said, "I am following my trade, and I have no fear; but how do you, who are a Bráhman and a landsman, come to be in such a place?" Then he told her of the perplexity which had befallen him. The girl gave a scornful laugh, and said, "O Bráhman, how foolish and ignorant you are! Do you not know that the goddess Bhagabati dwells in every woman, and that every woman is a part of her? Why, then, should you be startled to find that your bride bears her name?" The Bráhman was amazed to receive such a reproof from a simple fisher-girl, and at once felt sure that she was other than she seemed, and was a goddess in disguise.

Leaping into her boat, he clasped her knees, and adjured her to tell him who she really was. In vain she reminded him of his caste, and bade him not sully it by contact with a fisher-maiden. He refused to let her go, and she was constrained to acknowledge that she was his goddess Bhagabati. The Bráhman was not slow to take advantage of the confession, and forthwith supplicated the goddess to bestow a boon upon her worshipper. She assented, and told him that the sea on which he then was would one day become dry land, and that he would possess it, and call it Chandradwip, after his own name.

Another story is, that there was a great ascetic, of the name of Chandra Sekhar Chakrabarti, who used to travel about accompanied by his disciple, Ram Nath Dhanaj Mardan Dé. One night, when he was asleep in his boat, the goddess Kali appeared to him in a dream, and told him that there were some images lying under water near his boat, and that he should secure them. Next morning he made his disciple dive twice into the water. Each time a stone image was brought up. Unfortunately, the disciple did not dive a third time, or he would have brought up Lakshmi, the goddess of Fortune. The two images he found were Katayani and Madan Gopal. They are sculptured in black stone, and are still worshipped in Madhabpásha. Chandra Sekhar then predicted to his disciple that the sea at the place where they were would one day be dry land, and that he would be the Rajah of it. He also bade him call it Chandradwip, after the name of his master.

The first seat of the family was at Kachua, a village on the right or west bank of the Títulia river, and in the Baufal thana of the Patuyakháli subdivision. According to one tradition, the Rajahs were forced to leave Kachua on account of the incursions of the Mugs — *i.e.*, the Burmese — and according to another story,

they left it on account of the encroachments of the river. There is no doubt that much diluviation has taken place near Kachua, and indeed it is still going on. The local tradition is that the Títulia was once a very narrow stream, and that the main course of the Meghna flowed on the east side of the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. This view is supported by the circumstance that the same parganas are to be found on both sides of the river—viz., Ratandi Kalikapúr, Nazirpúr, and Uttar Shahbázpúr. The traveller Ralph Fitch describes a visit he paid to Bákla in 1586. There is no town or village of the name of Bákla now in existence, nor have I ever heard any tradition of there having been such a town. I presume, therefore, that Bákla must be the same as Kachua, though if so it must have been a much larger place in Fitch's time. Probably much of the old town has been washed away. Fitch describes the country as being governed by a Hindu prince who was of a good disposition and fond of shooting. I visited Kachua in the end of 1874, and found that the only remains of old building were a lonely and deserted temple standing on a high mound overlooking the river, and a series of vaulted chambers of very strong masonry, which are said to have been the *rajbari* or palace. The temple is conical in shape and is double storied, which is, I believe, not commonly the case in modern Hindu temples. It is evidently of considerable age, for there is a large tree (a *pakour*) growing on the top, which is so branching as almost to conceal the temple underneath.[1] The rajbari is a little farther inland, and is surrounded with jungle.

[1] Perhaps this was the very temple in which the Rajah's son is said to have taken refuge. It certainly was a natural place to run to in case of an inundation.

The genealogy of the Chandradwip family is told by their descendants with one or two variations, but the most correct account appears to be as follows: Ram Nath Dhanaj Mardan Dé was, as we have seen, the founder of the family. He lived at Kachua, and was succeeded by his son Ram Ballab. Ram Ballab was followed by Sri Ballab, Hari Ballab, and finally by Krishna Ballab, who had no sons, and with whom therefore the direct male line became extinct. Krishna Ballab, however, had a daughter named Kamala, who has left her mark on the district, and deserves a passing remembrance. I have said that Kachua is on the bank of the Títulia; the work for which Kamala is famous is the excavation of a large tank at a place not far from Kachua, and near the mouth of the Kalaia river. The tank is now in ruins, but enough remains to show that it was larger than any tank, not excepting Durga Sagur, which has since been dug in the district. The tradition is that after Kamala dug the tank the water would not rise in it, and that the people reproached her family, saying that on account of the Rajah's sins the water would not come in. Thereafter Kamala, being warned in a dream, went and stood in the middle of the tank, and the waters rose up and closed round her, and she remained in their midst under the guise of a water-lily. According to another tradition, she floated out to the great river by a stream which still flows through the tank. The tradition goes on to say that Kamala had an infant child, and that when her husband saw the waters closing round her, he called to her to come out. She replied that she could not, as the waters were drawing her down; and then he asked her who would nurse her child if she did not return. Under instructions from the goddess Ganga, Kamala answered

that if her child were placed every morning on the steps of the *ghât*, or landing-place, she would come and nurse him, but no one else must see or touch her. The child was accordingly set down on the ghât every morning, and Kamala rose out of the water and nursed him. But the Rajah, being disconsolate for her loss, resolved to try and get her back; so he hid himself near the ghât, and attempted to seize Kamala as she was giving milk to the child; but she escaped from his embrace, disappeared in the water, and never again emerged. There is a Bengali song about these occurrences, which is still sung in the neighbourhood of the tank. A few verses of it have been recovered for me by Babu Chandra Kumar Ghose, the police sub-inspector of Baufal. They are printed in the Appendix. Another part of the tradition is, that when Kamala set about making the tank she resolved that it should extend as far as she could walk without turning round. She had walked about four *druns* (three druns and thirteen kanies), when her servants, being alarmed lest she should walk too far, induced her to turn round by smearing her heel with the blood of a pigeon, and calling on her to stop as her foot was bleeding. Labourers were brought from Dakhin Shahbázpúr to dig the tank, and Kala Bhadranath and his twenty-seven sons and thirteen grandsons made the *kodals* or spades for them. The digging cost nine lacs of rupees. According to one account, Kamala was the wife of Rajah Jagadanand Bosu; and according to another (unless the two names refer to the same person), she was the wife of the Kala or Black Rajah, whose name still survives in the Kala Rajah bíl, an extensive swamp in the Baufal thana.

The tank is no longer full of water, but Kamala's good

deed has not been unfruitful, for its bed now yields a rich harvest of rice, and its lofty walls or sides support forty or fifty homesteads, luxuriant in tamarind-trees, gáb-fruit trees, and bamboos. It is pleasant to see these homesteads raised high above the surrounding swamps, and to think that their inhabitants owe their comforts to a forgotten Bengali princess. We are reminded of the noble language used by Burke when speaking of the tanks in the Carnatic: "These are the monuments of real kings, who were the fathers of their people; testators to a posterity which they embraced as their own. These are the grand sepulchres built by ambition, but by the ambition of an insatiable benevolence which, not contented with reigning in the dispensation of happiness during the contracted tenure of human life, had strained, with all the reachings and graspings of a vivacious mind, to extend the dominion of their bounty beyond the limits of nature, and to perpetuate themselves through generations of generations the guardians, the protectors, the nourishers of mankind."

Krishna Ballab is said to have been succeeded by his daughter's son, Sib Nand, *alias* Parmanand Rai. He was the son of Balabhadra Bosu, and with him commenced the Bosu family. Parmanand was succeeded by Jagadanand, who was drowned in the Ganges, and whose son, Kandarpa Narain, removed on this account from Kachua and settled at Madhabpásha, about seven miles west-north-west of Barisál. There is a tradition that an astrologer foretold to Jagadanand that he would be drowned, and that to guard against this he shut himself up in his palace at Kachua. But at the appointed time the river swelled and rose up to the level of the balcony, and as the Rajah looked out upon the flood the goddess Ganga rose out of the water and

stretched out her arms and beckoned to him to come. The Rajah, seeing that his fate was inevitable, yielded to it, and sinking into the arms of the goddess, disappeared into the river, which immediately afterwards returned to its old bed. This tradition appears to be a poetical reminiscence of the great storm which overwhelmed sarkár Bákla in 1583 or 1584. It appears from Professor Blochmann's work that the son of the zamindar of Bákla in 1583 was called Parmanand Rai, and this may have been Jagadanand's father.

Rajah Kandarpa Narain was succeeded by Ram Chandra Rai, who married a daughter of the famous Rajah Pratápáditya. It is said that when Ram Chandra Rai went to his father-in-law's house to bring away his bride he was accompanied by a favourite jester called Ramai Bhar. This man dressed himself up as a woman, and so gained admission to Pratápáditya's zenana and conversed with his queen. This came to the ears of the Rajah, and he resolved to revenge the insult by killing his son-in-law. His queen told this to her daughter, who communicated it to her husband, and he contrived to escape from the palace in disguise. On coming to his boat, however, a new difficulty presented itself, for Prátápáditya had felled trees and made a barricade in front of the boats in order to prevent his son-in-law's escape. But a famous athlete, named Ram Mohan Mal, who was in the Rajah's company, surmounted the difficulty. Though the boat was one of sixty-four oars, Ram Mohan lifted it over the barricade and launched it into the river. Afterwards Pratápáditya relented, and sent his daughter to Ram Chandra, and the place where she landed, near Madhabpásha, is still called Bodhu Mata Hát, or the Bride's Market, as a market was established there in her honour. It may be mentioned

here that Ram Mohan Mal is said to have been the founder of the old family known by the name of the Raies of Ujirpúr, and it is a curious circumstance that the present Rajah of Chandradwip is a scion of this family, he being an adopted son. Thus Ram Mohan Mal's descendants have attained the dignity which their ancestor helped to preserve. Unfortunately, however, the glory of the Chandradwip family has long since departed.

Ram Chandra Rai is mentioned in Harish Chandra Tarkalankar's history of Rajah Pratápáditya, but the story of his escape is told somewhat differently. Ram Chandra, it is there said, was Pratápáditya's son-in-law, and had left his country and fled to his father-in-law's house. Pratápáditya resolved to have him assassinated, and to take possession of his kingdom.[1] Pratápáditya's daughter heard of the plot, and warned her husband, who called in the aid of Udai Aditya, his brother-in-law. Udai Aditya said he was going that night to Jessore to a *nách*, and suggested that Ram Chandra should disguise himself as a linkman and accompany the palanquin. Ram Chandra did so, and escaped; and then Pratápáditya sent his general, Kamal Khoja, to take Ram Chandra's country.

This Ram Chandra is in all probability the boy-king of Bákla whom the Jesuit Fonseca speaks of, and who was son-in-law of the King of Chandecan. Du Jarric says he was driven out of his country by the Arracanese, which agrees with the statement above that he had fled to his father-in-law's house (see below, in chapter on Sundarbans).

Ram Chandra was succeeded by his son Kirti Narain, who is reported to have been a great warrior, and who,

[1] Tarkalankar speaks of Ram Chandra as being only a zamindar, but this is a mistake (see the original life of Pratápáditya by Ram Ram Bosu).

according to a tradition common to several Hindu families, lost his caste by smelling a Masalman's dinner. He lost his rajahship from the same cause, and was succeeded first by his younger brother Bashodeb, and then by his son Prataáp Narain. Prataáp Narain was succeeded by his son Prem Narain, with whom the Bosu dynasty became extinct, and was replaced by the Mitra family. Prem Narain was succeeded by his son-in-law, Gouri Charan Mitra, who had two sons, Udai Narain and Raj Narain. Udai Narain was expelled by two Mahomedans of Chakar, called Mendi Mozamdar and Sarafaddin Mozamdar, who had found favour with the ruling Nawab by giving to him in marriage their sister, who was famed for her beauty. Udai Narain went to plead his cause with the Nawab, but was told that he must first exhibit his prowess against a tiger. An arena was prepared. Udai Narain killed the tiger in the presence of the Nawab, and then craved a boon. The Nawab's beautiful wife was present, and as she favoured her brothers, and was vexed at Udai Narain's victory, she flung him the rind of a plantain fruit, and scornfully told him to take that as a gift. The rind of a plantain is called *bákla*, which also, as we have seen, was another name for Udai Narain's zamindari. So the ready-witted Hindu quickly picked up the plantain skin, and gratefully thanked the Nawab and the lady for having given him Bákla. The Nawab was pleased with his wit, and restored his zamindari to him. It may add some confirmation to this story to mention that it appears from a report of Mr Massie's, dated 18th June 1801, that the Chandradwip family had at one time possessed three firmans or grants of the time of King Mahomed Shah, bearing the seal of Nawab Murshid Kali Khan—*i.e.*, Nawab Jaffar Khan—confirming Udai Narain in the

zamindari, *hissajat*, and *nánkar* lands of Chandradwip. In these papers he was described as having succeeded Indra Narain, who had died without children, and as being the grandson of Pratáp Narain.

Udai Narain's brother, Raj Narain, did not get any share in the zamindari, but he got a taluq called Rajmata, and established himself at Pratappúr, two or three miles north of Madhabpásha. Udai Narain was succeeded by his son Sib Narain, who became insane, set fire to his house, and destroyed many old papers (see enclosures of Mr Massie's report of 18th June 1801). Sib Narain was succeeded by his eldest son, Lakshmi Narain, who died shortly before 1780 (see enclosures to above report), and was succeeded by Jai Narain, also called Durga Kuar Narain. During Jai Narain's infancy, his servant, Sankhar Bakshi, got possession of the zamindari, but Jai Narain's mother recovered it with the help of the famous Ganga Govind Sing. Perhaps it was on this occasion that the sanad of 24th November 1780 was given, which bore the seal of the Provincial Council of Dacca and the signature of Mr Holland, the Chief of Dacca, and of which a translation is appended to Mr Massie's report aforesaid. The getting of the sanad is said to have cost the Rani a good deal of money, and this, and the digging of a large tank near Madhabpásha, which is called after her, Durga Sagur, are said to have impoverished the estate. Probably it was the expense of feeding the Bráhmans, and of the other religious ceremonies attending the construction of the tank, which weighed more heavily on the estate than the mere cost of the manual labour. Jai Narain, *alias* Durga Kuar, was the last zamindar, as in his time the Chandradwip pargana was sold by the Collector for arrears of revenue in 1799. Jai Narain was succeeded by his son, Nar

Sing Rai, who was famed for his personal beauty. He had no son, but each of his two widows adopted a son, and these are now the representatives of the family. Their names are Bir Sing Narain Rai and Dabendra Narain Rai, and they are popularly known as the Bara and Chota Raja. They live at Madhabpásha, but are in poor circumstances, as they have nothing to support them except the lands round about Madhabpásha, which are *lakhiraj*, or rent-free, and some dependent taluqs. Most of the lakhiraj belongs to what is called the *khanabari* or homestead, locally called *Srinagar*. An attempt was made to resume it, but it was finally released. The khanabari is of considerable extent, and is bounded on the west by a stream called Rajar Ber, or the Rajah's Moat, which commences on the east of Rahamatpúr, and which is said to have been made by one of the rajahs as a defence to his palace. Madhabpásha is connected with Barisál by a road made many years ago by a Hindu lady named Parvati Chaudharine. There are many ruins of old buildings about Madhabpásha, but none of them are at all remarkable, and the finest thing about the place is undoubtedly the large tank called the Durga Sagur. There is a brass cannon lying near the bazár, and there is a small old tank in the neighbourhood called Kamantolla. Some have professed to read the name Kandarpa Narain on this cannon, and to connect it with the Rajah of that name, but the inscription is, to say the least, very indistinct, and it seems to me not improbable that the gun may have been brought by Rajah Durga Kuar Narain from the Mahomedan fort of Sujábád. There is a petition among the records from him asking leave to bring away some cannon from that place.

### (*b.*) *Financial History of Chandradwip.*

In the Settlement of Todar Mal the revenue of sarkár Bákla is put down at Rs.178,266, and this is larger than the revenue at that time of Khalífatábád—*i.e.*, Jessore. In 1135 B.S. the revenue of Chandradwip pargana was only Rs.6608 (Grant, p. 365). This small amount only represents the *khalsa*, or exchequer revenue, and is evidently the result of the greater parts of the pargana having been held as a *jaghir*, or fief, on the condition of the zamindar's furnishing boats and crews to the Dacca flotilla. In 1165 (Grant, p. 367) the revenue was Rs.68,509, of which only Rs.1170 were khalsa, and Rs.58,581 were jaghir, the remaining Rs.8758 being apparently composed of *abwabs* or cesses. At this time the pargana stood in the name of Adi (Udai ?) Narain of the Ganges, and is described as consisting of one zamindari and twenty-two mahals—*i.e.*, apparently parganas. This circumstance, that the zamindari consisted of twenty-two subordinate mahals, is very interesting, as it helps to explain a curious fact in the topography of the district—*i.e.*, that there is one village in the district the lands of which belong to no less than twenty-two parganas. The village is Nohalia—a large village in the Baufal thana of the Patuyakháli subdivision, and therefore not very far from Kachua, the ancient seat of the Chandradwip rajahs.

The following parganas are to be found in this village:

1. Buzurgumedpúr.
2. Bangrora.
3. Khanjabahadurnagar.
4. Arangpúr.
5. Shaistanagar.
6. Bahadurpúr.
7. Fadainagar.
8. Uttar Shahbázpúr.

9. Azimpúr.
10. Ramnagar.
11. Idrakpúr.
12. Khorda Shafipúr.
13. Shahzádpúr.
14. Kasimpúr Selapati.
15. Rasulpúr.
16. Shaistábád.
17. Farokhábád.
18. Tappa Birmohan.
19. Nazirpúr.
20. Sultanábád.
21. Shafipúr Kala.
22. Pargana Birmohan.

All the lands of these parganas are now traceable in the village except those of Farokhábád, Kasimpúr Selapati, Khorda Shafipúr, and Rasulpúr, which, however, are said by the villagers to be still in existence, but to be hidden in the jungle which covers the outskirts of the village. On account of this grouping together of twenty-two parganas, the place is popularly called Gachani—*i.e.*, the bundling or tying together. The word is also used to mean the forcing a person to accept something against his will, and hence in revenue parlance *gachani* means the compelling a proprietor or farmer to take the settlement of several estates—*i.e.*, the good and the bad together.

Two things are deserving of note in this list. The first is, that the name Chandradwip is conspicuous by its absence; and secondly, that the large pargana of Ratandi Kalikapúr is not mentioned. Now, it is known that Ratandi Kalikapúr was formed out of part of Nazirpúr and other parganas in 1149 B.S., and therefore we may reasonably conclude that the gachani took place before that period. This circumstance and the omission of Chandradwip give countenance to the following tradition: Rajah Udai Narain's brother, Raj Narain, did not take any share of the zamindari, but in order to keep alive the memory of his rights, and also of the fact that Chandradwip was composed of twenty-two parganas, he made the village of Nohalia into a taluq, and aggregated in it the names of all the parganas. It

is a fact known from other sources that most of the parganas in Bákarganj have been formed out of Chandradwip; in revenue parlance they are *kharija*, or excluded from Chandradwip, and the above list is an additional proof of this.

In 1169 B.S., as appears from a report by Mr Massie, dated 25th November 1800, the revenue of Chandradwip was Rs.71,042; and in 1194—*i.e.*, 1787—it was Rs.85,725. Mr Day, in his proposals for the Permanent Settlement, recommended that this assessment should be increased by Rs.15,000, in consideration of the Hissajat or stipendiary lands held by the zamindar. The Board of Revenue approved of this proposal, but expressed a hope that it would not cause distress to the zamindar or his family, or to the ryots. On 6th April 1790 Mr Douglas reported that Rs.3000 of the increase was obtained in 1195, and Rs.1000 more in the assessment for the current year (1196). He added, "The proprietor of the pargana is a youth of seventeen years of age, but as no attention has been paid to his education, he remains in total ignorance of the minutiæ of the Mofussil collections; his time is wholly spent in the luxuries of a zenana, and these his mother, wishing to continue in the management of the pargana, supplies him with the means of gratifying." On 29th April the Board replied by directing the Collector to make the Decennial Settlement of Chandradwip on the revenue of 1196—viz., Rs.89,725. On 4th October 1791 Mr Douglas reports that he called on the zamindar to enter into engagements on the terms proposed by Mr Day, and that he positively declined to do so. Mr Douglas adds, that some of the lands had suffered much from the inundation, but that he thought the estate could bear the increase if it were well managed, and if the Hissajat lands were resumed.

Eventually Mr Douglas proposed that the revenue for the remaining years of the Decennial Settlement—viz., from 1200 to 1206—should be fixed at Rs.87,652-1-8, and this was approved by the Board and the Governor-General. It seems that a *tahsildar*, or native collector, of Chandradwip had been appointed, owing to the Rajah's having defaulted; and on 26th October 1791 Mr Douglas reports that the owsh or early rice crop had been much injured by crabs, and that he had therefore suspended the payment of an instalment of the revenue. The zamindar did not agree to Mr Douglas's proposals, and on 21st October 1795 the Collector (Mr Armstrong) reports that the zamindar of Chandradwip is not under engagements to Government, and that he gives as a reason for not being so, that some taluqs had been separated from his zamindari in 1198 which were not entitled to separation, and that others had been separated at a much inferior rate of rent to that which he used from time immemorial to receive from them. Mr Armstrong considered that there was some truth in the latter assertion; but apparently Mr Armstrong was not a sufficiently active Collector, for he was called upon by the Governor-General in Council to explain why the revenue in his time was invariably in arrear, whereas under a former Collector it was realised with the greatest regularity. In his defence he pleads that the low price of grain, and the protracted suits which the zamindars had to bring against their under-renters, prevented them from paying the revenue (25th July 1795). Meanwhile the affairs of the Rajah of Chandradwip went from bad to worse, and on 11th November 1799 Mr Massie reports that the whole of the Rajah's lands have been sold by public auction, and that there was still a balance due of upwards of Rs.35,000, and requests that he may be

allowed to put the Rajah in the Dacca Civil Jail, if he can succeed in apprehending him. "He has distinguished himself very much," writes Mr Massie, "by his refractoriness, and the making an example of him would, I am confident, be attended with very beneficial effects in this district." The Board replied on the 22d idem by approving of this proposal. The Rajah was never actually imprisoned, but Mr Massie attempted to carry out his proposal, for there is a petition from the Rajah's mother (called by Mr Massie, the old Rani of Chandradwip), dated January 1800, in which she says that a *piada* has come to summon Rajah Jai Narain—*i.e.*, Durga Kuar. "How shall I describe to you how sick the Rajah is? The whole of the zamindari has been sold. I am a widow, and the only son I have is on the point of death." In a subsequent petition, dated March 1800, the Rani begs that the Collector will pass an order for the recall of the piada deputed to summon the Rajah. "The whole of the zamindari has been sold, and the Rajah is sick, and therefore I am distressed beyond measure; you are master of the country, and I am hopeful that, taking compassion on a poor widow, you will remit the fine, and by whatever means I can I will pay the money." It may be noted here, in explanation of Mr Massie's apparently harsh proceedings, that the preamble to Regulation 3 of 1794 states that "from the earliest times the rulers of these provinces have exercised a discretionary power of confining proprietors of land who have failed in the discharge of the public revenue." The Regulation took away the power in ordinary cases, but section 14 retained it for instances in which the proceeds of the sale of the defaulter's land did not cover the arrears, as was the case with the Rajah of Chandradwip.

Chandradwip pargana was sold at Dacca in 1206 B.S. (1799), and was bought by two Greeks, Messrs George and Alexander Panioty, by one Dal Sing of Dacca, and by several others, of whom the chief appears to have been Ram Manik Mudi. It appears to have been sold in three shares, as follows :—

| | A. | Gandas. | Krants. |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ram Manik Mudi and others . . | 8 | 12½ | 2 |
| Messrs Panioty . . . . . | 5 | 10 | 0 |
| Dal Sing . . . . . | 1 | 17¼ | 1 |
| | 16 | 0 | 0 |

Soon after the purchase the pargana was attached because the purchasers fell into arrears, and an amín was sent to collect the rents. Another amín was also sent to make a partition of the pargana, in accordance with a request of the purchasers. The difficulties of the Collector and the purchasers lasted for some time, and in one petition Messrs Panioty pathetically observe that "what we intended as a purchase of lands has only been the purchase of disputes in the Faujdari and Diwani Adâlats." On 15th April 1800 Mr Massie writes, "It is extremely unpleasant to me to be so very troublesome to your Board with regard to the affairs of pargana Chandradwip, but really the parties concerned are so clamorous and harass me so much with their petitions and representations of one kind or another," &c.

Messrs Panioty represented that they were the only real purchasers, and that Ram Manik Mudi was only a *benamidar* (man of straw) for the Rajah. Unfortunately for the Chandradwip family, this was not the case. According to the story now current in Bákarganj, Ram Manik was a *mudi* or petty shopkeeper in the Madhabpásha bazár, but he was also the Rajah's agent or *gomasta*, and he pretended to him that he was only

buying the estate on his behalf. Afterwards, however, he turned round and claimed to be the real purchaser. Ram Manik's descendants are still in possession of the zamindari, and live at Madhabpásha side by side with the representatives of the old rajahs. They are still contemptuously spoken of as the Mudi Bansa or family, and I am sorry to say that though some of them are rich, they have done very little to wipe out the discredit which rests on their ancestor's name.

The difficulties experienced by the purchasers in getting possession arose partly from the claim of the Rajah to hold certain lands rent free. These were called Hissajat lands, and are thus defined by Mr Massie in a statement submitted to the Board on 5th November 1798: "It seems that in the time of the incursions of the Mugs, the zamindars of this part of the country held certain lands exempt from revenue on condition of their furnishing boats and men to oppose those people. And the lands so held were termed Nowara lands. Some, if not all of the principal zamindars, exclusive of furnishing boats, &c., engaged to go in person in these expeditions against the Mugs, and in such cases they were allowed to hold a still greater proportion of land exempt from revenue, in consideration of their own personal services. And the lands, though included under the general term Nowara, were distinguished by the specific term Hissajat, of which latter description are the lands alluded to." Durga Narain Kuar petitioned about these lands, and Mr Massie submitted a report thereon on 18th June 1801. He states that Durga Narain produced among other papers a *parwana* signed by Mr Holland, the Chief of Dacca, dated 24th November 1780. The preamble to the parwana is worth quoting. "To the matsaddies that are employed at

present, or that may be employed hereafter, the chaudharies, zamindars, kanangoes, taluqdars, ryots, and all other inhabitants of pargana Chandradwip, &c., sarkár Bákla, Mahal Nowara, &c., dependent on Chakla Jahangirnagar, in the souba of Bengal, the paradise of kingdoms,—be it known that the aforesaid pargana, &c., is a zamindari of forty-two cosas [a kind of boat], of thirty-two mullahs [boatmen] each, and that Hissajat has been allotted to Udai Narain, the zamindar." On 21st July 1801 the Board rejected Durga Narain's claim to the Hissajat lands.

The partition papers of Chandradwip, which are in the Collectorate, bear the date of 1210 B.S. (A.D. 1803–4), but apparently the partition was not completed then, for Mr Battye, in a letter of 8th June 1807, speaks of the extraordinary delay which has taken place in completing the partition, and mentions that at last the zamindars had applied, under section 22 of Regulation 25 of 1793, for permission to make the partition by private arrangement. The Board had approved of this proposal, and Mr Battye submitted the partition papers, with the letter aforesaid. The Board confirmed the partition on 21st July 1807. A portion of the Paniotys' share is still held by their descendants, and another portion has been bought by Babus Rajendra and Mohima, of Chaudharassi, and a third portion belongs to the Kallowas family. Dal Sing's share is still held by his descendants.

In closing this account of Chandradwip, and of the ancient family which once possessed it, it is impossible to avoid the conclusion that the ruin of the rajahs was inevitable. Mr Massie may have been somewhat harsh, and our settlements and our sale laws somewhat rigid, and Ram Manik may have behaved to the Rajah after

the fashion of Glossin in his dealings with the Laird of Ellangowan, but, after all, what hope was there for a youth like the Rajah, who had spent all his life in the zenana? If none of the other adverse influences had existed, he must still in time have gone to the ground from sheer incapacity to manage his affairs; and if it were possible now to restore Chandradwip to the present representatives of the family, they would be unable to keep it. The elder or Bara Rajah is intelligent, and of fair character, but he is devoid of energy, and the demon of discord has taken possession of him and his brother, so that cases between them, and these, too, of no very reputable character, not unfrequently come before our criminal courts.

It is a remark of Mr Helps in his life of Mr Brassey, that families seem to be like certain plants which take long to come to maturity, and then flower and die; and the remark is probably even more applicable to Bengal than to Europe. I could enumerate many native families which, after being long obscure, have shot up during a single generation, have exercised much power and influence, and then have sunk back into insignificance with the death of the one leading spirit. The great Narail family of Jessore is a case in point, for it does not appear to have produced a single man of mark before or after Ram Ratan Rai. The Tagores of Idilpúr, the Ghosals of Selímábád, and the Biswases of Jolabari are also instances; and if we look at men who are now flourishing—such as Khajah Abdul Ghani, C.S.I. of Dacca; Gholam Ali Chaudhari of Haturia; Raj Ballab Rai of Madhabpásha; or Boroda Kanth Rai, the present energetic zamindar of Arangpúr—we must feel it to be very doubtful if they will leave successors who will be able to walk in their footsteps. Apart from questions

of climate and race, I think there are two circumstances which make such declensions more common in Bengal than in Europe. One is, that, as a general rule, a man of rank in India gets no training worthy of the name. If he becomes great, he does so by the pure force of his own abilities, and by breasting the blows of his surrounding circumstances. But as genius is always rare, it is not likely that it should show itself in two successive generations; and there is no external aid in the shape of good teaching, &c., to supplement deficiencies, and to enable a man of only average ability to fill a difficult position. Another circumstance, I think, is that, owing to the institution of caste, it is not so easy to get a new strain into a family as it is in Europe. In Hindu families the practice of adoption might be supposed to have some influence in this respect; but not only is the liberty of choice in adoption restricted by the rules of caste, but also, unfortunately, adoption must take place at a very early age, and therefore before anything can be known of the capacities of the adopted child.

The present revenue of the Chandradwip zamindari is Rs.82,562-14-4½. There are also seventy-three separated taluqs in it, the revenue of which is Rs.58,104-10-8½; so that the total land revenue is Rs.140,667-9-1. The Chakrabarties of Rahamatpúr, said to be descended from the Rajah's dewan or minister, are among the largest taluqdars in the pargana. The pargana is situated chiefly in thanas Kotwali, Mendiganj, and Baufal. In old records it is described as Chandradwip, &c., and the &c. is said to refer to two obsolete parganas, called Jaffirábád and Rafianagar. The Sundarban portion of Chandradwip belonged to these two parganas. The lands of Chandradwip are in general fertile and well cultivated. It is, along with Kotwali-

para and one or two other parganas, remarkable for the number of Bráhmans who live in it. Many of them hold rent-free lands, though the quantity in each case is generally small. The town of Barisál is situated in this pargana. The land measure in use is the *kani*. It is divided into gandas, cowries, and krants, there being twenty gandas in a kani, four cowries in a ganda, and three krants in a cowry. Sixteen kanies make one drun. The kani is measured by a nal or rod eight cubits and eight fingerbreadths in length. Twenty-four nals by twenty make a kani, and as the eight fingerbreadths are reckoned as equal to six inches, a nal is twelve and a half feet long (the cubit being of eighteen inches); so that twenty-four by twenty nals are equal to 300 by 250 feet, or 75,000 square feet. The standard bigha used in the measurement of Government estates, &c., is in area, 14,400 square feet, or 1600 square yards; so that the Chandradwip kani is equal to about five bighas, four kathas, and two chittaks—*i.e.*, to about five and one-fifth bighas, or about one and three-fourths of a statute acre. The same measurement is in use in parganas Azimpúr, Bangrora, Buzurgumedpúr, Gird-i-Bandar, Idilpúr, and tappa Havili. There is, however, occasionally some confusion about the size of the Chandradwip kani, one being sometimes referred to in which the nal is only eight cubits long, the fingerbreadths being omitted. This is the kani referred to by Mr Hunter in his letter to the Board of 9th December 1818, in which he describes the Chandradwip kani as being 288 by 240 feet, or 69,120 square feet. It is thus equal to four bighas and sixteen kathas, or upwards of one and a half acre. I may mention here that it is almost impossible to state all the land measures in use. There is an old list in the Collectorate, and on this Mr Reilly, when

Deputy-Collector, constructed a table, which is referred to in cases of doubt, but it does not appear to be exhaustive.

One of the principal families residing in Chandradwip, though their property lies in pargana Azimpúr, &c., is the Raies of Lakutia, about six miles from Barisál. They are a Bráhman family, and their ancestors are said to have been originally the cooks of the Rajah of Chandradwip. But, whatever their origin, they can boast of at least one member who would have done honour to any family. This was Raj Chandra Rai, the father of the present owners. He was a pleader and an enlightened zamindar, and made one of the best roads and canals in the district (the Lakutia road and khál) entirely at his own expense. The estate at present belongs to three brothers, who have become Bráhmos and have thrown aside their sacred thread.

The following papers connected with Chandradwip appear in a volume in the India Office Library, called General Appendix to Judicial Papers, 1774 :—

*To the Honourable Warren Hastings, &c.*

We beg leave to refer to your consideration a petition which has been laid before us by the vakil of Raghanandan Chaudhari, security for the pargana of Chandradwip. We understand the two Europeans there mentioned are officers of the Supreme Court of Judicature ; and we transmit this petition to you as an instance of the inconveniences which attend this jurisdiction's being exercised on the persons employed on the collections. In the present case we presume the zamindars are not amenable to the power of the Supreme Court, not being servants of the Company or any European.

(Signed) ROUSE, PURLING, &c.

DACCA, 30*th Oct.* 1775.

The petition of Khosal Chasat, vakil of the security for the parganas Chandradwip, Jaffirábád, and Rafianagar.

Showing—That Odal San (?), the former Naib, having preferred a complaint for debt against Sib Narain, zamindar, and Ram Sank-

har Bakshy, Naib of aforesaid parganas, in Calcutta, has brought from thence two Europeans to the said zamindar's house, seized and confined the Naib. . . . If the zamindar and Naib are carried to Calcutta on account of an old debt, the business of the collections cannot be carried on, &c.

### 2. Gird-i-Bandar.

Though called a pargana, this is merely a small portion of Chandradwip, which has been excluded from it in order to form the bazár of Barisál. It consists of one village (Barisál), and this a very small one, and is altogether comprised in one taluq, called Hari Radha Nath Dass, of which the revenue is only Rs. 53-5-4. The town of Barisál now includes much more than the village of that name. The civil courts and the collectorate and the magistrates' cutcheries are built on the aforesaid taluq, the sites being held by Government as an under-tenure. The taluq belongs to Babu Chandi Charan Rai, and is a very profitable one.

### 3. Buzurgumedpúr.

This is an old pargana, and was formerly included in sarkár Bazuha. It is said to derive its name from Buzurg Umed Khan, son of Shaista Khan who governed Bengal in the latter half of the seventeenth century. Some account of him will be found in vol. liii. of the "Calcutta Review" for 1871, article "Feringhies of Chittagong." Buzurgumedpúr belonged to Aga Bákar, and the mart of Bákarganj, which gave its name to the district, is situated within it. On Aga Bákar's death, Buzurgumedpúr became the property of Rajah Raj Ballab, the Naib of Shahamat Jung, nephew and son-in-law of Aliverdi Khan. He was also the Peshkar of the Nowara or Fleet lands. Grant refers to Buzurg-

umedpúr as a petty zamindari, which in the space of five-and-thirty years anterior to 1170, improved in its rental from Rs.6000 to two lacs, chiefly through new acquisitions of soil, though doubtless partly from amelioration of the uncultivated wastes of the Sundarbans, increased manufacture of salt, and growth of betel-nut. In 1135 the revenue of Buzurgumedpúr is put down as only Rs.4647. At present it is upwards of three lacs—that is, including the revenues of the permanent taluqs and of the temporarily settled estates. The zamindari cutchery of Buzurgumedpúr was at Golabari, near Bákarganj. There are still some ruins of buildings there, and the remains of a road which connected it with Bákarganj. The name Buzurgumedpúr is older than that of Bákarganj, and it appears from an official order published in vol. i. p. 185, of Seton-Karr's Selections, that Buzurgumedpúr was at one time considered important enough to be managed by a European Collector, and that Mr Henry Lodge had charge of it previous to 1787. A petition from the vakil or agent of the zamindar of Buzurgumedpúr (Rajah Raj Ballab), dated 1764, is printed at page 408 of Mr Long's Selections. It is full of complaints against the English traders. "By reason of the oppressions of the factories of the Company and many other English traders, all the inhabitants are fled: the people of the factories take from the merchants what they please at half price; cut down bamboos and trees belonging to the inhabitants, and take them away by force; if any one complain, they punish him for it. They press the inhabitants, and carry them in the woods of Sundarban, paying them only half their wages. They take possession of land in the Sundarban and make *tafalls* of salt, for which they pay no rent. They seize the salt of the tafalls of the pargana and of the inhabi-

tants. They force the inhabitants to take tobacco, salt, and other articles, and refuse to pay the legal duties on the trade which they carry on. If we demand a sight of the Company's *dustak*, they beat us with bamboos. Some of them pretend that they have been robbed and insist on our making restitution, placing peons upon us, and putting us to a good expense. They judge causes, impose and exact fines. They send peons and seize the Naib of the pargana, taking for *talabana* (peons' fees) one rupee every day. They grant guards to many of the taluqdars and mahajuns in the country, by which means we are prevented from collecting the King's revenues; and many inhabitants take shelter in the factories, and thereby avoid paying the rents. There is little chunam made within the distance of four days' journey from hence, the whole quantity made within the pargana not exceeding 2000 maunds. Notwithstanding, Mr Dobbins has established two factories within my pargana, committing every species of injury and oppression, and violating the women of the inhabitants, and erecting factories in places where none ever were before, drives away the inhabitants, and, upon the information of many people, he takes upon him to recover debts of five and ten years' standing."

The early records are full of reports about the Buzurgumedpúr pargana, and of petitions by its proprietors. Rajah Raj Ballab, who lived at Rajnagar, in the Mulfatganj thana, and was the most conspicuous native in the Dacca division in the middle of the last century, got possession of the pargana on the death of Aga Bákar. He had it measured in 1167 B.S. (A.D. 1759), and an assessment was made according to this measurement in the following year. Raj Ballab's history rather belongs to Dacca and Faridpúr than to Bákarganj, but I may

mention here that he held the office of *peshkar* of the *nowara* or fleet, and that he was also, I believe, the dewan of the Naib of Dacca. He was a Baidya by caste, but was of humble origin,[1] and only got into good society by dint of his wealth. He is said to have bought for the Baidyas the privilege of wearing the sacred thread. The buildings erected by him at Rajnagar have all been washed away by the Padma, but the large tank which he dug there is still in existence. He had seven sons. Kissen Dass, one of the seven, is famous as having been the person who fled to Calcutta in Surajah Daulah's time, and whom Governor Drake refused to give up—a refusal which led to the war between the Nawab and the English, and to the battle of Plassy. Kissen Dass escaped on this occasion only to die a violent death some years afterwards, for he and his father were seized by Mir Kassim and drowned in the Bhagireti at Monghyr.[2] Rajah Gopal Kissen, another son, thereon succeeded to the charge of the property. He died 24th Ashar 1194 B.S. (6th July 1787), and his son Pitambar Sein, and Raj Ballab's

[1] I believe it is correct that Raj Ballab was not of good family, but the evidence of the Serishtadar Mritanjai Mukti, when examined before Mr Thompson in the proceedings about Rajnagar on 20th September 1791, seems to show that Raj Ballab inherited some wealth, and was not altogether a self-made man. The Serishtadar's words are, "I have served in the zamindari from the age of fifteen or sixteen years, and am now sixty-two. My father served before me, in the time of Raj Ballab's father, and we were both employed as the head Serishtadars of the whole zamindari."

Raj Ballab is referred to by Orme, who says that he was the dewan of Nowazis. Nowazis died in 1756, and Raj Ballab's influence continued during the time of the widow, with whom Raj Ballab was said to be improperly intimate (Orme, vol. ii. p. 49).

[2] In a petition of Pitambar Sein, dated June 1798, he says, "We are the descendants of Maharajah Raj Ballab, who was a wellwisher of the Company, in consequence of which Kassim Ally Khan drowned him and his son Kissen Dass Bahadur in the Ganges, and having deputed Aka Reza, confiscated to the State his house and property."

other grandchildren, inherited the estate. They quarrelled among themselves, and in 1790 Mr George Thompson, assistant to the Collector of Dacca, was deputed to make a partition of Rajnagar and Buzurgumedpúr. It appears that the first application for the partition was made to the Civil Court by Kali Sankhar, one of the partners, that he got a decree in 1189 B.S. (1782) in the Dacca Court, and that this order was confirmed on appeal in Baisak 1194 B.S. (1787). Mr Day accordingly attached the parganas of Buzurgumedpúr, Rajnagar, and Kartikpúr Sujábád, but through the intrigues of Pitambar Sein, no partition was made until afterwards. Mr Thompson accomplished it. It was Gopal Kissen, the father of Pitambar, who appealed against the decree of division given by Mr Duncanson in the Dacca Court.

I have heard it said that Gopal Kissen had his cutchery at Sutaluri, near Jhalukátti.

It also appears that the munsiff, acting, I presume, under Mr Thompson's superintendence, was the authority who directly made the partition. The partition, however, generally goes by the name of Mr Thompson's Batwara; and he is stated in the official papers to have completed the partition of Rajnagar, &c., Buzurgumedpúr, &c., and Kartikpúr Sujábád on 2d May 1792. The estate was divided into five shares, and the five partners cast lots for their shares, the lots being drawn by two boys of the Bráhman caste, one of about ten years and the other of eight years. The engagement was made for eight years, ending 1799. As there was much jungle in Buzurgumedpúr, Mr Thompson did not measure the pargana, but only made a division of the revenue and rent of it. He also did not include the Sundarban lands, much of which was considered to be

part of Buzurgumedpúr, in the assessment, and therefore they were afterwards resumed by Government on the ground that they had not been included in the Decennial Settlement. In the original engagement the partners said as follows: "The Sundarban forest-lands, as well as the cane and reed jungle-lands appertaining to the pargana Buzurgumedpúr, our zamindari, not being included in the division now made between us, but continue as heretofore our joint property in equal shares, we therefore write and deposit this as our engagement that the duties and revenue forthcoming therefrom, and collections under the Mahal Bhashan Gorekátti, shall be divided and received by us severally in equal shares, and that the same mode of division shall be observed between us with regard to all revenue or profits to be derived from taluqdari grants made, or which may hereafter be made, of the aforesaid jungle-lands."

It appears from the record that there were three ranís or widows of Raj Ballab living at the time, and it was a stipulation of the partition that each of them should receive Rs.100 sicca monthly. The revenue payable by the zamindars, according to Mr Thompson's partition of 1792, was sicca Rs.181,107, 5 anas, and that payable to them from the taluqdars was *bhari* or *arcot* Rs.237,496, 8 anas, 17 gandas, equal to Rs.2,30436-14-3 sicca, Rs.7059,10-14 being deducted as batta. (The bhari or Company's arcot rupee was coined at Calcutta, and was in value $3\frac{1}{2}$ per cent. less than the sicca rupee.)

Mr Thompson received the thanks of Government for his work, but the zamindars complained that he had over-assessed them, and they were certainly never able to pay the revenue. Both Rajnagar and Buzurgumedpúr had suffered severely from the inundations of 1787, and it is probable that Mr Thompson did not make suffi-

cient allowance for this circumstance. There was also much controversy about the *nij* taluqs or private tenures held by each shareholder subordinate to the zamindari, and as the partners were at bitter enmity with one another, it is probable that their *zidd* and envy led to the over-assessment of each of them. Buzurgumedpúr was a taluqdari mahal—*i.e.*, most of the land was held by taluqdars, and as the lands were not divided, to each shareholder in the zamindari was assigned one-fifth of the revenue of each taluq; and on the same principle each shareholder who held a taluq had to pay four-fifths of its revenue to his co-sharers.

Mr Thompson considered that he had discovered that a great fraud had been committed by Rajah Gopal Kissen when he was manager of the estate, in that he had reduced the assessment on the estate by Rs.17,500, and had then concealed the deficiency by adding to the paper assets of the estate Rs.17,500 as the proceeds of a sayer mahal which had formerly been abolished, and therefore could not really yield anything. The sayer mahal was called the *Phanri Malwa*, and seems to have been a transit duty, as the word *phanri* means a station or outpost, and is still in use to designate a police outpost. The discovery has been endorsed by Mr Sutherland in his description of Bákarganj, but Mr Douglas's letter of 6th April 1791 shows that there was another side to the question, and that probably Gopal Kissen had been authorised by the Government to make the deduction in the assessment.

In a petition from Pitambar Sein, the son of Gopal Kissen, and one of the parties to the batwara, there occurs the following significant allusion to Sir Elijah Impey: "Mr Hastings having inspected these [certain proceedings of the Superintendent of the Khalsa], referred

them to the decision of Sir Elijah Impey, the Judge of the Court of Appeal. The said Sir Elijah having received from me a considerable sum on account of commission, received my petition for the two parganas, and having issued his summons and *parwanas* in the Mofussil, investigated for a length of time the cause, and leaving his proceedings, departed for Europe without passing a decision on it."

Buzurgumedpúr soon fell into arrears, and it was no easy matter to recover them, although there was a *tahsildar* or native collector stationed at the *golabari* or zamindari cutchery of Buzurgumedpúr, near Bákarganj, for several years after the Permanent Settlement. This officer used to clear his balance in part by paying the salary of the Judge-Magistrate of Bákarganj, who in this way was saved the trouble and expense of sending to Dacca for money. In April 1801 the tahsildar reported that the buildings at the golabari had been destroyed by a storm, and in 1802 he reported that he had engaged spearmen at the rate of Rs.2-8 a month to protect the treasure against dacoits. On 16th November 1796 Mr Armstrong, the Collector of Dacca, reported that he had put up the pargana to sale by auction for three successive days, and for two hours each day, and that nobody had made a bid for it. This was in consequence of its consisting almost entirely of dependent taluqs. These taluqs were of the description called *Jangalburi* taluqs, and it appears from a letter of Government to the Board of Revenue (13th July 1821) that the rules about Jangalburi taluqs, contained in section 8 of Regulation 8 of 1793, had been framed with reference to this very pargana of Buzurgumedpúr. Jangalburi taluqs—*i.e.*, jangal-cutting taluqs—were generally granted on a rent-free tenure for a number of years, with a pro-

vision that thereafter the cultivation should be measured and assessed at certain rates specified in the lease. They were common in Buzurgumedpúr, because about three-fourths of the pargana were formerly Sundarban jangal, and could only be cleared by the granting of improving leases with a condition of permanency. Under the Government orders of 10th October 1799, Mr Massie, the successor of Mr Armstrong, bought in for Government in November of that year the whole pargana of Buzurgumedpúr (see his letter, 29th November 1799), and Government has ever since been the zamindar of the pargana. Government was, of course, the creditor at whose instance the estate was brought to the hammer, and all that it paid for the acquisition was the nominal price of one rupee.

The sale of the zamindari was followed in 1801 by the sale of the dependent taluqs. There were then 594 of them (28th November 1801). There are now 407. It had been held by Government (Resolution of Governor-General of 31st December 1790), and afterwards declared by law (Regulation 8 of 1793), that Jangalburi taluqs were not entitled to separation. When, however, Government acquired the zamindari, it was found expedient to allow the separation of the taluqs, as in that way the expense of collecting the rents was saved, and also the arrears were more speedily and regularly collected. In making the separations the Board adhered to the rentals shown in Mr Thompson's Batwara papers; but a letter of Government, dated 13th July 1821, and written by the famous Holt Mackenzie, shows that Government by no means approved of this step, and also that the Board had exceeded their powers in granting the separations at all. "It appears to have been hitherto assumed," he writes, "that the rent demandable

by Government, on converting the taluqs into independent tenures, was necessarily to be fixed at the rate specified in the Batwara jama adjusted by Mr Thompson; but although that rate might justly be taken to show the amount demandable by the zamindar, and consequently by Government, until a fresh *Jamabandi* should be made, yet, unless in the case of taluqs holding under *mocurrari* tenures, it is not apparent why it should be assumed as constituting the ultimate limit of Government demand; and after the period fixed by Regulation 1 of 1801 for the separation of taluqs, no taluqdar could of course claim to become hazuri as a matter of right. Under these circumstances Government would be justified in annulling the whole of the separations made by the Board without reference to Government." He then adds that the great length of time, &c., prevented Government from taking this course. In 1799, the year of the sale of the pargana, the arrears due to Government were Rs.171,346; and so little had the sale improved matters, that the arrears had increased in 1801 to sicca Rs.386,574. It was then that the sale of the taluqs was resolved on. The separation, however, of the taluqs did not take place until several years after their sale, and was only accomplished gradually. A notification was issued on 27th January 1812, inviting all the Buzurgumedpúr taluqdars to become hazuri—*i.e.*, independent. It was after the experiment of khas management had been tried and had failed that separation was had resort to. There was great confusion in the accounts of Buzurgumedpúr when it was under khas or direct management; and indeed this might be anticipated, when we consider the extent of the collections, the fact that there was no Collector of Bákarganj at the time, and that the only control over the tahsildar was

situated so far off as Dacca. Kali Prasad was about the last Naib or tahsildar. He was guilty of embezzlement, and fled in December 1812 to his home in Birbhum, where he shortly afterwards died. He was succeeded by Radha Nath, who remained in charge till Asar 1219 (1813), when, in place of the direct mode of management, the taluqs were separated off, and the remainder of the estate was farmed. There is a full report by Mr Prinsep, the Legal Remembrancer, on the embezzlement and mismanagement in connection with Buzurgumedpúr, and in it he refers to the state of the Dacca Collectorate, and observes that "the state of the *amla* of Dacca has long been notorious" (24th March 1817). In 1822 the revenue of Buzurgumedpúr was sicca Rs.244,867; of this, Rs.217,295 were collected from the separated taluqs, and Rs.27,571 from the dependent tenures included in Tilak Chandra Rai's farm. This farm apparently consisted of such under-tenures, howalas, and the like, as were not considered entitled to separation, or the holders of which had not applied for it. It probably also contained any lands which had been the khas or direct property of the former zamindars, or which had been their nij or private taluqs. At present there are 407 separated taluqs, and their united revenue is Rs.265,895. Each of these taluqs bears a separate number on the Revenue Roll, and the holders of them pay in the revenue direct to Government. But besides these separated taluqs there are three mahals, or estates, belonging to Buzurgumedpúr, and numbered respectively on the Revenue Roll 1406, 1437, and 1447. No. 1406, which goes by the name of the farm or *izara*, contains a great many properties, and is apparently the portion of the pargana of which Government acquired the direct possession when it bought the pargana in 1799. There

is, however, some obscurity about its history, and I am not able to state positively that it is the property which was known in 1822 as Tilak Chandra Rai's izara. There is no doubt, however, that it corresponds to it in some measure.

There are in No. 1406 149 estates of which the revenues are permanently fixed, and there are 47 temporarily settled estates, or altogether there are 196 estates in No. 1406, each one of which ought to bear a distinct number in the Revenue Roll. Owing to this not having been done as yet, the full number of the estates in Bákarganj is not shown in the books, and the true amount of the work in the *Taujih* or Revenue Department is not exhibited. Of the 47 temporarily settled estates, four are ferries, so that they may be considered as relics of the old sayer duties. They have been leased for terms of years. They are the ferry on the Bishkháli (revenue, Rs.40); the Kumarkháli ferry, on the Nalchiti river (revenue, Rs.46); that between Bishkháli and Tulatuli (revenue, Rs.9); and that on the Srimantapúr. The total revenue annually derived from them is Rs.115. I once proposed to make them public ferries, and to transfer them to the Road Committee, but the proposal was negatived by the Commissioner. The 43 other temporarily settled estates are let in farm to various persons. No. 1437 is let to Mr Brown. It consists of resumed *chakran* or service lands, and is scattered over no less than 45 kismats or hamlets. It was bought at a sale for arrears of revenue in 1840. No. 1447, also called the Dari char, consists chiefly of resumptions. There were 77 estates in it, but there now only remain 28 temporarily settled estates, and 4 permanently settled estates. The rest have been sold.

The revenue of No. 1406 is Rs.29,413, and of this,

Rs.26,196 belong to the permanently settled estates, and Rs.3217 to those temporarily settled.

The revenue of No. 1447 is Rs.3935-4, of which Rs.3850 belong to the farm, and Rs.85-4 to the permanently settled estates.

It is reckoned that there are 431 estates in Buzurgumedpúr—viz., 407 separated, 11 khas mahals, and 2 zamindaries, Nos. 1406 and 1447. Altogether, and with inclusion of the revenue of No. 1437 (I do not know accurately its present rental), Buzurgumedpúr yields to Government in round numbers Rs.337,000 annually. It thus yields by far the largest revenue of any of the parganas. Large sums also were obtained when Government sold the khas mahals or Government estates belonging to it, and there still remain some to be sold.

Buzurgumedpúr is remarkable for the number and value of its taluqs. The most interesting as regards its origin is the taluq Padrian or Mission taluq of Sibpúr. It is said that it was originally granted by Raj Ballab Sein to some Christians from Bandel. The tradition is that he wanted to coerce his tenantry, who were inclined to be disobedient to him, and that he judged that Christians would be well fitted for the purpose, as mere contact with them would be sufficient to destroy the ryots' caste, and that the latter would therefore gladly come to terms in order to avoid the visits of the Christian servants. He accordingly applied to the Portuguese Mission at Bandel for some Christians, and four were sent to him. They afterwards applied to him for a priest, in order to perform their religious ceremonies. He procured one from Bandel, and assigned him four pieces of land or howalas for his maintenance. The four Christians were put in charge of the property, but in consequence of their dissensions the howalas

were formed into a taluq, and made over to the priest in trust for the mission. The first priest was called Fray Raphael das Anjos, and the date of his *patta* or lease for the taluq was 9th Phalgun 1171 B.S., or A.D. 1764. In the decision of the Sadr Diwani Adâlat, dated 18th April 1856, it is said that the lease was granted by Rajah Pitambar Singh (Sein ?), zamindar of Arangábád, but from the date it appears more probable that the lease was granted, as is the tradition, by Pitambar's grandfather, Rajah Raj Ballab. It was renewed by Mr Thompson in 1790 or 1791, when he was making the partition of Raj Ballab's estates among Pitambar Sein and the other heirs. The first church at Sibpúr is said to have been built by one Pedro Gonsalves, but it has been superseded by a larger edifice built with money left by Domingo de Silva. The first priests were Augustinian monks; and they, acting in subordination to the Prior of Bandel and to the Bishop of Meliapore, from the year 1764 down to the year 1836, were in uninterrupted possession of the Sibpúr taluq, and administered the duties of priests of Sibpúr. But in 1836 an attempt was made to bring the exercise of the clerical office at Sibpúr and the management of the property thereto attached under the immediate control of the Vicar Apostolic, Dr St Leger, who, with a view to the organisation of the Roman Catholic hierarchy for the first time in Bengal, by the Pope's brief of 18th April 1834, had been appointed to that office. Dr St Leger dismissed Fray Jos das Neves, and appointed in his room Ignatius Xavier Mascarhenas to be the incumbent at Sibpúr, and this Mascarhenas managed to get himself substituted for Fray Jos das Neves as decree-holder in a rent suit, and so got possession of the taluq, &c., by a summary order of the Bákarganj Civil Court (S. D. A.

decision). The real fact, I believe, was that the Roman Catholic inhabitants of Sibpúr quarrelled with their pastor because he refused to perform the burial service for a parishioner who had died without making confession, and that, like true Bákarganj ryots, they placed themselves under the *zimba* or protection of Dr St Leger. In consequence of the quarrel the Sibpúr incumbent left the place, and for several years there was no service in the church. A protracted litigation followed on the appointment of Mascarhenas. The Portuguese priests sued for recovery of possession of the church and lands; and as Mr Loughnan, who was the Judge of Bákarganj, was a Roman Catholic, the suit was at his request transferred to the court of the judge of the twenty-four parganas. The Augustinians were successful both in that court and in the Sadr Diwani Adâlat, and the litigation ended in 1857 with their recovering possession of the taluq, and with their getting a decree for mesne profits, which, however, was not enforced. The decision of Mr Robert Torrens, the judge of the twenty-four parganas, dated 9th December 1847 (published in the decisions of the Zila Judges for that year), gives a full account of the suit. It states that the taluq had been in possession of Fray Raphael das Anjos previous to 1171 B.S. (1764), and that in that year, on the 9th Agrahan, the rent payable by him was reduced from Rs.2234-3 by Rs.533-3, making the yearly rent Rs.1701.[1] The patta was granted to Fray Raphael by Lakyi Narain Rai,[2] and after the death of the former, Pitambar Sein, the zamindar, confirmed the grant by a written

[1] The present rental is Rs.1761-8-10, being the equivalent in Government rupees of Rs. 1701 sicca.

[2] Lakyi Narain is a name of Vishnu, and was the name under which Rajah Raj Ballab recorded his zamindari of Rajnagar and Buzurgumedpúr.

declaration on 25th Phalgan 1198 to Fray Raphael's successor.

It also appears from Mr Torrens' decision that the first church was built by Pedro Gonsalves, and that afterwards, in accordance with the will of Domingo de Silva, his son Manuel pulled down the old church and built in 1823 the present enlarged edifice, which the De Silva family have continued to repair (see also decision of 31st December 1853). Since the termination of the litigation, the Sibpúr incumbent has been appointed by the Archbishop of Goa. The revenue of the taluq used to be paid to the zamindar of Buzurgumedpúr, but in 1808 it was separated, and made an independent taluq. The agreement with the Collector, dated 1215 B.S., and stipulating for payment of revenue in eight instalments, is in the Collector's record-room. The taluq yields a profit of about Rs.700 or Rs.800, which are spent in supporting the mission. The priest also receives the fees on marriages, funerals, &c.; and these, I believe, amount to a considerable sum. Sibpúr was once a very flourishing place, and there are the remains of many large houses in it. It is situated on the Srimantapúr khál, and is about five miles from Bákarganj, with which it is connected by a road (now in disrepair), in which there are several masonry bridges. Its prosperity was owing to the rice and betel-nut trade, but now Bákarganj and Kaliganj have taken its place. The most conspicuous resident of Sibpúr was Domingo de Silva, who made a large fortune in the rice trade. He came to Sibpúr (I believe from Goa) at the end of the last century, and died in 1821. By his will, dated 7th October 1821, he left money for the building of the church, and also ordered that Rs.500 should be distributed in charity every year on the anniversary of his

death (21st November 1821) to poor Christians and needy and helpless orphans, "together with such poor, be they Mahomedans or Hindoos, as may be present on that day" (at Sibpúr).

The charity still exists, and the money is paid to the priest by the Administrator-General of the High Court. The existence of the charity is well known to the faqirs and the rest of the begging population of Bákarganj, and they flock down to Sibpúr on the appointed day.

The Feringhies of Sibpúr, as they are called, are less numerous and less prosperous than they were half a century ago. They support themselves chiefly by going about to Mahomedan marriages and firing off *feux de joie*. They are also employed by the villagers to kill pigs, and some hold appointments in the police. They are indisposed to agriculture or other regular industry, and they are about as ignorant and superstitious as their Bengali neighbours. The only thing for which I can heartily praise them is the great neatness and cleanliness of their homesteads. Probably, however, the want of cattle or agricultural implements has something to do with this. They have adopted the Eastern notions about the seclusion of women, and do not like to give their daughters any education. Their numbers are about 800—the census giving 785 Christians in Bákarganj, and 43 in Mirzaganj. Sibpúr is by far the largest settlement; but there are a few families at Kalada, also in the Bákarganj thana, and at Maitbhanga in the Mirzaganj thana.

The largest taluq in Buzurgumedpúr is that called joár Ramna-Bamna, which is now in possession of the Bamna Chaudries. The revenue is Rs.19,487-10-8. It is situated on the west bank of the Bishkháli river, in the subdivision of Perozpúr, contains forty-three villages,

and is very profitable. It was originally entered in the name of an Armenian named Khajah Michael, and is described in the old records as Mudafat Khajah Michael. One Mahomed Shuffee, the ancestor of the present proprietors, got a settlement of the taluq from the Board in 1809. The popular tradition is that he was originally only a salt-piada, and this is supported by the fact of his being styled in the official papers Mahomed Shuffee Jamadar. At the time of Mr Thompson's Batwara the land was waste, and was entered as Mudafat Khajah Michael. It seems to have been originally included in pargana Shahzádpúr, six anas of which were transferred to Buzurgumedpúr (see Mr Battye's letter of 19th February 1807). The property was at one time in the possession of one Sadasib Mozamdar, who was Naib of the former zamindar of Buzurgumedpúr. Sadasib's sons disputed Mahomed Shuffee's claim to it, and said that he was only *ausat* taluqdar, and that their father held a patta for it, given in 1188 by Rajah Lakyi Narain Rai. They, however, lost their cause; and Mahomed Shuffee got the settlement on the ground of his former possession, which, it appears, dated as far back as 1202 (1795). The settlement made with him in 1809 was for seven years, and the annual rent was Rs. 1165.

The leading taluqdars in Buzurgumedpúr are the Rahamatpúr Chakrabarties, the Narainpúr Chakrabarties, Khajah Ahsanoolah, Rassik Chandra Newgi, Chandra Kanth Mukharjya of Bara Mozamdar, the Messrs Brown, who own a taluq with the curious name of Bagdeshwar (a mistake for Balthazar) Johannes, Prosunno Kumar Sein, the Ghosal family, Thomas Gomez, the De Silvas, Bhagabati Debya, the heirs of Dr Clement of Dacca, the Banarjis of Koulipara.

One Ainaddin Sikdar, who lived at Chamta, near Niamati, and was a notorious dacoit, had taluqs in Buzurgumedpúr. In 1789 he was banished, and his property confiscated. There is extant a vast amount of correspondence about this man's property, and about that of Mahomed Hayat, which was confiscated under similar circumstances. It was found very difficult to discover their properties, as the zamindars did their best to conceal them; but eventually some were found, and were gradually disposed of by sale.[1]

The most remarkable incident in the history of Buzurgumedpúr is perhaps that by which many thousand acres of land in it were given away in perpetuity for a quit-rent of Rs.372 a year. I refer to the famous grant of the villages of Aila Tearkháli and Phuljhuri, which led to a long litigation between Government and the purchaser from the original grantee, and which terminated adversely to Government on 26th January 1870, by the Privy Council's upholding the decree of the High Court.

The first mention of the lease occurs in a letter dated 18th March 1805, sent by Mr J. Battye, Collector of Dacca, to the Board of Revenue, and in which he forwards a copy and translation of a petition from one Ram Dhan Chattarji applying for a taluqdari lease of some jungle-lands in Buzurgumedpúr. Ram Dhan Chattarji applied for a rent-free grant for seven years, and offered to pay afterwards a fixed rent of Rs.349 sicca. He described the villages as Aila Tearkháli and Phuljhuri, and gave a specification of their boundaries. Mr Battye, in forwarding the application, said that the offer was

[1] For a full report about these taluqs, see Mr Massie's report, 19th August 1800. A full report on Buzurgumedpúr generally will be found in a letter of Mr Collector Phillips of 20th December 1822.

the highest among those which he had received, and that the land had not been included in Mr Thompson's partition of the pargana; and that from the information he had been able to gather through his officers, the land did not appear to be able, when brought into a state of cultivation, to bear a much higher assessment. Unfortunately, Mr Battye depended for his information on the Naib of Buzurgumedpúr, who was, it seems, the real applicant for the lease, Ram Dhan Chattarji being merely a *benamidar*. The Board sanctioned the proposal (with the authorisation of the Governor-General) on 9th April 1805, and on the 17th idem Ram Dhan executed the necessary engagements and was put into possession (Mr Bird's letter, 5th November 1807).

One Surjya Narain Bannarji, who had also applied for the lease, petitioned Mr Battye and Mr Fortescue his successor, alleging that the Naib of Buzurgumedpúr had himself obtained the pottah in Ram Dhan's name, and that the Naib had accepted his (Surjya Narain's) petition, and promised to report it to the Collector, but had afterwards not done so. Mr Bird, the Collector, adds that "repeated parwanahs were issued to the Naib in consequence of Surjya Narain's petitions, but that the Naib had denied every charge." Mr Bird trusted, therefore, that the Board would deem Surjya Narain's petition worthy of no further consideration! It appears from a report of Mr Hunter, dated 5th August 1818, that two other persons—namely, Ram Rattan Bosu and Chandra Sekhar—petitioned the Collector of Dacca, and made the same allegations against the Naib. The name of the Naib was Kali Prasad Mozamdar, and it appears that there were certain sums which he had not accounted for, and that the petitioners alleged that Kali Prasad had spent the money in cultivating the

jungle-lands, and offered to prove this by the evidence of Domingo de Silva, Mahomed Shaffi, and others. However, says Mr Hunter, no final orders appear to have been passed on these petitions, nor was any investigation made into the truth of the assertions. Ram Dhan's lease was dated 6th Baisak 1212, and the agreement was that he should begin to pay rent from 1219. On 14th Chait 1213, however, he sold his rights to Nand Kumar Rai Sarm *alias* Ganga Nand Rai Sarm, alleging that he was unable to cultivate the land. Ram Dhan's name was struck out in 1216 B.S. Nand Kumar was the Naib's brother, and he purchased the property from Ram Dhan in the name of Krishna Govind Charan Rai, and the transfer in the Collector's books was made in this name. The name Krishna Govind Charan Rai was said by the petitioners to be a junction of two names—namely, Krishna Kishor Rai, the son of Kali Prasad, and Govind Charan, the son of his brother Nand Kumar. Kali Prasad, as we have already seen, took flight in order to escape arrest, and his brother, Nand Kumar, afterwards sold Aila Phuljhuri to Hafizoolah of Dacca, who, I believe, was the grand-uncle of Khajah Abdul Ghani, for Rs.21,000 on 27th Chait 1219, or 8th April 1812. Mr Hunter goes on to observe, "The strongest presumption may be formed that Kali Prasad [the Naib] was the real proprietor of the taluqs until his death, as the transfer of it in 1216 to Krishna Govind Charan Rai, the son and nephew, proves. It must, in fact, have been only a deception, he being well aware that claims would be brought against him for the balance of his unaudited accounts of 1214–15, and that it would be an easy matter to prove at that time that the original jangalburi patta was *benami*, although now, from the lapse of time and late

transfer of records, as well as change of *amla*, I am much puzzled to get at the real state of the case. This is corroborated by Nand Kumar Rai, his brother's, subsequent sale of the property without explaining in his *kawala* (deed of sale) further than that the taluq is his benami, Kissen Govind Charan Rai. I have not a doubt, though I might find it difficult to prove in a court of justice, that Hafizoolah was well aware of the impending cloud over the heirs of Kali Prashad at the time he bought the taluq, as he is an inhabitant of Dacca, and a landholder and *mahajan* in that zilla."

Mr Hunter's object in writing this report was to make Hafizoolah, as owner of Aila Phuljhuri, responsible for the amount which might be decreed against the Naib's heirs in a suit which Government had brought against them for embezzlement, and which was valued at upwards of Rs.70,000. I do not know what steps were taken on this letter, but it is curious that no attempt appears to have been made by Government to impeach the original patta on the ground of fraud. Hafizoolah afterwards granted three anas of the land to Mir Gholam Imam of Shaistábád, and the estate is now held by Khajah Ahsanoolah and the Mirs of Shaistábád. It is a very large and valuable property, and is said to yield Khajah Ahsanoolah a profit of about one lac of rupees. The question in the suit between Government and the proprietors turned on the construction of the boundaries stated in the patta of Ram Dhan Chattarji. These consisted of rivers, and it was not easy to say what was meant by the terms used. The litigation began as early as 1830. In the latter stages of the proceedings the Government abandoned all claim to the resumption of Phuljhuri, as the boundaries given of it in the patta were precise and indisputable. The con-

test thus became confined to Aila Tearkháli, and the great question about it was the determination of the western boundary. Khajah Abdul Ghani claimed under his patta not only Phuljhuri and Aila Tearkháli, but also three *chucks* or plots called Dhallooa, Bargona, and Naltona, and which lay to the south of Phuljhuri and Aila. His contention was that his boundary went down to the sea. He instituted a suit for the recovery of the possession of these three southern chucks in 1857. Afterwards, in 1860, he was dispossessed from chucks Aila and Phuljhuri by Mr Reilly, the Commissioner of the Sundarbans, who resumed them, and whose proceedings were confirmed by the Commissioner of Nadiya in the following year. After the resumption, Mr Reilly made a settlement with the ryots, and appointed the Messrs Morrell tahsildars or collectors on a commission of twenty-five per cent. Khajah Abdul Ghani then instituted a suit for the recovery of possession of Aila and Phuljhuri, and this suit and that instituted in 1857 were tried together, as both were based on Ram Dhan Chattarji's patta. The suit for the three southern chucks was dismissed by the High Court, and that for the Aila and Phuljhuri chucks decreed, and these orders were upheld on appeal to the Privy Council. Afterwards, Khajah Abdul Ghani instituted a suit for recovery of mesne profits, and this was compromised in May 1871 by Government's paying him the sum of Rs.272,348. In addition to this I believe that Khajah Abdul Ghani indirectly profited by his dispossession, owing to the howaladars and other under-tenure holders on the estate giving him an increase of rent on his recovering possession, and I believe that the increase was given in the shape of an extra rupee of rent on each kani of land held by them. This was given by them in acknow-

ledgment of Khajah Abdul Ghani's services in fighting their and his battle in the courts, for thirteen years, in India and in England; for when he was dispossessed the under-tenure holders were dispossessed also, the settlement being made by the revenue authorities with the *karsadars* or simple cultivators. When therefore Khajah Abdul Ghani was restored to possession, the under-tenure holders were restored also, and that without their having borne the expense of the litigation.

Khajah Abdul Ghani, or rather his son, Ahsanoolah, in whose name the property is now entered, has a cutchery at Phuljhuri, which is a bazár, and is also the seat of a police outpost, subordinate to the station at Gúlsakháli. Phuljhuri is a place of some trade, as sundari wood is brought there for sale. It is reputed to be the place where the first clearing in the Bákarganj Sundarbans was effected. There is no doubt that the grant of the Aila Phuljhuri lease to Ram Dhan Chattarji was most improvident, and deprived Government of a very large revenue. It may be thought that it at least had the good effect of encouraging cultivation, and that the public have been in this way indemnified in some degree for the loss of revenue. However, whatever has been the result in subsequent years, it appears that the grant did not for a long time give an impetus to cultivation, but rather was a hindrance to it. The very magnitude of the grant prevented cultivation, for there was too much land to be managed by one lessee, and the vagueness of the boundaries, &c., deterred other cultivators from settling in the neighbourhood. It is true Aila Phuljhuri is well cultivated now, but so also is Ramna-Bamna, which pays a considerable revenue to Government. On 16th December 1818 Mr Hunter reports that "the two mozahs, or, more properly, girds

of Aila Tearkháli and Phuljhuri are almost entirely jungle. A portion of Phuljhuri is at present in a state of cultivation, the produce of which would, even now, admit of an increase of revenue in a quadruple proportion, and the cultivation is at present being extended. Aila Tearkháli is so extensive that it occupied me more than a tide to pass it on the east side; if it were all cultivated, which I have reason to suppose it capable of being, the revenue derivable from it would be very considerable; but at present no person will commence on the cultivation while the pattadar holds it along with Phuljhuri, from the fear of being dispossessed by him." In a letter written one day previously, Mr Hunter had said that he had visited Ramna-Bamna, and had found only a very small portion of it under cultivation. On 20th December 1822 Mr Phillips writes, that if the whole tract of Aila Phuljhuri were brought into cultivation it might yield Rs.25,000. The revenue received by Government for it is Rs.372-4, this being the equivalent in Government rupees of the Rs.349 sicca. There is a market at Aila, and endeavours have lately been made to establish a *mela* or fair.

### 4. Selímábád.

This is a very large pargana. It comprises most of the land in the west central part of the district, and even extends across the Baleshwar into the Baghahát subdivision of the Jessore district. According to Professor Blochmann, this pargana was originally called Sulaimánabád, after Sulaiman Shah of Bengal, and he suggests that the name may have been changed to Selímábád in honour of Akbar's son, Prince Selim, afterwards known as Emperor Jahángír. I have, how-

ever, never seen it designated by any other name than Selímábád. It belonged to sarkár Fathábád.

Its history is given by Mr Collector Thompson in a report to the Board, dated 28th December 1793. He states that the whole pargana was taken possession of by Aga Bákar at the time he was *wadadar* or farmer of it. In 1156 B.S. the dispossessed proprietors complained to the Subah, and were restored to $4\frac{1}{2}$ anas of it. This $4\frac{1}{2}$ anas were some time afterwards divided into ten shares. Aga Bákar remained in possession of $11\frac{1}{2}$ anas till 1160 B.S., when he was put to death for rebellion, and Rajah Raj Ballab was appointed to attach his property. Rajah Raj Ballab managed to retain possession of the $11\frac{1}{2}$ anas up to 1164 B.S., when Sheo Narain, a son of Jai Narain, one of the original proprietors, recovered the estate in the time of Mr Verelst. Sheo Narain was assisted by the influence of Gokal Chandra Ghosal, Dewan of the Provincial Council of Chittagong, to whom, as a reward for his services, Sheo Narain gave half of the recovered property—*i.e.*, 5 anas 15 gondas. This share was entered in the name of Bhowani Charan, which is said to have been the esoteric or astrological name of Gokal Ghosal (Massie, 12th April A.D. 1798), and the $11\frac{1}{2}$ anas were held by him and Sheo Narain jointly till 1179 B.S., when at their request a partition was made by Mr Barwell, who was then Chief of Dacca. A copy of the partition papers, dated 1180 B.S., exists in the Bákarganj Collectorate. In Grant's "Analysis," Selímábád is described as belonging to Jai Narain, Bhowani Charan, and others in 1170 B.S., and as consisting of four zamindaries bearing a revenue of Rs.40,190. On 14th January 1791 Mr Douglas refers to the decline in the assets of the pargana, and states that this was chiefly owing to the misconduct of Bhowani

Charan, who used to live in Calcutta and let the office of his agent or land-steward to the highest bidder. Thus there had been as many as four *gomastas* or agents in one year. Gokal Ghosal, as I find from an elaborate report of Mr Money, dated 2d September 1847, died in 1779, or 1186 B.S., and ten years afterwards—namely, on 6th July 1789—his share was sold for a private debt under a decree of court, and bought by Kashi Nath Chaudhari for Rs.29,100. Kashi Nath, however, was merely the ostensible purchaser, the real buyers being the Ghosal family. A few years before this, Sheo Narain had fallen into arrears, and one-half of his share, or 2 anas 17½ gandas, was bought by Jai Narain Ghosal in the name of his son, Kali Sankhar. This was in 1189 B.S. In 1796 Kashi Nath's share was sold by a decree of the Supreme Court to Rajah Raj Kissen, and ten years afterwards his son, Noba Kissen, resold it to Kali Sankhar Ghosal. Thus the Ghosal family became possessed of 8 anas 12½ gandas 2 krants of the whole pargana—namely, 5 anas 15 gandas, and 2 anas 17 gandas 2 krants—and these shares they still retain. They reside at Bhukoilas, near Calcutta, and have enjoyed the title of Rajah from the time of Kali Sankhar Ghosal, who was made a Rajah and a Bahadur in 1825 (Government letter, 15th July 1825). The Ghosal family were famous for many years for the excellent way in which they kept their accounts, and for the quietness with which they managed their zamindari. They never were in the criminal court, and they collected their rents chiefly through the Collector's office (Act 10 of 1859). They are still reported to be easy landlords, but dissensions have broken out among them, and their affairs are now in the hands of a receiver. One of their ancestors, I believe, left a will, or made some

other arrangement to prevent that subdivision of property among heirs which has pulverised so many large estates. Their head cutchery or office is at Jhalukátti, about twelve miles west of Barisál. Rajah Satya Charan Ghosal built three houses there, laid out some gardens, and made some roads through and near the bazár. It was in consequence, I presume, of these improvements that Jhalukátti, which literally means the clearing of the fisherman, received the more dignified appellation of Maharajganj. Jhalukátti is one of the largest marts in the district, and is the seat of most of the wood trade.

The descendants of Jai Narain live at Raikátti, in thana Perozpúr, about four miles from the subdivisional headquarters. The name Raikátti means literally the clearing of the Raies, and points to a time when the country was covered with jungle. According to tradition, one Satrujit Rai, an inhabitant of Deganga, near Calcutta, was the founder of the family. The goddess Sidheshwari is said to have appeared to him in a dream and directed him to proceed to Selímábád and settle there. The family is one of the oldest in the district, and there is a Sanskrit inscription on a temple of Kali at Raikátti to the effect that the idol was set up by Radu Narain Rai in 1050 B.S., that the temple for it was erected in 1144 B.S., and that Jai Narain Rai inaugurated it on 30th Paus 1162 B.S.

Selímábád was at one time a chief seat of salt manufacture, and on this account much of it lay waste. In the Ninth Report of the Committee of the House of Commons, dated 25th June 1783, it is stated that an Armenian merchant, named Khaja Kaworke, had the salt farm of Selímábád in 1773. In 1774 Mr Barwell, the Chief of Dacca, held the salt estates of Selímábád.

He relet them to Khaja Kaworke in consideration of a present; for this he was censured by the Court of Directors. The collections of Selímábád gave the Government officers much trouble for many years. On 20th June 1792 the Governor-General ordered the whole zamindari to be held khas—*i.e.*, to be managed directly by Government officers. The arrears of land revenue were borne on the books of the Dacca Collectorate for a long time, and were even transferred to Bákarganj when it was made a district in 1817. Thirty years afterwards Mr Money wrote a long report about them, and suggested that they should be realised from the Ghosal family.

The present revenue of Selímábád is Rs.98,227, of which Rs.59,982-2-6½ are paid by the Ghosal family. The remainder is divided among fourteen sets of shareholders, some of whom reside in Jessore. The Ghosals are Bráhmans and the Raies of Raikátti are Kayasts, and among the most respectable of that caste. The most prominent members of the Raikátti family are Raj Kumar Rai, and the two brothers Madhab Narain and Nar Narain. Madhab Narain is a gentleman of considerable ability, and is possessed of a good estate, though I believe he does not hold a bigha of land in his own name. Nar Narain has distinguished himself as an author, and as the supporter of an Anglo-vernacular school at Raikátti. His wife also has published some poems. Nowhere is the benami principle carried out further than at Raikátti, nearly all of the shareholders holding their lands in the names of their servants and relatives. This is owing to most of them being in debt. Among the principal taluqdars in Selímábád are Prosunno Kumar Sein of Kirttipásha, near Jhalukátti, who is also a small shareholder in the par-

gana ; the Mahullanavises of Basanda, where they have a large school ; the Biswases of Jalabari, and the Datts of Amrajhuri. Prosunno Kumar Sein's ancestor was the Dewan or Naib of Satrujit Rai, and the Mahullanavises were formerly servants of his family. Most of Selímábád is now highly cultivated, and produces much rice, supari, and pán. It lies chiefly in thanas Jhalukátti, Surapkátti, and Perozpúr. One of the most important places in it is Banaripara, which, with the neighbouring villages of Gabha, &c., is inhabited by numbers of Kulin Kayasts, such as the Thakurtas, the Guhas, &c. The land measure in general use is the bigha. The nal is small, being only five cubits, but these cubits are more than eighteen inches long, for the nal is equal to eight feet seven and a half inches. Twenty nals by twenty make one bigha, which is equal to about two bighas and one katha of the standard bigha measurement. The same measurement appears to be in use in Arangpúr, Kotwalipara, and Telihati.

### 5. Tappa Havili Selímábád.

This is a small pargana, lying chiefly in thana Nalchiti, and has evidently been formed out of pargana Selímábád. The word *havili* implies that the tract was the stipendiary or demesne land of the zamindar—that is, it was the land appropriated to his own use. It thus corresponds to the word *nankar*, which literally means bread-making. It is a peculiarity of this pargana that it consists of seven anas instead of sixteen. The other nine anas have been included in Selímábád, as is shown by the partition papers of 1180 B.S., already referred to. Four anas out of the seven belong to Khajah Ahsanoolah, and the remainder to the Panabalia Chaudharies and

others. Panabalia is a little below Nalchiti, and was formerly the headquarters of the zamindar of the pargana. The Sugandha or Sunda river is said to have flowed past it in old times, and hence a village in the neighbourhood bears the name of Sundarkúl or shore of the Sunda. There is an ancient image of Siva at Shamrail, near Panabalia, and it is fabled that Bhagabati's finger fell here. The Panabalia Chaudharies belong to an old Baidya family, but they are now in impoverished circumstances, and, moreover, the different members are at enmity with one another. The pargana of Syedpúr is said to have been formerly included in Havili Selímábád, and to have been separated from it through the influence of Bhagirath Singh, who was a kanungo. Gupta Chaudhari was the first zamindar. His son Ram Bhadra Rai is said to have fought with the Mahrattas or Bargis, and to have defeated them near Panabalia. Curiously enough there is an entry in Mr Long's Selections under date 1748, that the city of Dacca was much alarmed on account of the approach of the Mahrattas, who were coming by the Sundarbans, and had advanced as far as Sundarkúl.

### 6. Tappa Havili.

This small pargana appears also to have been formed out of Selímábád. Its lands lie, I believe, in thanas Nalchiti and Bákarganj. It is divided into two shares, a ten-ana and a six-ana. The ten-ana share is possessed by Asmat Ali Khan and Fazal Ali Khan of Charamadi, and by the Ghoses of Bakai; also by the Bosus of Bamrail. The six-ana share belongs to the Charamadi family above noted, and to some Bráhmans of Pinglakátti, in Gournadi thana.

## 7. Idilpúr.

Professor Blochmann states that the real name of this pargana is Adilpúr, from *adil*, "just." It is one of the four parganas originally included in sarkár Bákla. In Grant it is described as having belonged in 1170 B.S. (1764) to one Ram Ballab, as situated at the confluence of the Ganges and Meghna, and as consisting of three zamindaries and eight mahals. The revenue was Rs.106,270. Perhaps no pargana gave more trouble to the early collectors than Idilpúr. The Chaudharies of Idilpúr, as they were called, were Hindus of the Kayast caste, and did not bear a good character, as they were accused of harbouring dacoits. Doubtless the jungly condition of the pargana encouraged bad characters to resort to it.

On 23d June 1795, Mr Armstrong writes: "In the Bengal year 1184, during the existence of the Provincial Councils of Revenue, the settlement of Idilpúr was adjusted and jama fixed at Rs.83,506. Some animosities, however, taking place, the proprietors tendered up a *darkhast* to the Council, requesting their estate might be divided. An amín was accordingly deputed, the estate divided, and they entered into separate engagements for the payment of their revenue at the rate of Rs.81,115, on which terms they continued holding it until the year 1188, when, declining it, it was given in farm to Manik Bosu for seven years. In 1195 it was held khas and fell in balance Rs.30,541. In 1196 the assessment was reduced to Rs.80,000, and the Chaudharies again undertook the management of it, but finding it was not equal to the payment of such a high revenue, relinquished it at the close of the year. In

1197 it was accordingly held khas, when the collections did not exceed Rs.63,346, out of which the sezawal's salary (Rs.2640) and the zamindar's mashahara (Rs.5936) being deducted, the net collections appear to be Rs.54,769. In the year following the taluqdars were separated at Rs.13,547-2-13 (which the zamindars assert was only half what they used to pay before), which being deducted from what the estate yielded the preceding year (Rs.63,346), the remainder is Rs.49,798-13." The Chaudharies did not accept the terms offered to them at the Decennial Settlement, and afterwards, when the estate was sold for arrears of revenue, they made this a ground of appeal. The pargana was held khas at various times, but this did not much mend matters. There is a long report on the pargana by Mr Armstrong, dated 9th February 1797. He ascribes the balances to encroachment of the river (the pargana lies chiefly in the Mendiganj thana, on the west bank of the Meghna), contumacy of the Chaudharies, and interference of the Civil Court. Another reason, probably more powerful than any other, was that many chars had formed in the Meghna, and that the ryots had deserted the mainland for them. "The land of the pargana is high, and as there are few kháls in it, the soil is no longer fertile." I think it proper to observe here that it is precisely the highest and most valuable lands which suffer most from river action in Bákarganj. *A priori* it might be supposed that the low lands would suffer most, but this is not so; for the evil done by the rivers is not the mere overflowing of the land, which in a rice country, and where there are so many kháls and other channels to carry off the water, is not of so much consequence, but the carrying away of the land bodily. A high bank

is always the sign of diluviation, for there the stream runs deepest and strongest, and therefore cuts away the land most, while on the shallow side its force is broken by the shoals. This is well known to native boatmen, who, in towing or rowing up against the stream, always prefer the side of the river where the bank is low.

Mr Armstrong goes on to say, "The ryots of the high land pay twelve rupees a kani (1645 square yards), which seldom produces more than ten maunds of grain, and the land takes much trouble to cultivate, not only from its being a hard soil, but from the prevalence of underwood and jungle. The low land, on the contrary, is easily cultivated. The first year the ryot pays nothing, the second only one rupee, the third two rupees, the fourth three rupees, and the fifth the full jama, which only amounts to four rupees per kani, which, after the third year's cultivation, always produces twenty maunds of paddy. The consequence of which has been that, instead of the pargana's being in the flourishing state of cultivation it was in in 1177 B.S. (1770), when the sezawal realised in it one lac and sixteen thousand rupees, the lands have been neglected, the ryots have deserted, and the pargana has become in many parts an impenetrable jungle, and its cultivation reduced to one-eighth. . . .

"The great plenty which has been felt in the pargana these last three years, and particularly in the present, has also affected the realisation of the revenue in a very great degree. Paddy that used to sell for three maunds the rupee, and then considered very cheap, now sells for eight maunds the rupee, eighty-two sicca weight. Red pepper that used before to bring two and a half, and sometimes three rupees per maund, now is so plentiful as not to pay for the expense of bringing it in, and

when sold never yields more than eight or ten anas a maund. Molasses that formerly sold from four to seven rupees per maund, is now sold for one rupee, and sometimes twelve anas." In a letter of 20th December 1796, the Collector says that if the river does not take a turn, no part of Idilpúr pargana will be left in two years, and also reports that there is a plague in the pargana which carries off hundreds of the inhabitants daily.

This plague is also referred to in the letter of 9th February above quoted. Mr Armstrong writes, "The mortality has likewise been of infinite injury to the welfare of the pargana. In the house of Sarbeshwar Pal, in particular, a grain merchant, who by his trade has supported many of the poor families, seventeen lives were lost in the space of eleven days; and I make no doubt, from the account I have received, that 400 or 500 lives have already fallen a sacrifice to the plague, which is not yet subsided."

I do not know if these explanations proved satisfactory, but I am afraid that Mr Armstrong was not very successful in such matters. In another letter he writes that the sentiments expressed by the Governor-General concerning him have weighed heavy on his peace of mind, and concludes a long letter by begging the Board to have the goodness to make allowances for a mind not at ease, from the idea of having risked the censure of the Governor-General in Council as well as of the Board. He appears to have been superseded by an officer of a different stamp (Mr Massie). In 1198 B.S.—*i.e.*, at the time of the Novennial Settlement—Ram Ballab Rai, Kista Ballab Rai, and Nar Sing Rai were among the principal proprietors. In a report dated August 1797, it is stated that the pargana is subdivided into nine

distinct shares, and that there are numerous partners in each of them.

The Board instituted a suit against the Chaudharies for the arrears due by them, and gained a decree. Afterwards, in July 1804, the Board ordered the Chaudharies to be put in possession of their estate, they having agreed to pay up the arrears within ten years from the beginning of 1214 B.S. Here we appear to have an instance of the authorities trying to bolster up the old families; but the experiment failed, and in 1812 the zamindari was put up to sale, and bought by Mohini Mohan Tagore, in whose family it still remains.

The revenue is Rs.65,904-4-11, but there are also 119 independent taluqs, the revenue of which is Rs.8637. The revenue of the zamindari is still paid into the Bákarganj treasury, but a considerable part of the pargana has been transferred along with the Burirhát outpost to Faridpúr. Serious affrays took place in 1815 between the auction purchaser and the old proprietors. Such contests are, or at least were, frequent in Bákarganj on the occasion of any large property's changing hands; and as a general rule, it is the *mazul* or old proprietors who are in fault, as they try by force or fraud to deprive the purchaser of his legal rights. However, it would appear from Mr Sage, the Magistrate's, letter of 23d September 1815, that in the case of Idilpúr the auction purchaser was to blame. The Naib of Mohini Mohan Thakur found that some lands claimed by the Nawab of Dacca as a jaghir had been let to the taluqdars, and he tried to get hold of them. An affray, in which a man was killed, took place on 8th September 1815. At that time the pargana was under the district known by the name of the City of Dacca; and it was on account of such affrays, and of

the difficulty of managing the pargana from a place so distant, that it was transferred to the Bákarganj magistracy.

The portion of Idilpúr which remains in Bákarganj lies chiefly, if nót entirely, in the Mendiganj thana. It is a well-wooded pargana, and the land is high and well adapted for riding over. It suffers from the want of kháls, and there are as yet no made roads in it. The whole pargana being in the hands of one zamindar, he, or rather his agents (for he himself is an absentee) have considerable power, and the ryots are not forward with complaints. The thana is at present at Patarhát, although it has been proposed to remove it to Allyganj. There are a rural registrar's office and a bazár in Patarhát. The best *kós* boats are made in thana Mendiganj, near a place called Debaikháli. There is a large betel-nut cultivation in the pargana, and it also produces a few oranges. It was in Idilpúr that the copperplate inscription elsewhere referred to was discovered. There are some old villages in the pargana, and indications of forts and battles. There are many Bráhman families in Idilpúr.

### 8. Tappa Nazirpúr.

This pargana is described in one document as a tappa dependent on pargana Kasimnagar, sarkár Bazuha. Mr Douglas, on 27th May 1790, reported that there were thirteen claimants to this pargana—namely, the widow and legitimate son of Imamuddin, the late proprietor, and eleven illegitimate sons. It appears to have been held khas for several years.

Tappa Nazirpúr is somewhat scattered, part of it being in Gournadi and part in the south and east of

the district. This pargana or tappa is a very old one, and Professor Blochmann thinks that it is marked on the maps of De Barros and Blaev opposite the group of islands called the Don Manik Islands. I doubt, however, if this be the Bákarganj Nazirpúr, as the map seems to place it north of the city of Dacca. Char Kalmi, one of these islands, was claimed by the zamindars as part of Nazirpúr, and was afterwards settled by one of the family. Portions of Dakhin Shahbázpúr belong to Nazirpúr and to Ratandi Kalikapúr, which was formed out of it. There is a full report on the early history of Nazirpúr by Mr Massie, dated 6th December 1797. It was sold for arrears of revenue, and bought by the Tagore family in 1819. Fourteen-sixteenths were purchased then, and the remaining two-sixteenths were acquired by the Tagores by private purchase from Mr Panioty and others in 1830. The Tagore family are thus the largest zamindars in Bákarganj, as they hold two entire parganas (Idilpúr and Nazirpúr). Some interesting facts regarding Nazirpúr will be found in a Privy Council decision of March 1865 (Gopal Lal Thakur, appellant, Moore's Appeals, vol. x.) In 1704 (1111 B.S.) Syed Shamsuddin Mahomed was the zamindar; Syed Imamuddin Mahomed was his descendant, and died in 1785 (1192 B.S.) The family is now represented by Mir Mamtazuddin, who lives at Nalchira, where the old family mansion was. He is very poor, and the family has become degraded by misalliances contracted for the sake of gain, but it still enjoys some respect on account of its great antiquity. According to the family papers, Alfat Ghazi of Ghazipúr was the founder of the family. He was vizier of one of the Delhi emperors, and came to Dacca in the time of Jahangír. Possibly the old

village of Uzirpúr (the city of the vizier) is named after him. His son Syed Jan obtained the zamindari and settled at Tero char, and the grandson of Syed Jan removed the family residence to Nalchira. His name was Ainuddin, and he was succeeded by Shamsuddin, who created a taluq in his own name, which was afterwords bought by Mr Gill, grandfather of Mr Brown of Barisál. The zamindari was sold in the time of Shamsuddin's son Hoseinuddin.[1]

### 9. Ratandi Kalikapúr.

This pargana was formed in 1149 B.S. by a sanad from Aliverdi Khan. The sanad, a copy of which has been filed in a recent lawsuit, states that the pargana is formed out of Nazirpúr tappa and other places, that it is to be called Ratandi Kalikapúr, and that Krishna

[1] The name of Imamuddin figures in some complaints of the Provincial Council of Dacca against the proceedings of an attorney named Peat, who settled himself at Dacca, and used the processes of the Supreme Court against the zamindars. On 18th September 1777, Mr Rous and the other members of the Provincial Council wrote to the Governor-General (Warren Hastings) as follows: "For instance, the zamindar of Nazirpúr, which pays an annual revenue of about Rs.40,000, is seized by a warrant, in order to be carried away to Calcutta, at the instant he was proceeding to his lands to take measures for discharging the revenues for which he has bound himself. Thereby he may be absent for many months, the collections will be ill-conducted during the master's absence, the revenue of the Government will fall short, and at last his pargana is sold to make good the deficiency. It will be a poor compensation to the zamindar in the end to be informed that he was unjustly arrested."

Lall Rai, the zamindar of Uttar Shahbázpúr, had been arrested in like manner.

See "Observations upon the Administration of Justice in Bengal, occasioned by some late Proceedings at Dacca."

Imamuddin's petition is printed in an appendix to Judicial Papers for 1774 (India Office Library). He says, "Char Tengra Colla, under tappa Nazirpúr, formed by the inundation of the river, is in my possession, but is contested with me by Mahomed Radák, taluqdar of pargana Bangrora," &c.

Ram, the son of Ratneshwar (who thus gave his name to the pargana), is to be the chaudhari of it. It is stipulated that the zamindar shall pay the revenue (Rs.1777), treat the ryots well, assist in suppressing evil-disposed persons, root out dacoits and thieves, encourage the cultivation of the land, keep the roads and ghâts in good order, so that the public may travel about without impediment, prevent the drinking of intoxicants, and at the end of each year file his papers signed by himself and the kanungo. The kanungo also entered into a covenant that he would be security for the zamindar and cause his attendance when required, and that if the latter absconded he would take possession of the estate and collect the revenue, &c. The descendants of Krishna Ram reside at Uzirpúr, in the Gournadi thana, and still retain a share in the zamindari. They are much reduced in circumstances, and the greater part of the pargana has passed into the hands of other persons—viz., Sarup Chandra Guha, Brindaban Chakrabarti, Chandra Nath Sein (these three have five and a half anas), Abhai Charan Nazir of the Judge's Court, &c. As I have mentioned elsewhere, the family is said to be descended from Ram Mohan Mal, a servant of one of the Chandradwip Rajahs. It is one of the four old Hindu families in the district, the other three being the Chandradwip Rajahs, the Raikátti family, and the Arangpúr and Shaistanagar zamindars (Kalaskátti).

### 10. Uttar Shahbázpúr.

This pargana has suffered much from diluviation, and is now of small extent. It is situated chiefly in thana Mendiganj, but there are portions of it in the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. It is said to derive its name from

one Shahbáz Khan, a Mogul general in old times. A Shahbáz Khan Kumboo is mentioned in Stewart's "History of Bengal" as a general of Akbar, and as having been employed in the subjugation of Bengal; but Professor Blochmann informs me that the name Shahbázpúr is older than the date of this officer's expedition. The pargana is held in ten shares. The proprietors are chiefly Hindus, and Kali Nath Rai and Rashamani Chaudharine are among the principal of them. Some of the shareholders have held their lands for several generations, but most have acquired them by purchase in recent times. It is curious to find the pargana extending down into the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, and the explanation commonly given is that in old times the channel separating the island from the mainland to the north was much smaller than it now is. On 10th July 1794 the Collector reports that the zamindars of this pargana had not given tahút—*i.e.*, had not agreed to the settlement.

The zamindar of Uttar Shahbázpúr was one of those who suffered from the aggressions of Mr Peat, an attorney, who had been Mr Justice Hyde's clerk. Among other things, he shot a native for trying, as he said, to resist his authority. The unfortunate Provincial Council of Dacca seem to have been driven to distraction by Mr Peat and his English law, and so tried to turn the tables on him by unearthing a statute of Henry V. They remark, in a letter dated Dacca, 22d September 1777, "We take this occasion to notice a very important circumstance in the present discussion, that Mr Peat has been acting contrary to law during the whole time of his residence at Dacca, by holding a very active practice as attorney-at-law at Dacca, proved by his original letters already sent you, and at the same

time acting as Deputy-Sheriff, contrary to a statute of Henry V., which enacts 'that an Under-Sheriff cannot execute that office and practise as an attorney at the same time.' . . . Mr Peat's threefold capacity—Master in Chancery, attorney, and Deputy-Sheriff—in a situation so far removed from the Supreme Court, gives him an influence and advantage in the suits he engages in, and leaves little chance of equality to the poor native against whom he may be employed."

The following paper is published in the Proceedings:

"Translation of a petition from the vakil of Lall Ram, zamindar of Uttar Shahbázpúr.

"Your petitioner, Anand Ram, vakil of Lall Ram, the Chaudhari of Uttar Shahbázpúr, represents that Bhangesh Chaudhari, partner of his constituent, having falsely charged him with plunder and devastation in the cutchery of the Supreme Court of Mr Peat, has had your petitioner's constituent, together with his gomasta, arrested and confined in the gaol. Your petitioner's constituent has never been employed by the Company, or in any English service. He is hopeful for justice."

## 11. Dakhin Shahbázpúr.

This pargana belonged to sarkár Khalífatábád, which was also called sarkár Fathábád. It was only annexed to Bákarganj in 1869, or rather it was reannexed in that year, for it had belonged first to Dacca Jalalpúr and then to Bákarganj up to 1822, when it was transferred to the newly-established district of Noakháli. It appears from a petition of Khajah Aratoon, forwarded on 1st October 1795, that the pargana formerly belonged to Mirza Jan, and that in 1187 B.S. (1780), seven anas of it were sold for arrears of revenue, and bought

by Khajah Michael, an Armenian merchant in Dacca, and the father of Khajah Aratoon. In 1193 B.S. (1786), the remaining nine anas were sold, and were also bought by Khajah Michael; but in 1195 B.S. Mr Douglas restored 3 anas 1½ gandas 1 krant to Mirza Jan, and this share still belongs to his descendants—*i.e.*, the Mirza Sahibs of Dacca. It is separate from the 12 anas 18 gandas 1 cowrie 2 krants share. The latter is held by many proprietors, some of whom are descendants of Khajah Michael, and some of whom have obtained their shares by purchase. Among them are the Stephenses of Dacca, Mr Harney, Mr Lucas of Barisál, Mr Bagram as executor for the Gaspar family, and the Baisakhs of Dacca. All the zamindars of Dakhin Shahbázpúr are absentees, and there is hardly a *pakka*-house on the island. According to tradition, the first zamindars of Dakhin Shahbázpúr were Aman Ula Sikdar, Bijai Narain Mozamdar of Bhulua, and four other persons from Dacca. The villages of Amani and Bijaipúr are called after the two first-named individuals, and the zamindari cutcheries of several of the shareholders are still at Amani, which is a few miles from Daulat Khan. Before this time the island seems to have been held by the Arracanese, and by the famous Portuguese pirate Gonzales, who had a fort on the neighbouring island of Sandwip. Aman Ula and his party did not pay the revenue, and so the pargana was made over to a faquir named Abu Syed, who took it in the name of one of his wives, Sartaz Bibi.

Abu Syed and his dewan Krishna Ram Chakrabarti, who came from Srírámpúr in Bákarganj, succeeded in cultivating the island by letting out portions to howaladars and others on permanent tenures, as no one would undertake the clearing of the jungle on other terms.

Mirza Jan, or Mirza Ahmed Jan, was Sartaz Bibi's grandson, and it seems that it was the disputes between him and his stepbrother, Khuda Baksh, which led to the sale of the larger share of the property, and its purchase by Khajah Michael. In Grant, Dakhin Shahbázpúr is entered as having belonged in 1165 (1759) to one Bushan Ula, to whom also the old pargana of Srírámpúr appears to have belonged.

The revenue of Dakhin Shahbázpúr is now upwards of Rs.44,000, but it was formerly greater, being Rs.54,000 (sicca) at the time of the Permanent Settlement. A deduction of Rs.12,208 (sicca) was allowed as *khalari* suspension—*i.e.*, as compensation for land occupied by the salt manufacture. In a statement of the Board of Revenue, 8th May 1808,[1] this deduction is divided as follows among the two shares in the pargana :—

| | a. | g. | k. | Revenue. | Khalari Suspension. |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Khajah Aratoon's share | 12 | 18 | 1 | Rs.43,487 4 15 | Rs.9858 10 10 |
| Mirza Jan's share . | 3 | 1 | 3 | 10,358 12 15 | 2349 5 10 |

There were then two salt agencies, one at Rai Mangal, which appears to have been the same place as Jhalukátti, and another at Bhulua (Noakháli). The Dakhin Shahbázpúr manufacture belonged to the latter agency. Khajah Michael and Khajah Kaworke were at one time the lessees of the salt-farm, and we find a reference to Dakhin Shahbázpúr in the Ninth Report of the Committee of the House of Commons. The place was then known under the not infelicitous corruption of Savagepore ; and the notorious Mr Richard Barwell, the Chief of Dacca, had the salt-farm in 1774, he having engaged for it, as he said, "in the persuasion of its being a very profitable farm." It seems that Mr Barwell held the lease both of the Selímábád and the Shahbázpúr salt-farms, and that he relet them to two Armenian mer-

chants, Michael and Kaworke, on condition of their paying him Rs.125,000, exclusive of their engagement to the Company. Mr Barwell's engagement with them was benami—*i.e.*, it was in the names of Basant Rai and Kissen Deb Sing, as it was not thought consistent with the public regulations that the names of any Europeans should appear. Khajah Kaworke complained that after Mr Barwell had let him the farms, and taken a lac and Rs.25,000 from him on this account, he dispossessed him, and relet the farms to another person for another lac of rupees. When Mr Barwell was first called upon to explain his transactions with these Armenians, he candidly confessed that the salt-farms of Selímábád and Savagepore had been taken by him, and bursting into a fine train of sentiment, he exclaims, "If I am mistaken in my reasoning, and the wish to add to my fortune has warped my judgment in a transaction that may appear to the Board [of Directors] in a light different to what I view it in, it is past; I cannot recall it, and I rather choose to admit an error than deny a fact." In another letter he said, "To the honourable Court of Directors I will submit all my rights in the salt contracts I engaged in; and if in their opinion those rights vest in the Company, I will account to them for the last shilling I have received from such contracts, my intentions being upright; and as I never did wish to profit myself to the prejudice of my employers, by their judgment I will be implicitly directed."

Upon these expressions of Mr Barwell the Committee caustically observe, that "the extraordinary caution, and the intricate contrivances with which his share in this transaction is wrapped up, form a sufficient proof that he was not altogether misled in his judgment; and though there might be some merit in acknowledging an

error before it was discovered, there could be very little in a confession produced by previous detection." The Board of Directors ordered a prosecution, but it never took place. Meanwhile, Mr Barwell withdrew from his offer to abide by the judgment of the Directors, though he still indulged in a fine flow of sentiment, but in a new vein. His compliance (with the demands made on him) would be urged as a confession of delinquency, and as proceeding from conviction of his having usurped on the rights of the Company. Rather than do this, he resolved "to appeal to the laws of his country in order to vindicate his fame." Like draws to like, and it seems that Sir Elijah Impey became the guardian of Mr Barwell's children, and was the trustee for his affairs.

When the manufacture of salt in Dakhin Shahbázpúr was discontinued, it was proposed that the Rs.12,000 of khalari suspensions should be readded to the revenue at the zamindari, but the proposal was negatived at the instance of Mr Ricketts, who was then Commissioner of Chittagong, and who pointed out that the zamindars had suffered much by diluviation. In fact, the pargana is by no means very profitable to the zamindars. Much of the land has been washed away by the Meghna, and though there have been many re-formations, these were for the most part resumed by Government as island chars. At that time the law of re-formation on the old site, as since expounded by the Privy Council, was not understood. Some lands also appear to have been resumed by the Sundarban Commissioners in rather an arbitrary manner. For instance, the island of Manpúra was taken possession of by them, though it is entered in the papers of the partition of the pargana which was made before the Permanent Settlement. Only a small

part of the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr now belongs to the pargana of that name, and the south of the island consists mostly of chars resumed by Government. The most valuable interests in the land are held by the howaladars and other middlemen, and the zamindars have not been able generally to enhance their rents. On the other hand, most, if not all, the shareholders in the zamindari have also subordinate holdings in it, and are their own and their co-sharers' taluqdars, howaladars, &c., and probably these are among the most valuable of their rights in the pargana. It seems that formerly Dakhin Shahbázpúr pargana was bounded on the west by a large river called the Betua; that west of this river were the lands of Ratandi Kalikapúr, Uttar Shahbázpúr, Shaistanagar, and Baikanthpúr, &c.; and that west of them was the Ilsa or Títulia, which was then a small river. Now the Betua has been dried up, and much of the land in the centre of the island is situated in its old bed, and was resumed by Government, while the Títulia has become a very large river. The river between Hattia and Dakhin Shahbázpúr was also small in old times, and there is still a small portion of Dakhin Shahbázpúr pargana in Hattia. It is, I believe, a taluq, and bears a Portuguese name (das Anjos ?), so that it seems to be a reminiscence of the days when the Portuguese of Chittagong had possessions in these parts. There are no descendants of the Portuguese now in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, though there were a few till lately in the island of Hattia.

The zamindar of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, who then, I presume, resided at Dacca, is mentioned by Mr Mill as one of the victims of the usurpations of the old Supreme Court, his house having been broken open, and even the apartments of his women rudely vio-

lated, on pretence that he had been arrested and afterwards rescued.

The large or *shahi* kani is in use in this pargana. It is four times the size of the ordinary kani, and is equal to 19⅓ bighas.

Some copies of the partition effected in 1188 B.S. (1781) are in the Collectorate record-room. They bear the signature of Mr Day, who was formerly Collector of Dacca.

The book in the India Library, already quoted, contains some correspondence about Dakhin Shahbázpúr. One case is that of Sarup Chand Khazanchi. He, it seems, had been imprisoned by the Provincial Council for not paying the revenue of the pargana, and had sued out his Habeas Corpus in the Supreme Court. In a petition by him, included in the Proceedings of the Dacca Provincial Council, 18th August 1777, he says, "At the time of the Committee's *bandobast*, my father, Nitai Anand Dás Khazanchi, was security for the pargana of Dakhin Shahbázpúr; and I, to the year 1182, borrowed money and discharged the Government revenue," &c. In Chait 1183 Mr Purling demanded the balance to the end of the year, and confined his gomasta. The zamindars objected, alleging "the plunder and oppression by the invasion of the Mugs." Sarup Chand was released by the Supreme Court. In his examination before the Supreme Court he mentioned that several gentlemen of the Provincial Council were privately indebted to him in large sums. The case seems to have excited a good deal of attention, and Mr Justice Le Maistre recorded a long judgment on it.

A more important case, however, probably was that mentioned above of the zamindar of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. The papers are in the volume above quoted.

The zamindar was Mirza Jan, and he was sued by one Elias Abraham. A bailiff of the Supreme Court came to arrest him, and in trying to do so a tumult took place, and a slave-girl was wounded with a sword. This occurred on 1st February 1779.

I may note here that in the list of members of the Provincial Council, given in General Appendix No. 30 of the above-mentioned volume, the name of W. M. Thackeray[1] (father of the novelist?) appears as third member of the Dacca Council. His pay was Rs. 500 (sicca) a month, exclusive apparently of the allowances according to the rank he would have held in Calcutta —viz., a senior or junior merchant, factor, or writer.

In Appendix No. 36 of the same volume a list of the

[1] If this be the father of the novelist, then he is probably the person who was the Company's Resident at Sylhet, and who was severely censured by the Court of Directors. It seems that he had taken under a fictitious name an elephant-farm in Sylhet, and that he had supplied elephants which were in such bad condition that only sixteen out of sixty-six arrived at their destination. The elephants had previously been passed by the Patna Council, and the Company applied to Mr Thackeray to know how this had been done; but he refused to tell, because, having given his word and honour that he would not divulge particulars, "he would be breaking his promise, forfeit the character of a man of principle and honour, and suffer in the opinion of his friends." The Directors observed that "these reasons appear to us very extraordinary when urged by a man whose duplicity has just been manifested, who had, to use the Governor-General's words, been convicted of having secretly obtained the farm of Sylhet under fictitious titles, and punished for that offence; nor are we able to reconcile the Governor-General's tenderness for Mr Thackeray's honour and delicacy with his own further declaration that from the above transaction Mr Thackeray had been unanimously and justly condemned." Mr Thackeray appears to have sued the Company in connection with these transactions, and he got a decree in the Supreme Court for Rs. 29,600 and costs. Warren Hastings and Mr Barwell allowed the case to be decreed *ex parte*, and General Clavering is quoted in the Court of Directors' letter as having said that the cause was lost by "a most shameless desertion" on the part of the defendants. See India Papers, vol. i. 1787, and also vol. i. of Appendix to Parliamentary Proceedings against Warren Hastings, p. 175. The Court's letter is dated 28th November 1777.

zamindaries of the Dacca division and their revenues for the year 1777-78, &c., is given.

### 12. Tappa Kistodebpúr.

This tappa is situated on the west side of the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, about half way from its north and south extremities. It is said to have been formed out of Uttar Shahbázpúr, and to be named after a Bráhman called Kista Deb Bidyabagish, who got a sanad for it through the influence of Rajah Ganga Govind Sing, in whose house he was a pandit. The revenue is only Rs.816, but the pargana has so increased by alluviation that it now contains more than a lac of bighas. It is at present under partition, and has been so for many years. Part of it has been sold to the Shahs of Baliatti, and the Bráhman descendants of the original owner have made over the remainder in *patni* to a Mymensing zamindar. The estate is highly cultivated, but it is full of under-tenures, so that the profit to the zamindar is less than might be expected.

### 13. Tappa Alinagar.

This is another tappa of Uttar Shahbázpúr. It is situated in the northern part of the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, and belongs to Mr John Courjon. The revenue is only Rs.1578, but the collections from the ryots amount to about Rs.14,000.

### 14. Pargana Ramnagar.

This was once the property of Rajah Raj Ballab. It also was formed out of Uttar Shahbázpúr. Balia and Gangapúr belong to it, and it is now chiefly owned by

a Dacca family, the Koulipara zamindars. They have twelve anas, and the Madhabpásha zamindars, who are descended from Ram Manik Mudi, hold the other four anas.

### 15. Taraf Ram Hari Char.

This consists of one taluq called Dordana Khanam. It was created by Mr Henckell in 1785 under the same conditions as char Kalmi, and was granted in favour of Dordana Khanam, which was another name of Etimonissa. The amount of land conveyed was 313 bighas; and the taluq was composed of chars Patti, Maya, and Nangla, the last two of which, at all events, are a little to the north of char Kalmi. The history of this taluq is given in Mr Fortescue's report of 9th May 1806. See also the Board's reply of the 16th idem.

### 16. Kalmi Char and Taraf.

Char Kalmi is an island in the estuary of the Meghna. It was originally let on a jangalburi tenure by Mr Tilman Henckell in 1192 B.S. (1785) to Baidya Nath Sein and others, who, it appears, were merely bēnamidars for Serajuddin, the son of Syed Imamuddin, zamindar of Nazirpúr. The conditions of the lease were that no rent was to be paid for three years; that the rate was to be two anas a bigha for the fourth year, four anas for the fifth, six anas for the sixth, and eight anas for the seventh. This last rate was to be perpetual. The agreement was for 245 bighas, and a deduction of one-ninth, or of 200 bighas out of 1200, was allowed for *malikana*, &c. There is an unauthenticated copy of the original lease in the Collectorate. Mr Henckell granted this and other leases as Superintendent of the Sundarbans. He was Collector of Jessore, and figures

largely in Mr Westland's account of that district. Mr Westland has chronicled Mr Henckell's disputes with the Salt Department, and his endeavours to prevent their oppression, and it is pleasant to quote in this connection a newspaper extract of 24th April 1788, published at page 253 of Seton-Karr's Selections, which in all probability refers to Mr Henckell. "It is a fact," says the newspaper, "that the conduct of Mr H—— in the Sundarbans has been so exemplary and mild towards the poor *molunghies* or salt manufacturers, that, to express their gratitude, they have made a representation of his figure or image, which they worship among themselves. A strong proof that the natives of this country are sensible of kind treatment, and easily governed without coercive measures." Mr Hunter, the first Collector of Bákarganj, visited char Kalmi in 1818 or 1819. He found one Matioolah in possession of the greater part of the island as *ausat* taluqdar under Etimonissa, who was the widow of Serajuddin. Under the Board's orders he made the settlement with Etimonissa at a rent of Rs.1731-4 (sicca), being at the rate of eight anas a bigha on the land then in cultivation, after deduction of $16\frac{1}{4}$ per cent. (see Mr Hunter's letters of 25th May and 31st July 1818, of 17th March and 12th June 1819, and the Board's letter of 6th April 1819). This rent still holds good, the difference between it and the present amount (Rs.1846) being caused by the conversion of sicca into Government rupees. The island is now held by Imdad Ali Munshi, who resides on it, and a Ghose family resident in the Twenty-four Parganas. The former holds seven and the latter nine anas. I visited the island in the end of 1874, and found it well cultivated, though rice was almost the only product. The survey area is

about 3300 acres. There are about 635 inhabitants, all of whom are Mahomedans except one or two Hindu washermen and barbers.

Kalmi taraf is marked on the survey map as a distinct char, but it seems now to have diluviated. The river at Kalmi appears to bear the name of the Bura Gouranga. Kalmi is said to have been first cultivated by one Badan Ali Khan.

### 17. Sultanábád.

This pargana is chiefly situated in thana Baufal, but there are portions of it in thanas Barisál and Bákarganj. In 1797, Kalab Ali, one of the zamindars of the pargana, is described as being a lunatic. Khajah Ahsanoolah is the chief proprietor, as he holds 7 anas 10½ gandas 1½ krants. The oldest proprietor seems to be Syed Abdalla Chaudhari of Dacca, who is said to hold 6 anas 3½ gandas; but this, again, is divided into six shares, which are held in various names. Meharanissa Khanam, a lady who lives in Barisál, holds 1 ana 15½ gandas 2½ krants. Ahsan Mir and Mir Tajammal Ali, Deputy-Magistrate, have also shares. The pargana has been undergoing partition for many years, and the division is to be into ten shares. It is said to contain a lac and thirty-six thousand bighas. A char named Sanyasi has lately accreted to the pargana, and added a new difficulty to its partition. The zamindari assets are reckoned at half a lac, and as the Government revenue is Rs.23,000, the pargana is not a very profitable one to the landholders. There are many undertenures in Sultanábád, and these are in numerous instances held by the zamindars.

### 18. Kasimnagar Joár Dáspára.

This is a small estate situated at the ancient village of Dáspára, and near the Baufal police station. It is registered in the name of Hamidonissa Khatun.

### 19. Khanja Bahadur Nagar.

This is another small estate in Baufal thana. There are lands belonging to it in the village of Govindpúr. Whether its name be connected with the famous Khanja Ali I know not. Maulavi Mahomed Fazil, formerly police inspector, holds a share in this pargana.

### 20. Pargana Srírámpúr.

This is an old pargana, and has been nearly all washed away by the Meghna. It belongs to the Mirza Sahebs of Dacca, the family who own a portion of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, and who have held their lands for many generations. A famous riot took place in this pargana in 1869. It is situated in the Mendiganj thana. Government holds several chars which have been resumed from this pargana. As a proof of its deterioration from diluviation and other causes, I may mention that Government has acquired, by purchase at sales for arrears of revenue, fifty-two estates in Srírámpúr, and that their total revenue is only a little over Rs.200 (227-9).

### 21. Tappa Abdulapúr.

This appears to have been formed out of the four and a half anas of Selímábád. Its lands chiefly lie in

Mendiganj, but there are some in Jhalukátti. It belongs to a Baidya family (Har Nath Rai and others) who reside at Japsa in the Mulfatganj or Palang thana. Their ancestor was one Gopi Raman Sein.

### 22. Tappa Kadirábád.

This small pargana belongs to a Bráhman family who reside in the district of Dacca, and are known as the Koulipara Banarjis. Its lands are situated in Mendiganj.

### 23. Tappa Azimpúr.

This is a scattered pargana, and appears to have suffered from diluviation. It is situated in thanas Gournadi, Barisál, and Bákarganj, and there is part of it also in Bikrampúr in Dacca or Faridpúr. It belongs to the Piprakátti Shamadars, a Bráhman family, who reside near Palardi, in the Gournadi thana; to the Jahapúr Datts, to Asmat Ali Khan of Charamadi, and to the Lakutia Raies. The last-named shareholders have acquired their share recently by purchase. The Collectorate register of estates being arranged alphabetically, Azimpúr is the first on the list.

### 24. Pargana Jahapúr.

This is an old pargana, and has been nearly all swept away by the Arial Khan. It is situated in the Mendiganj thana, on the east bank of the Dakaitia river—*i.e.*, the Arial Khan. Char Jahapúr has probably formed on the old site of lands belonging to this pargana, and it too has lately been much washed away. The pargana

belongs to an old but greatly reduced Hindu family called the Jahapúr Datts.

### 25. Pargana Idrakpúr.

The land of this pargana appears to be *ijmali* or joint with that of Rasulpúr, there being many holdings in it of which eight anas or one-half of the rent is paid to Idrakpúr and the other half to Rasulpúr. It is situated in the northern part of the district, on both sides of the Arial Khan, in thanas Gournadi and Mendiganj. Three anas have been purchased by a family of traders called the Kundas of Lohajang, and the remainder belongs to a Dacca family, of which the present representatives appear to be Amiranissa Khatun, Abedanissa Khatun, and Karimanissa, and who have long been fighting in the civil and criminal courts. Their offices are at Sarikal and Gachua. A part of the pargana has been purchased by Nazimuddin Chaudhari of Kartikpúr. From a letter dated 10th July 1794 it appears that the pargana was bought in 1190 by one Imamuddin Chaudhari.

### 26. Pargana Rasulpúr.

There is no zamindari belonging to this pargana in Bákarganj. It suffered a great deal from the inundations of 1787. It appears also in old times to have suffered from mismanagement, for the Collector writes of it as follows: "The general mode of realising the revenues when the settlement was concluded with the three proprietors, was for each to appoint a Mofussil manager with equal powers. The consequences were that the ryots were constantly harassed, and frequently peons were placed on them at one time by the three

managers for the same demand, thus it often happened that three rupees were extorted from the ryots when the original demand was only for one."

### 27. Bangrora.

This pargana is remarkable for the large number of its separated taluqs, there being nearly a thousand in it. Many of them are very small, and their lands are greatly intermixed, so that frequent disputes arise among the owners. The zamindari is registered in the name of Hayatonissa Khatun. The principal taluqdars are the Datts of Batajor, the Dasses of Goila, and the Bakshies of Barthi. The large village of Goila is situated in Bangrora, which lies in Gournadi thana in the northern part of the district. Most of the land is very fertile, but some of it is marshy. The land revenue of the taluqs is Rs.20,724-2-9.

### 28, 29. Pargana Birmohan and Tappa Birmohan.

These are situated in thana Gournadi. In old times Birmohan was infested with tigers, and the Collector writes in July 1790, that he had endeavoured to induce the tiger-killers to repair to it, but without success. It appears that the tigers had increased in consequence of the desertion of the pargana, and its consequent relapse into jungle, after the inundations of 1787. It belongs to a Bráhman family known as the Birmohan Chaudharies, and to the Narail family (Jessore). It is at present undergoing partition, but the work is being carried on at Faridpúr, as the pargana has been transferred to that Collectorate.

### 30. Habibpúr.

This pargana is in the Gournadi and Sarupkátti thanas, and belongs to Lakya Kanth Bhuia and others of Bikrampúr, and to a family of Ghoses (one of them was formerly sub-inspector of Gournadi). There are many dependent taluqdars in the pargana, and the chief profit from it is received by them.

### 31. Maizardi.

This is a small pargana, situated in Mendiganj. It belongs to the Mirza Sahebs of Dacca, the Srinagar zamindars, and Dinu Bandhu Chakrabarti of Tunghibari (Bikrampúr). Gholam Gafur was the original proprietor, and he still holds a small share. Maizardi has suffered much from diluviation, like all the parganas in Mendiganj. Part of it was at one time bought by Government at a sale for arrears of revenue, but most of the purchase has been resold. In March 1793 the Collector reported that Maizardi had to be held khas on account of the zamindar's refusing to engage.

### 32. Jalálpúr.

This pargana chiefly belongs to Faridpúr, but there are portions of it in the north of Bákarganj and in Dacca. It is remarkable for the number of its taluqs. Mr Thompson (5th February 1794) wrote that there were about 2000 in the pargana, that many of the taluqdars were in extreme distress, and that upwards of 100 of them had fled, from inability to pay their revenue dues. The pargana suffered much in the inundations of 1787.

### 33. Shaistábád.

This is a small pargana formed out of Chandradwip. Syed Hassad Ali states, in a petition forwarded in February 1793, that he is the zamindar, and that the property had formerly belonged to his maternal grandfather, Mahomed Hanif Chaudhari. It once belonged to Mendi Mozamdar of Chakar, and the present Shaistábád family obtained it by marriage, their ancestor Mir Salimuddin having married Mendi Mozamdar's granddaughter. Mir Salimuddin came from Mokimpúr in the Dacca district. According to a paper given to me by Syed Mozaffar Hoosein, one of the present proprietors, Shaistábád derives its name from Shaista Khan, who was Governor of Bengal in the reign of Arangzeb. It belonged to sarkár Khalífatábád, and was included in chakla Jessore. The lands of the pargana are a good deal scattered. The zamindari residence is near Charaman, in the village of Aicha, about eight miles north-east of Barisál. Phultolla, Mírganj, and Karimganj are the chief trading-places. It is said that one Eerach Khan, a soldier or servant of the Nawab, obtained the pargana as a jaghir, and bequeathed it to his daughter Omdatanissa, also called the Bahu Begam, from her having married into the Nawab's family. She leased the pargana on a fixed rent to Mahomed Hanif Chaudhari by a sanad dated 25th Safar, 5th jalus (the chronological year cannot be deciphered). On the death of Mahomed Hanif, his widow, Amina Khatun, gave her only daughter in marriage to Mir Salimuddin, and made over the estate to their son, Mir Asad Ali, by a deed of gift dated 21st Asar 1171. Asad Ali left the estate to his three sons, Abbas Ali, Imdad Ali, and Gholam Imam. Abbas Ali left no son, and

Gholam Imam's two sons died without issue, hence the property devolved on the four sons of Imdad Ali—viz., Mir Tajammal Ali, Mir Abdul Majid, Mir Moazzam Hoosein, and Mir Abdullah. The family are Syeds, as descended from the Prophet. The gentleman who has obliged me with the above information has given me his genealogical tree, which seems to me to be interesting, and I therefore subjoin it (see p. 159). The family is the most considerable Mahomedan one in the district, and is remarkable for the number of officers whom it has given to the public service. It holds a share in Sultanábád, and three anas of the very profitable Sundarban estate known as Aila Phuljhuri.

## 34. Shaistanagar.

This is a small pargana, situated chiefly in thana Bákarganj. It belongs to a Bráhman family known as the Garuria Chaudharies, to the Narail family, and to Babu Chandi Charan Rai of Barisál, and others. The Garuria Chaudharies live near Kalaskátti, and belong to the same stock as the Arangpúr zamindars. They are a very old family, but are much reduced in circumstances.[1]

## 35. Shahzádpúr.

This is a small pargana, situated chiefly in thana Nalchiti. The principal owner is Durga Gati Rai of Siddhakátti, though Har Nath Datt of Amrajuri and others have also shares. Durga Gati belongs to a very good family, and is what is called a Kulin Baidya. The

[1] This Shaistanagar is distinct from the Shaistanagar in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, the revenue of which is paid into the Noakháli treasury.

pargana is an old one, but the most important thing about it at present is that the Nalchiti bazár is situated within it. In a petition of 12th May 1791, Pitambar Sein of Rajnagar claims the merit of having established the Nalchiti market. He says, "Receiving pottahs for lands belonging to Shahzádpúr and other parganas, and expending a large sum of money, I erected a hát at Nalchiti." In reply, Keval Ram and his other co-sharers say, "In regard to the exclusive claim which Pitambar Sein makes to the hát Nalchiti, we have to observe that the land upon which it is erected was received by him from the parganas of Shahzádpúr and Shaistanagar in exchange for others given by him to the proprietors of those parganas from that of Buzurgumedpúr, our joint property and estate." It will be noticed that the co-sharers hereby admit Pitambar's claim to be the founder of the market. Pitambar was the son of Gopal Kissen, and grandson of Raj Ballab, as has been elsewhere stated. There is an old temple of the goddess Tara at Nalchiti, which is said to have been founded by Gopal Kissen.

### 36. Tappa Bahadurpúr.

This is a valuable property, situated chiefly in thana Bákarganj. It belongs to the Messrs Pogose of Dacca, who inherited it from their grandfather, Khajah Nikus.

### 37. Pargana Arangpúr.

This pargana was formed out of Chandradwip. Professor Blochmann supposes that it derives its name from the emperor Arangzeb, but it seems unlikely that a comparatively small and obscure pargana should have been named after him.

The pargana still belongs in part to the Bráhman family who held it at the time of the Permanent Settlement, though now there are many other shareholders. The former reside at Kaloskátti, near Bákarganj. The Shaistanagar (Garuria) and Arangpúr families were originally one, and Gopal Rai is said to have been their common founder. He obtained the zamindari of Shaistanagar, and died, leaving several sons. Among them was Janaki Ballab. He, I suppose, was the youngest, and his brothers would not give him any share of the zamindari. Though he was only eight years of age, he went to Dacca to the Nawab, and succeeded in getting pargana Arangpúr from him. It was composed of three parganas—viz., Arangpúr, Raghanathpúr, and Itmadpúr, the last being given to the boy by Itmad Khan, a servant of the Nawab. Up to a recent date the zamindari continued to be entered in Janaki Ballab's name. A large part of the south of the district is included in the pargana, and it extends down to the line of the Sundarbans. The headquarters of the Patuyakháli subdivision, and much of its jurisdiction, are included in Arangpúr. The largest shareholder in the zamindari is Boroda Kanth Rai, who is reputed to be the wealthiest man in the district. According to a story current in Bákarganj, he owes part of his wealth to the circumstance of his having been fined Rs.30,000. He had given recognisances in this amount for the preservation of the peace, and on the occurrence of a riot, in which he was considered to be implicated, his recognisances were estreated, and the Rs.30,000 levied. Boroda paid the money, but immediately lodged an appeal, and at the same time recouped himself by taking Rs.30,000 from his ryots. On appeal the fine was remitted, and so Boroda got

back his money, but he did not return to the ryots what he had levied from them. A story somewhat similar to this is told of one of the Bamna chaudharies. He subscribed Rs.10,000 to the patriotic fund which was raised at the close of the Crimean war, and received the thanks of Government for so doing. Afterwards it came to light that he had not paid the money from his own coffers, but had screwed it out of the ryots. The Governor-General indignantly ordered that the money should be returned to him, but as he did not make restitution to the ryots, he made a profit of Rs.10,000. Although I narrate these stories, I must say that I think they are rather apocryphal. The second is of very dubious authenticity, for I do not think Government would be so foolish as to give back money which, according to the hypothesis, had never belonged to the ostensible donor; and as for the first, though I believe there is a foundation of truth in it, yet the fact of Boroda's having been put on Rs.30,000 recognisances implies that he was already a wealthy man. Boroda Kanth is a type of the conservative Hindu, being very strict in his religious observances, seldom or never wearing anything which has been sewn, and very chary of visiting the officials, or of subscribing to schools or dispensaries. He is remarkable as a benamidar—*i.e.*, he holds a great deal of property in other people's names. Thus all his zamindari is held in the name of his wife, Muktakeshi Debya, but this is so openly admitted by him and his agents that I can hardly think it has been done for the sake of fraud or concealment. Probably there was some notion of luck involved in it. He also holds numerous howalas and other under-tenures in Arangpúr under fictitious names. Arangpúr is divided into two shares, called the nine-ana and the

seven-ana. This division was made by private arrangement in 1197 B.S. (1790), and the ryots of the two shares are still separate. Each of these shares is, however, now subdivided among many people, and a batwara or partition of them has long been going on. This partition is one of the opprobria of the Bákarganj administration, it having been commenced more than fifty years ago, not long after the passing of the Batwara Law of 1814, and not yet being finished. Owing to disputes among the proprietors the seven-ana share of Arangpúr was attached by the Civil Court many years ago, and is now managed by Mr Scott, the Sarbarakar or Manager of Attached Estates. Khajah Ahsanoolah has a share of Arangpúr, and so also have the heirs of certain Banarjis. The seven anas were once sold for arrears of revenue. Durga Prosunno Rai had a share in the zamindari, but he has now given it in patni to Boroda Kanth Rai, and I understand that Khajah Ahsanoolah has done the same thing with his share.

## 38. Pargana Syedpúr.

This pargana is in the south-west of the district. Ten anas of it belong to Lalla Mitrajit Singh of Dacca, and six anas to the heirs of Briju Ratan Das. It was the disturbances between them which led to the famous Singhkháli cases some twenty years ago. Bhagirath Singh, who is said to have been a kanungo, was the founder of the Singh family. The Permanent Settlement was made with one Lalla Jeyt Singh. There is a report by the Collector on the pargana, dated 27th December 1809. Syedpúr was to a large extent a Sundarban pargana, and the Government estate of Tushkháli was resumed from it, and is described as

*lakt*, or adjacent to Syedpúr. The Táki Babus, as they are called, a family of Kayasts residing at Táki, in the Twenty-four Parganas, have a large *abád* or tract of country called the Debnathpúr abád in this pargana. It is held on a permanent lease, and contains about thirty thousand bighas. They had a lawsuit with Government (when Tushkháli was measured and settled), and succeeded in recovering possession of some nineteen thousand bighas. The family is descended from Kachu[1] Rai, whose father was killed by Pratápáditya.

[1] The name is said to be derived from the circumstance of his having, when a child, been hidden by his nurse in some *kachu* or *arum* jungle in order to save him from his father's fate. See the "Kshitisha Bansavali Charitam" or "Chronicle of Krishnagur," Berlin, 1852. There is an analysis of this work in the Calcutta Review for December 1855.

MOHUMMUD, THE PROPHET.

FATIMA (daughter).

1. Hosein (son). — Hasan (son).
2. Syed Zainolabideen (son).
3. Syed Mohummud Baker (son).
4. Syed Mohumud Emam Jafer Sady (son).
5. Syed Sha Ahmud Bulakhy (son).
6. Syed Abulunam (son).
7. Syed Anwarol Huq Bulkhi (son).
8. Syed Addlul Huq Bulkhi (son), buried in Samarkand.
9. Syed Sha Alum Bulkhee, who afterwards died at Samarkand.
10. Syed Sha Abdul Khalaque Bulkhee, lying buried there.
11. Syed Abdul Razzak (son), of Samarkand.
12. Syed Abdul Quader (son), of Samarkand.
13. Syed Godool Huq (son).
14. Syed Shah Sultan (son).
15. Salar Samarkandi (son).
16. Quorer Samarkandi (son).
17. Shah Bukhsee (son).
18. Shah Amanuth (son).
19. Shah Zukuriah (son).
20. Shumsuddeen (son).
21. Shah Mohummed Wallee (son).
22. Shah Adam (son), Walee Scindh.
23. Mortaza (son).
24. Hasamuddeen (son), came from Scindh.
25. Shamsoddeen (son).
26. Salimuddeen Chowdhri (son).
27. Assad Ali Chowdhry (son).

Syed Abbas Ali, died without issue. — 28. Mir Emdad Ali. — Meer Gholam Imam (left two sons, who died sub-equently).

Meer Tujummol Ali. — Meer Abdul Mujeed. — Meer Moazzum Hosein. — Meer Abdullah. — Three daughters.

Meer Tufuzzul Ahmed (son). — Meer Abdul Hameed (son). — Abdul Waheed (son.) — Meer Mohumed Israil (son). — Meer Obeidullah (son).

Meer Mozuffer Hosein (son). — Meer Abdur Rub (son.) — Meer Mohumed Hosein (son). — Mir Mohmood Hosein. — Mir Mothalin Hosein.

# CHAPTER V.

## *SUNDARBANS.*

### I. GENERAL DESCRIPTION.

The different explanations of the origin of the name Sundarbans have already been given. The lands known under this name were not included in the Permanent Settlement. It was directed by Regulation 9 of 1816 that a special officer should be appointed to the charge of the Sundarbans, who should be styled Commissioner in the Sundarbans. Regulation 23 of 1817 (repealed by Regulation 2 of 1819) in its preamble describes the Sundarbans, and refers to Bákarganj and Jalálpúr.

The Sundarbans were surveyed by Lieutenant Hodges in 1830. Those belonging to Bákarganj are small in comparison with those of Jessore, or of the Twenty-four Parganas, but are much more cultivated, owing to their higher level and to the large quantity of fresh water brought in by the Meghna and Bráhmaputra. The Commissioner has his headquarters at Alipúr, near Calcutta. Most of the estates in the Sundarbans are managed by him either directly or through farmers, and the Collector of Bákarganj has no connection with them further than that their revenues are paid into his treasury. There are, however, some estates—such as Ramna-Bamna, Halta, Sonakháli, Aila Phuljhuri—which have been permanently settled, and are no longer

under the control of the Commissioner. These estates are, I believe, seventy-one in number, and are arranged in the Collectorate papers according to the parganas to which they are lakt or contiguous. Their united revenue is Rs.134,098. (The seventy-one include eleven in Buzurgumedpúr and Nos. 1437 and 1447.) The estates of Ramna-Bamna and Aila Phuljhuri have been described in the account of pargana Buzurgumedpúr. Halta and Sonakháli belong to Messrs Morrell. At Schillergunge, on the banks of the Sapleza, Mr Casperz has a property of about 12,000 acres, which he has called Casperábád, and which is for the most part rent free. Dhallooa, Bargona, and Naltona lie to the south of Aila Phuljhuri. They were claimed by Khajah Abdul Ghani, but his claim was rejected by the Privy Council, and they are now under khas management. Kolaran Chandipúr is a Sundarban taluq situated in the Perozpúr subdivision, but the revenue is paid into the Jessore treasury. Its history is given by Mr Rocke in a letter to the Collector of Dacca, dated 21st August 1790. He says that in 1192 B.S. one Kanye Ghosal applied for seven chucks as a taluq. Three of them—viz., Kolaran, Chandipúr, and Baleshwar—were granted to him, and he then sold them by patta to Bijai Ram Sha (the ancestor of the Shas of Dattapara). The amount of land stated in the patta is 500 bighas. Mr Rocke mentions that Bijai Sha complained that the zamindar of Selímábád had imprisoned his son for rent.

The boundary line of the Sundarbans is irregular; and we find estates, such as Baisdia, Rangabali, Kázal, &c., which are the property of private individuals, and were so at the time of the Permanent Settlement, in the middle of the Government Sundarbans. This is

especially the case in the south-east of Bákarganj, where the kharija or separated taluqs of Chandradwip extend to the seaboard. It is curious that the islands of Kúkri Múkri, or, more properly, Kukuria Mekuria—*i.e.*, Dog-and-Cat Islands—belong to the Sundarbans, while the neighbouring island of Chopa does not.

The Sundarbans proper chiefly occur in the Gúlsakháli and Perozpúr thanas. Their general aspect is that of lonely forests traversed by sullen streams. The trees are seldom allowed to grow to any great height, as they are cut down by the woodcutters, or *bawalis*, as they are called. These people go down in the cold weather to cut wood, and in spite of their taking faquirs to charm them away, are often carried off by tigers. There were formerly two sayer holdings in the Sundarbans, called Gore Katta and Takta mahals, consisting of tolls levied from the woodcutters. They were abolished by the Board's orders, 8th May 1818. The chief wood-marts are Amtolli, Gúlsakháli, Jhalukátti, Phuljhuri, Bákargánj, and Nalchiti. Charcoal is made in the Sundarbans, but in a rude way without pits. The chief supply for Europeans is brought from Moidapúr, near Nalchiti, where the Mahomedans manufacture large jars, and afterwards sell the charcoal which remains in the kilns. The Sundarbans are much used for the pasturing of buffaloes, which are swum across to Kúkri Múkri, Chopa, &c. At Dhula char, near Chapli, the wind has heaped the sand into low dunes or sand-heaps. Boats cannot track in the Sundarbans, and have to depend entirely on the tides. According to Mr Gomess, about one-half of the Bákarganj Sundarbans has been cleared. It appears from a statement of the same gentleman in the Census Report, that 276,804 square miles (177,152 acres) were cleared between 1830 and 1872.

In early times the Mugs used to commit depredations in the Sundarbans, and in Rennel's map a large tract is marked as depopulated by them. They have been in the habit of trading in betel-nut from an early date, and there is a letter of Mr Battye, dated 31st December 1812, about some Mugs who had come over from Ramu, and whom he had arrested under the idea that they were adherents of one Kiobering. They were afterwards released, and Rs.326 were paid by Government for their keep (see letters of 17th January and 11th March 1812).[1]

The Mugs at the present time occupy many parts of the Sundarbans, but there is no reason to suppose that they have been there since the time of their early depredations, and probably none of their settlements are more than seventy years old. On 24th March 1824, Thungari Mug petitioned the Board of Revenue, saying that he had brought 230 families of settlers at a great expense from Chittagong and Ramu, and that he had been dispossessed by Domingo de Silva. He added that he was a native of Arracan, and that he had abandoned his country when its monarch was dethroned, and had availed himself of the asylum offered by the British Government. He had brought over the settlers, he said, on the faith of an encouraging letter which he had received from the Collector of Dacca, dated 31st July

[1] Mr Sutherland remarks that he could not say who this Kiobering was. I have found a description of him in Mr Paton's account of Arracan, vol. xvi. of "Asiatic Researches," p. 368, where the name is given as Khyngberring. It seems that he attempted a rebellion in the Mug era, 1173 (1811?). Along with other Sardars, he formed a resolution to expel the Burmese; and having collected 500 men, invaded Arracan in twenty-five boats. He was defeated by the King of Arracan, and after making various other ineffectual raids, he died in exile. According to Sir Arthur Phayre, A. S. J., vol. x. for 1841, the correct name is Khyeng-byan, literally Khyeng-return; and he was so called because he was the first-born after his father returned from the Khyeng Hills. A son of Khyeng-byan died at Akyab in 1840.

1816.[1] The Mugs now in the district state that they were driven from their country by war. It appears that they came from Arracan, which was annexed to Burmah in 1787. In 1798 30,000 Arracanese took refuge in Chittagong, and it is probable that some of them came to Chapli. The principal seat of the Mugs is at Khaprabhanga, near Chapli, in thana Gúlsakháli. They are also numerously settled at Chapli, Nishanbari, and Maudhobi. Khaprabhanga is a little further inland than the place usually visited by Europeans. When I visited it in October 1874, I found a priest and a small *kaioung* or monastic school. The Mugs are all Buddhists. They are very good clearers of jungle for a time, but seem wanting in persistent energy. During the five years I was in the district, they had made no noticeable extension of cultivation. Many, indeed, seem to have returned to Arracan, and the number and energy of those who remain are not sufficient to make much impression on the vast jungles by which they are surrounded. The number of Mugs in the district, according to the census, is 4049, of whom 2140 are men and 1909 women.

The Mugs are well spoken of by Bengalis for their truthfulness. As a general rule, they are inoffensive, though I am sorry to say that they have been losing their good reputation, and that some dacoities and other crimes have lately been committed by them. I cannot say that I have been favourably impressed by them. They are a dirty people, and have not the art of making their houses look pretty or comfortable. They only know how to clear jungle and to plant rice, and for their

[1] The Mugs at Chapli informed me that Thungari was not the first settler, and that Anju Chaudhari was the first to come. One Mirasat Chaudhari told me that Anju Chaudhari and Amparit Chaudhari were the first settlers, and that Boro Baisdia was the first settlement.

*dhulat—i.e.*, cold-weather crops—they rely upon their Mahomedan tenants and neighbours. Some Mugs settled in Kúkri Múkri, but their rice crops suffered extremely from the Sundarban rats, which are there large and numerous. The Mugs speak and write their own language, but have also picked up a colloquial knowledge of Bengali. They are generally addressed by Bengalis by the title of Chaudhari—a title which seems to have originated with Chila Chaudhari, a Mug who made a good deal of money, and was well known to the Government officers.

The Mugs live in houses raised on piles, and thatched with the *golpati*. They make ropes of the *banpát*, a species of hibiscus, and the women weave cloth. They are addicted to the use of opium. They have a great objection to the payment of rent, and often desert their clearings when it is demanded. They are quite omnivorous, and regard as a great delicacy the turtles' eggs, which they collect on the chars.

As Kúkri Múkri is seldom visited by Europeans, I append here an account of a visit which I made to it in October 1874 :—

"Next morning we left Kalmi, and sailed down to Kúkri Múkri. In doing so we left the *maij—i.e.*, middle char—and the wooded island of Chopa on our left, and the reedy and swampy island of Nalua on our right. This island of Nalua is not marked on the maps, as it formed only about four years ago. At Kúkri Múkri we moored in a khál near the sheds of some buffalo-herdsmen. The island is large, and covered with dark tree jungle. It lies athwart the stream, and at a distance it looks like a huge black alligator stretched out on the water. The buffalo-herdsmen, who were Mahomedans, told us that they came from Kalmi char, that they kept

their buffaloes at Kúkri Múkri up to December and January, and that they then removed them, as the water got salt, and the herbage became unfit for food. To my surprise the water both on the south and east side of Kúkri Múkri was perfectly fresh on the occasion of our visit, and I believe it remains so till December, or even later. Such a fact as this, I think, gives a very strong impression of the immense volume of water which must be brought down by the rivers, for a reference to the map will show that Kúkri Múkri is almost in the Bay of Bengal. We learned from the herdsmen that the only permanent inhabitants of the island were a few Mugs or Burmese, who lived on the banks of a creek to the eastward. We went off to visit them, and in doing so passed through the dōn or channel—called the Daiar dōn—which divides Kúkri from Múkri, or rather Kukuria from Mekuria. The sides of the dōn were thickly clothed with wood, and the creepers, with which the trees were often festooned, had a very pretty appearance. There was no sound, however, in the wood, except the occasional short whistle of a bird, and almost the only life to be seen was a kingfisher flitting with his brilliant plumage over the muddy water. It seemed almost a profanation that so beautiful a bird should have his home by a sullen creek fit only for alligators and their like, instead of dwelling by the crystal waters of a mountain stream. But such is nature; and we need perhaps not wonder to find a kingfisher and mud together, when we reflect that the most brilliant dyes are extracted from a substance so nasty as coal tar. We found the Mug settlement to consist of seven households. They had been on the island for four years, and had tried to grow rice, but had failed on account of the great number of bandicoot rats. I am afraid that Mugs do

not in the long-run make good settlers. They are very energetic for a year or two, and clear a lot of jungle, but they seem to relapse into lazy habits after a time. Khela, the principal Mug, spoke favourably of the island. He said the climate was cool and healthy, the soil rich, and that there were no tigers. If the rats could only be kept down—and surely this might be done with the help of poison—the island might become highly cultivated. I suppose it has an area of about seven thousand acres. There is another island to the east of it called Phul Kachia, and to the east of it again there is a small island with trees on it, and which is not marked on the map. I did not go to it, but Khela informed me that the Mugs occasionally visit it in quest of turtles' eggs. The trees at Kúkri Múkri grow to the height of fifty or sixty feet. The chief tree is called the kerua. I did not see any sundari-trees on the island, and the Mugs told me that there are none. The sundari is rarely met with on the chars, and is indeed by no means so common in the Sundarbans as one would expect. In Chopa, which is a little to the north of Kúkri Múkri, I saw only two or three young trees of sundari. The kerua was the prevailing tree. Another tree which is very common on the chars is the *bolye*. This tree does not seem to be so well known as it deserves. Its inner bark yields a strong fibre, which the herdsmen twist into tethering ropes for their buffaloes, and which is also largely used instead of rattan or string in the roofing of houses. The tree is bushy, with large leaves, and seems to affect especially the sides of kháls. It grows so abundantly that possibly the bark might have a commercial value. When burnt it yields an ash which is used by the washermen as a substitute for soap. I questioned Khela Mug about the curious phenomenon known by the name of the

Barisál guns. He said that he heard them often in the months of Jaist and Ashar—*i.e.*, in the beginning of the rains. He described the sound as being exactly that of the discharge of a cannon, and said it appeared to have no connection with the tide, and that the noise was quite different from that of the bore or of the coming in of the breakers. The noises appeared to come from the north, south, and south-west. This statement, that they are sometimes heard from the north, is important, for hitherto we have supposed that no one ever got to the south of them. It is because they are always heard from the south that natives poetically represent them as caused by the shutting and opening of Ravan's gate in the island of Lanka (Ceylon). Khela's statement seems conclusive against three hypotheses for the origin of the sounds. These are—1st, that they are nothing but the guns fired at marriage processions; 2d, that they are caused by the falling in of the river-banks; 3d, that they are the sound of the breakers. But there are no marriage processions and no high river-banks north of, or anywhere near, Kúkri Múkri; and as the breakers come in on the south side of Kúkri Múkri with great force in the stormy season, Khela must be well acquainted with the sound they make. When, therefore, both he and the Mugs at Chapli say that the Barisál guns are not the sound of the breakers, I do not see how we can refuse to believe them. The conclusion, therefore, which I come to is that the sounds are atmospheric, and in some way connected with electricity. In conclusion, I should mention that there are no deer on Kúkri Múkri or the neighbouring island of Chopa, but there are wild buffaloes and wild pigs. On Kúkri Múkri there are also wild cattle, which are said by some to have been carried there by an inundation, and by others to be

the remains of some cattle employed by former cultivators."—*Bengal Times*, November 7, 1874.

### II. WERE THE SUNDARBANS INHABITED IN ANCIENT TIMES?

This is a question which has excited a great deal of attention. The Bengali mind, as being prone to the marvellous, and to the exaltation of the past at the expense of the present, has answered the question in the affirmative, and maintains that there were formerly large cities in the Sundarbans. Some persons also have suggested that the present desolate condition of the Sundarbans may be due to a subsidence of the land, and that this may have been contemporaneous with the formation of the submarine hollow known as the "Swatch of No Ground." It seems to me, however, to be very doubtful indeed that the Sundarbans were ever largely peopled, and still more so that their inhabitants lived in cities or were otherwise civilised. As regards the eastern half of the Sundarbans—namely, that which lies in the districts of Bákarganj and Noakháli, and includes Sandwip and the other islands in the estuary of the Meghna—it seems to me that the fact of so much salt having been manufactured there in old times militates against the view of an extensive cultivation, for the salt could not have been made without a great expenditure of fuel, and this of course implies the existence of large tracts of jungle. Du Jarric speaks of Sandwip as being able to supply the whole of Bengal with salt, and it seems evident that in old times salt was reckoned as the most valuable production of this part of the country. How inimical this must have been to a widespread cultivation of the neighbouring tracts may be judged of from the fact that in modern times the Government salt

manufacture was a great obstacle to the clearing and colonising of the chars and islands in Bákarganj and Noakháli. The Government officers used to insist upon the jungle being maintained for the supply of the tafals, and the disputes between them and the lessees of waste lands and other settlers led to much correspondence. The tendency of the salt manufacture to keep land out of cultivation is shown by the circumstance, elsewhere mentioned by me, that the zamindars of Dakhin Shahbázpúr annually obtained a large reduction of their land revenue on account of some of their lands being taken up for the salt manufacture.

Sandwip was, it is true, cultivated in Cæsar Frederick's time (1569), but so it is now, and there is no reason to suppose that its civilisation was greater then than it is at present. It may have had at that time, as it certainly had some thirty or forty years later, one or more forts, but these were marks of insecurity rather than of prosperity, and they do not now exist simply because there is peace in the land, and the Arracanese and the Portuguese pirates are no longer formidable.

Ralph Fitch visited Bákla in 1586, and describes the country as being very great and fruitful. He does not expressly say that Bákla was a city, and it is possible that he found the people of the country living, as they do now, in detached houses, and not crowded together in large towns. But even if we take the words, "the houses be very fair and high builded, the streets large," to mean that there was a city of Bákla, and give full credence to Fitch's statements, the next clause of his description—viz., "the people naked, except a little cloth about their waist"—does not suggest the existence of much civilisation or refinement. Moreover, it appears to me that Fitch was not a very observant or satisfac-

tory traveller. His descriptions of places are meagre, and his itinerary not distinct. I think, too, that if he had kept his eyes and ears open he must have been able to tell us something about the great storm which had devastated Bákla only a twelvemonth or so before his arrival. It is hardly possible that a storm which is said to have drowned 200,000 people could have left no physical marks behind it which Fitch might have seen, and, at all events, its moral effects must have been still existent, and Fitch could hardly have had any intercourse with the inhabitants without hearing of it. I think, therefore, that we must not press his statements too far. It is not likely that he stayed long at the place.

However, the question of Fitch's credibility and intelligence is not very material, for there is nothing to show that Bákla was situated in the Sundarbans. It probably was the same as Kachua, which, according to tradition, was the old seat of the Chandradwip rajahs. But Kachua is in thana Baufal, which is at this day one of the most fertile and best cultivated parts of Bákarganj, and is the only thana in the south of the district which contains a large Hindu population. No doubt there has been a great amount of diluviation near Kachua, and the river between the mainland and Dakhin Shahbázpúr has become much wider than it was in old times. In this way the old city of Bákla and much of its territory may have disappeared, and to this extent there probably has been a decay of civilisation. I have no doubt also that many settlers in the south of the district, especially the Hindu portion of them, left their homes when the Chandradwip rajahs removed to Madhabpásha, and when the Mug inroads became troublesome, but I do not believe that these settlers were very

numerous, or that they were civilised and dwelt in cities, &c.

Another thing which indisposes me to believe in the early colonisation of the eastern Sundarbans is the terrible hardships which the crew and passengers of the ship "Ter Schelling" suffered on this coast in 1661. The "Ter Schelling" was a Dutch ship which sailed from Batavia for Angueli (Hijlí), in Bengala, on the 3d September 1661, and which was wrecked off the coast of Bengal on the 8th of the following month. The narrative of the shipwreck, and of the sufferings and adventures of the crew and passengers, was written by one of the latter named Glanius. He was, I presume, a Dutchman, and his account was first published at Amsterdam, and afterwards, in 1682, at London, under the title of "A Relation of an Unfortunate Voyage to the Kingdom of Bengala." The shipwrecked men seem to have landed on an island near Sandwip, and their sufferings from hunger were most terrible. They were compelled to live on most disgusting objects, such as a putrid buffalo, a dead tortoise, a small quadruped called by the natives a *legane*, and which the sailors found eating the buffalo, serpents, snails, &c. A chief part of their sustenance was derived from eating the leaves of the jungle trees, and they even tried eating grass, but this they could not manage. Their only drink was salt water. They saw very few inhabitants, and those whom they did come across were in almost as wretched a plight as they themselves, and appeared to have been driven out from more civilised regions. They were several times on the eve of resorting to cannibalism, but eventually they got to Sandwip, where they were kindly treated by the Governor and sent on to Balwa (Bhalloah). The Prince of Balwa was also kind to them, and sent them on to

Deeka (Dacca), where they were impressed, and made to serve under Mir Jamla in the war against Assam. Eventually they got their release and made their way to Hijlí, but Glanius did not return to Europe for several years. Unfortunately, he does not clearly mention the site of his shipwreck, but it was apparently somewhere on the sea-coast of the Sundarbans. The people whom he met, or at least some of them, were Mahomedans, for they used the expression *salam*.[1]

I do not wish, however, to lay too much stress on Glanius's description, for his shipwreck took place in 1661, and it may be that "the depopulation by Mugs" noted in Rennel's map occurred at an earlier date. Indeed, we know from Du Jarric that the King of Arracan conquered Bákla in the beginning of the seventeenth century, and it may be that the desolation of the country dates from this time.

I may also notice here that the copperplate inscription found at Idilpúr in Bákarganj, and described by Babu Pratáp Chandra Ghose in the Asiatic Society's Journal (1838), seems to indicate that the inhabitants of that part of the country belonged to a degraded tribe called the Chandabhandas,[2] a fact which is not favourable to the supposition of the Sundarbans having been at an early period inhabited by a high-caste population.

By far the most interesting account of the Sundarbans is contained in the letters of the Jesuit priests who visited Bákarganj and Jessore in 1599 and 1600. They were addressed to Nicholas Pimenta, a visitor of the order stationed at Goa, and were forwarded by him,

[1] In Professor Blochmann's "Contributions to the Geography, &c., of Bengal," p. 18, reference is made to Van den Broucke's map in Valentyn's work, as showing the place where the "Ter Schelling" was wrecked.

[2] Babu P. C. Ghose compares the Chandabhandas to the Molunghies.

along with some remarks of his own, to Claude Aquaviva, who was then general of the order. The letters seem to have been originally written in Italian, and were first published at Venice in 1602 or 1603, and were afterwards translated into Latin and French. I was indebted for my introduction to them to my friend Dr Wise, who told me that they were quoted in "Purchas's Pilgrimage." Extracts from the letters and the subsequent history of the mission will be found in Pierre du Jarric's "Histoire des Choses plus memorables advenues aux Indes Orientales," &c., Bordeaux, 1608–14.

It appears from Pimenta's account that he sent the priests Fernandez and Sosa to Bengal in 1598, and two others—namely, Melchior da Fonseca and Andrew Bowes—in the following year. Fernandez and Sosa sailed from Cochin on 3d May 1598, and arrived in eighteen days at the Little Port (Porto Pequino). From thence they sailed up the river to Gullo or Goli, where they arrived in eight days after leaving Porto Pequino. From here they seem to have gone on to Chittagong. While at Gullo they received an invitation from the King of a place called Chandecan (in Italian, Ciandecan) to pay him a visit. They did not go then, but as Fernandez afterwards heard that the King was angry at their not coming to him, he sent Sosa to Chandecan sometime in 1599, and he met with a very favourable reception. Afterwards Fernandez himself went to Chandecan in October 1599, and got letters-patent from the King authorising him to carry on the mission. In December 1599 Fernandez was at Sripúr, and on the 22d of that month he wrote a letter to Pimenta giving an account of the mission; and on 20th January 1600 Fonseca wrote a similar letter from Chandecan. Fonseca's letter is most interesting, and has been quoted at p. 31.

For my present purpose it is only necessary that I quote the following passage: "The King [of Bákla], after compliments, asked me where I was bound for, and I replied, 'I am going to the King of Ciandecan, who is to be your Highness's father-in-law.'" These words are extremely important, because they help us to identify both the King of Bákla and the King of Chandecan. Chandecan, as I hereafter will show, is identical with Dhumghát or Jessore, and the boy-king of Bákla (Fonseca says he was only eight years old) can be no other than Ram Chandra Rai, who, we know, married a daughter of the famous Pratápáditya. Before, however, going into this matter, I wish to draw attention to Fonseca's description of the journey from Bákla to Chandecan (see p. 31). Now, though the good father evidently had an eye for natural scenery, and was delighted with the woods and rivers, it is evident that what he admired so much must have appeared to many to be "horrid jungle," and indeed was very like what the Sundarbans now are. In fact, Fonseca's description of the route from Bákla to Chandecan might almost be used at the present day to describe the route from Barisál to Kaliganj, near which Pratápáditya's capital was situated. The chief difference is that the progress of civilisation has driven away the herds of deer and the monkeys from the ordinary routes, though they are still to be found in the woods, and the herds of deer have given their name to one of the largest rivers in the Sundarbans (Haringháttá). The faithfulness of Fonseca's description seems indicated by his modestly admitting that he had never seen a rhinoceros, while stating (quite truly) that there were such animals in the woods. Had Fonseca come upon any town on his journey, it is reasonable to suppose that he would have mentioned

it; and my point is, that his description shows that the Sundarbans were in much the same condition in 1599 as they are in now.

I may add that the missionaries speak of dacoits as infesting the rivers, which certainly was a marked feature of the Sundarbans up to the last fifty or sixty years. Fonseca arrived at Chandecan on the 20th November 1599, and there he found Fernandez' companion, Dominic de Sosa. The King received Fonseca with great kindness, so much so that he says a Christian prince could not have behaved better to him. A church was built at Chandecan, and was formally opened on 1st January 1600. It was the first church in Bengal, and was on this account dedicated to Jesus Christ. Chittagong was the second, and Bandel the third. The last was built about this time by a Portuguese named Villalobos.

In reply to the questions, Where was Chandecan, and who was its King? I answer, that as I believe Chandecan to have been identical with Dhumghát, or at least in the same neighbourhood, it must have lain in the Twenty-four Parganas, and near the modern bazár of Kaliganj, and that its king was no other than Partápáditya.

My reasons for this view are, firstly, that Chandecan[1] or Ciandecan is evidently the same as Chand Khan, which, as we know from the life of Rajah Pratápáditya, by Ram Ram Bosu (modernised by Haris Chandra Tarkalankar), was the name of the former proprietor of the estate in the Sundarbans which Pratápáditya's father

[1] Chandecan does not appear to be marked on any of the old maps, and as far as I am aware Bernouilli is the only other person besides the priests who refers to it. In the article on the Feringhies of Chittagong, in "Calcutta Review," Bernouilli is quoted as speaking of *Kandecan*, an old name for the province of Satigam, which included Hughli, &c.

Bikramaditya got from King Daoud. Chand Khan Masandari had died, we are told, without leaving any heirs, and consequently his territory, which was near the sea, had relapsed into jungle. Bikramaditya saw that King Daoud would be ruined, as he had taken upon himself to resist the Emperor of Delhi, and therefore Bikramaditya, who was his minister, took the precaution of establishing a retreat for himself in the jungles. King Daoud was killed in 1576, and Bikramaditya, though he had prepared a city beforehand, seems to have gone to it in person about this time. His dynasty had been only about twenty-four or twenty-five years in the country when the Jesuits visited it, and it would have been quite natural if the name of the old proprietor (Chand Khan) had still clung to it. Moreover, we know that Pratápáditya did not live always, at least, at his father's city of Jessore. He rebelled against him, and established a rival city at Dhumghát. In so doing he may have selected the site of Chand Khan's capital, and this may have retained the name of Chand Khan for two or three years after Pratápáditya had removed to it. Nor is there anything in this opposed to the fact that one Khanja Ali formerly owned Jessore; Khanja Ali died in 1458, or about 120 years before Bikramaditya appeared on the scene, so that Chand Khan may very well have been the name of one of Khanja Ali's descendants.

But there is still more evidence of the identity of Chandecan with Dhumghát.

The fair prospects of the mission, as described by Fernandez and Fonseca, were soon overclouded. Fernandez died, on 14th November 1602, in prison in Chittagong, in consequence of injuries which he had received in a tumult there, and the other priests took refuge in Sandwip. In

consequence, however, of a war with the King of Arracan, they soon left the island and took refuge in Chandecan. But the King of Chandecan was cruel and treacherous (traits which agree with the description of Pratápáditya), and was desirous of making his peace with the King of Arracan, who was then very powerful, and had, as Du Jarric informs us, taken possession of the kingdom of Bákla. Carvalho, the gallant captain of the Portuguese, was at Chandecan, and the King of Chandecan, who was then at "Jasor,"[1] sent for Carvalho, and had him murdered in order to ingratiate himself with the King of Arracan. Du Jarric adds that the news of Carvalho's murder at Jasor reached Chandecan on the following midnight, which may give us some idea of the distance between the two places.

This ended the Bengal Mission, for the King of Chandecan destroyed the church and ordered the priests out of the country. We are glad to think that this king, if he was, as we believe, Pratápáditya, shortly afterwards expiated his crimes and died in an iron cage at Benares. That Pratápáditya was a cruel monster, and quite capable of directing the assassination of a brave man like Carvalho, we have proof enough in the work of his admiring biographer, who tells us that Pratápáditya cut off the breasts of a female slave who had offended him.

There are two other slight pieces of evidence in support of the identity between Pratápáditya and the King of Chandecan. One is that Du Jarric tells us that the

[1] *Jasr* means "bridge" in Arabic, and General Cunningham derives the name Jessore from this word, and observes that the appellation indicates the nature of the country. He also states that the old name of the Ganges delta was Samotata. Murali was an old name for Jessore; query, was this connected with Muradkhana, which we know to have been an old name for the Sundarbans?

young King of Bákla was absent when the King of Arracan overran his territory, and we know that Ram Chandra Rai was for awhile a prisoner in the city of his father-in-law, who wished to assassinate him. Another is that when Fernandez came to Chandecan in October 1599, and got the King's signature to the letters-patent, he took the precaution of having them also signed (with the King's permission) by the King's son, who was then about twelve years old. This may have been Pratápáditya's son Udai Aditya, whom we know to have been a great friend of his brother-in-law Ram Chandra Rai, and to have succeeded in saving his life. The two young princes must, from the accounts of Fonseca and Fernandez, have been of nearly the same age, and this makes the story of their friendship all the more probable.

I must not omit to point out that the fact that Bikramaditya chose Jessore as a safe retreat is the strongest possible evidence of the jungly nature of the surrounding country. It is true it had been cultivated in the previous century by Khanja Ali, but the experiment had proved a failure, and the land had in the time of his successor, (?) Chand Khan, relapsed into jungle.

To sum up, it seems to me that the Sundarbans have never been in a more flourishing condition than they are in at present. I believe that large parts of Bákarganj and Jessore were at one time cultivated, that they relapsed into jungle, and that they have now been cleared again; and I have also no doubt that the Court of the Kings of Bákla and of Chandecan imparted some degree of splendour to the surrounding country; but I do not believe that the gloomy Sundarbans, or the sea

face of Jessore and Bákarganj, were ever well-peopled or the sites of cities.[1]

[1] The following interesting description of the Sundarbans, as they appeared in 1712–13, is given by Père Barbier in vol. xiii. of "Lettres edifiantes et curieuses," ed. 1781. Père Barbier accompanied Bishop Laynez when the latter made a visitation to the Bengal portion of his diocese, and this is what they saw on the journey from Chandarnagore to Chittagong: "Pour nous y (Chittagong) rendre nous eûmes à tenir une route affreuse. Huit jours entiers, quoiqu'on ramât dix-huit heures chaque jour et que le courant et souvent la marée fussent favorables, suffirent à peine pour nous faire trouver une habitation; jusques là nous ne vîmes que des bois épais, des bras de rivières par où le Gange se dégorge, tantôt d'une étendue prodigieuse, tantôt si étroits qu'on ne le pouvoit ramer que d'un côté. Les bords garnis de grandes arbres dont les branches s'avancent fort avant dans l'eau et par-dessus tout l'appréhension continuelle où l'on est des tigres dont on voit des vestiges de temps en temps par des pieux plantés aux endroits où il y a des personnes dévorées à terre ou bien enlevées jusque dans leurs bateaux. Dans l'eau se trouvent des crocodiles longs de vingt et trente pieds qui engloutissent hommes entiers. Enfin on y est souvent à la merci des voleurs qui rôdent incessament dans ces parages montés sur des *panceaux* (pansways) qui vont comme un trait." From Chittagong they went to Bhulu (Noakháli), where there was then a Christian settlement, and from thence to Dacca and Rangamatti, passing on the way Hooseinpúr in Mymensing.

The literature of the Sundarbans is very scanty. Ritter has collected the principal authorities in his "Erdkunde." Williamson, in his "East India Vade Mecum," gives some account of the state of the molunghies or salt-makers in the Sundarbans. See also Forbes's "Oriental Memoirs." Other authorities are Gastrell's Report, Westland's "Jessore," Hooker's "Himalayan Journal," vol. ii., Pogson's "Tour to Chittagong" (Serampúr, 1831), "Calcutta Review," March 1859, article "Gangetic Delta." A map of the Sundarban grants has been made by Mr Gomess, and I believe he has also written a memorandum on the Sundarbans. Lloyd's memoir, on his survey of the coast from Calcutta to Chittagong, is still in MS. (see Markham, Indian Surveys).

The Lieutenant-Governor considers that the reclamation of the Sundarbans has been carried sufficiently far for the present, and that there is a danger of the woods being too much cut down. No more clearing grants are to be made, and the tract has been placed under the management of the Forest Conservancy (B. A. Report for 1873–74, p. 36).

## CHAPTER VI.

### *GOVERNMENT ESTATES, ETC.*

The number of Government estates in Bákarganj was at one time very large, and though many of them have been sold, a considerable number still remain. There is probably no other district in Bengal Proper where Government has so many and such valuable estates, and therefore we may say that there is no other district in which Government has so large and direct an interest.

We have seen that Government is the zamindar of Buzurgumedpúr pargana, but besides this, it owns a great many islands and chars. This is a natural consequence of the fact that the district is an alluvial formation. The rivers continually throw up islands and chars, and under the resumption laws these were taken possession of by Government. Of late years, however, resumption proceedings have nearly ceased, and Government now only takes possession of islands in navigable rivers. The existence of these is brought to light by Government officers in their tours, or more commonly by some one reporting that a sandbank has formed in such and such a river, and asking for a settlement of it These petitions are generally referred to a deputy-collector for inquiry, and if the formation is found to be really an island—*i.e.*, if the water between it and the shore is not fordable at any time of the year (Regulation 11 of 1825, sec. 4, cl. 3)—he takes possession of it by

sticking up a bamboo on it. Such inquiries are more protracted than they were in former days, for now private individuals are more alive to their rights and better skilled in maintaining them, and the decision of the Privy Council in the famous Lopez case has enabled many persons to raise with success the plea of reformation on an old site. The apparently simple question of fordability is not always easy of determination, for the rivers vary much in depth, according to the season and the state of the tide. According to the rule now in force, the question of fordability is decided when the rivers are at their lowest—*i.e.*, in or about the month of February. The number of islands in Bákarganj which are now the property of Government appears to be 133. Many of them belong to the Dakhin Shahbázpúr subdivision, and were transferred along with it to Bákarganj in 1869, from the district of Noakháli. The most interesting of the island-estates, or *jaziras*, as they are called, is Manpúra, an island situated to the south-south-east of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. It was resumed by the Commissioner of the Sundarbans in 1833, though it seems doubtful if the resumption was justifiable, for the island is an old formation, and was included in the partition of the Dakhin Shahbázpúr zamindari, which took place in 1188 B.S. (A.D. 1781)—that is, nine years before the Decennial Settlement. It is said to owe its name to one Man Ghazi, who got a lease from the Dakhin Shahbázpúr zamindars, and was the first to break up the soil. At the time of the resumption the island was in the hands of the zamindars, and there were 536 acres under cultivation. According to the papers of the partition already referred to, the amount of cultivation in 1781 was thirteen kanies—that is, about 250 bighas or 160 acres, as the kani in use in Manpúra is the large or

shahi kani, which is four times the size of the ordinary one. Manpúra is diluviating at the north-east, and alluviating at the south and west, where a large char called Kista Prasad has formed. The area of Manpúra is about fourteen square miles, and its population 4500. Three-fourths of the inhabitants are Hindus, so that the island is an exception to the general rule that the inhabitants of the islands and chars in Bákarganj are Mahomedans. The Hindus are all low-caste men, and are called Dasses or Halia Dasses—*i.e.*, Dasses who hold the plough, as distinguished from the Dasses who follow clerical pursuits, or who are fishermen. The Dasses are a quiet and well-behaved set of men, and are very hard-working. It is a Bengali saying that the Dass and the *bhaish—i.e.*, the buffalo—are equally strong and laborious. They have two customs which are looked upon with abhorrence by the stricter Hindus—they eat pigs, and they marry widows. The remaining fourth of the inhabitants are Mahomedans, and they too are quiet and inoffensive, and do not seem to be tinctured with any Ferazi notions. There are a schoolmaster, a post-master, a pound-keeper, and nine chaukidars on the island, but there is no magistrate nor any regular police. The island is well raised, and is very fertile, though rice is nearly the only product. There is no jungle on it except a belt which surrounds it, and which is preserved by the inhabitants because it breaks the force of the waves and keeps out the salt water from their cultivation. A few deer and a good many pigs live in this jungle, but there are no tigers or leopards. For everything except rice, milk, and firewood, the inhabitants have to depend on the markets in the adjacent island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. During the cold weather boats come from Dacca, and from the bazár of Bákarganj, &c.,

and export rice from the island. During the rains the island is not easily accessible, and is seldom visited by boats from a distance, though a ferry-boat regularly plies between it and Tazamuddin in Dakhin Shahbázpúr. I have referred in the chapter on under-tenures to the curious fact that four different classes of proprietors have sprung up in the island. The late settlements have been made with the *abádkárs*, but the rate of rent payable to them by the howaladars has been fixed at eleven anas three pies a bigha. The old rate prevalent in the island was Rs.2-8 the small or *karsha* kani, or eight anas four pies a bigha. No expenses of collection were allowed to the abádkárs or howaladars in former times; but, on the other hand, they were allowed a deduction on account of *ails*—*i.e.*, the limits or ridges separating the fields—and for *matan*, as it is called—*i.e.*, a deduction allowed to a tenant as his profit on condition of his bringing the adjacent lands into cultivation. The rate of rent actually paid in former times was, after deduction of matan and for ails, seven anas three pies a bigha. The above rate of Rs.2-8 a kani was the general one in all the Noakháli chars, and was adopted by Mr Ricketts in his settlements. Manpúra is divided into eight estates, the net revenue from which to Government is about Rs.8500. In 1844 the revenue was only Rs.1311. The first settlement was made in 1837, when Mr Ricketts was Commissioner of Chittagong. The holdings of the ryots under the howaladars and nim howaladars are called *jotes*. These inferior ryots are divided into two classes—viz., *khudkast* and *paikast*, the khudkast being those who cultivate lands on the estate on which they reside, and the paikast those who cultivate lands on other estates. The same person may be both a khudkast and a paikast ryot—

*i.e.*, khudkast with regard to the land he cultivates near his homestead, and paikast with regard to that which he cultivates at a distance. There are 226 khudkast ryots, and 179 of them have rights of occupancy. Sixty-six paikast ryots have similar rights. The total number of ryots is 566; so that if we reckon five to a family, the ryots number 2830, or more than half the population of the island. The other inhabitants are howaladars and nim howaladars, but they for the most part cultivate their own lands. The ryots pay Rs.16 to Rs.24½ per shahi kani, according to the nature of their lands. They have also to work two days in the year on the lands of their titular superiors, or to pay eight anas in lieu of this service. The island originally contained only one estate, which was divided into blocks under orders of Mr Ricketts in order to facilitate cultivation. When Mr Garrett, the Deputy-Collector of Noakháli, reported on the island in 1841, there were only two classes of residents—namely, howaladars and jotedars. Six out of the eight estates have been settled up to 1907 B.S.

The incidents in the history of Manpúra are not numerous. In 1218 B.S. (1811) the manufacture of salt was introduced, and caused so much oppression that 350 homesteads had been deserted by 1225 B.S. (1818). In 1229 B.S. (1822) a cyclone swept over the island and drowned most of the inhabitants, and another inundation took place in 1850, and led to a remission of one-fourth of the revenue. Four or five years ago a whale was stranded on the island, and some of its bones were afterwards brought to Barisál and placed in the public library. I have said there are no tigers or leopards; there are not even any jackals; but there are snakes, and cases of death from snake-bite occasionally

occur. I have referred to Mr Ricketts in connection with Manpúra, and I may take this opportunity of noticing that this officer (now Sir Henry Ricketts) is famous all over Dakhin Shahbázpúr and Noakháli, and, I believe, throughout the whole Chittagong division, for his settlements, and that there is no name more frequently or more honourably mentioned either by ryots or by old native servants of Government. His letter of 22d May 1841 is the most important one in the history of the settlements of Manpúra, and is that in which the title taluqdar is applied to the abádkárs.

There is a very full and excellent report about Manpúra by Babu Anand Chandra Sein, Deputy-Collector, dated 3d December 1873, and to this reference should be made by all who wish to know more about Manpúra and its settlements. The Babu made the settlements, which have lately been confirmed by the Board and by Government.

It would take up too much space if I were to describe the other islands belonging to Government, and I am not aware that there is anything specially interesting connected with them. Many of them have ceased to be islands, owing to the silting up of the intervening channels; and it is probable that at no distant date Manpúra will also cease to be an island, and be joined on to the Dakhin Shahbázpúr mainland. Many of the islands show by their names the periods at which they were formed, or at least at which they were taken possession of by Government. Thus we have Lord Hardinge char and Lawrence char (spelt Lallon on the map, and situated in Noakháli), which point to the period of the Sikh war; while Falcon char, Alexander char, Drummond char, Price char, Hankey char, Brown char, Ram Kanye char, Henderson char, &c., point to the time when the

officers whose names they bear were collectors of Noakháli, or otherwise employed in that district.

Besides the islands, there are ninety-four or ninety-five Government estates included in parganas, which have chiefly been acquired by purchase at sales for arrears of revenue. Such estates are not generally of much value, for it is almost always owing to their deterioration that Government has to put them up to sale for arrears of revenue, or that Government is enabled to purchase them at the upset price of Rs.1. Fifty-two of them belong to the pargana of Srírámpúr, forming part of an old estate called Gokul Mukarjya (see p. 147).

With the addition of Nos. 1406, 1437, and 1447 (described under pargana Buzurgumedpúr), the khas mahals—*i.e.*, Government estates (exclusive of the islands)—may be reckoned as numbering ninety-seven estates, and as bearing a revenue of about Rs.115,000.

There are also resumed or *bazyafti* estates. These are the property of individuals, but are managed by Government, either directly or through farmers, owing to the owners not accepting the terms of settlement offered by Government. Such resumptions were made under Regulation 2 of 1819 and 9 of 1825, and are to be distinguished from resumptions under Regulation 11 of 1825, whereby islands become the exclusive property of Government. There are 111 bazyafti mahals, and the Government revenue from them is about Rs.84,000. The owners receive *malikana* or proprietary allowance. Some bazyafti mahals not included in the 111 have been permanently settled with their owners. The bazyafti mahals are chiefly *taufirs*—*i.e.*, lands which have accreted since the Permanent Settlement, and which were not included in it. They are numerous in Dakhin Shah-

bázpúr, where the collections from resumptions amount to about Rs.50,000. The largest is Jainagar, which is managed directly by the Collector through a tahsildar, and which yields about Rs.15,000 a year. It belongs to the heirs of the notorious Sibkissen Banarji. The bazyafti mahals were let by Government to abádkárs or improving tenants, and now that the lands have been cleared the owners are coming forward and claiming them.

The large estate of Tushkháli in the Perozpúr subdivision is the exclusive property of Government, and should have been mentioned among the khas mahals. The rental is about Rs.78,000, and the estate is at present undergoing settlement with a view to enhancement. The rate of rent hitherto prevailing was Rs.1-4 a bigha. It was farmed to the Morrells for twenty years, but their lease has been cancelled, and it is now under direct management. Tushkháli was resumed from pargana Syedpúr, and was first cleared by the De Silva family. It was once sold to the Ghosal family, but the sale was cancelled in consequence of the lawsuit referred to at p. 158.

Fisheries.—It might be supposed that there would be many fisheries in Bákarganj belonging to Government. There are, however, only four, and the total revenue derived from them is very little more than one thousand rupees (1029). They are the Jahapúr Fishery, the Meghna Jhap Fishery, the Bishkháli Fishery, called Surjya Narain Chakrabarti or the Buzurgumedpúr Bishandi Jál, and the Bhashan Títulia. The first of these is a resumption, the second is a part of the Gokul Mukarjya taluq already referred to as lying in Srírámpúr pargana, and the third and fourth belong to pargana Buzurgumedpúr. There was a lawsuit about

the Bhashan Títulia Fishery in 1858, and there is a full account of it in a letter of Mr Collector Dalrymple to the judge, dated 11th December 1858. It appears that *bhashan*, or floating, means the right to collect rent from fishmongers who within certain limits in the Títulia buy fish from the fishermen. Bhashan Títulia was originally an under-tenure of Buzurgumedpúr, and was separated at the application of its owner in 1803, and registered as bearing a revenue of Rs.97-7-15. It was held that the right to such an estate was not affected by Regulation 27 of 1793. The taluq is now in the hands of the Chakrabarties of Rupatolli, who have given an ausat taluq of it to certain *nikaries* or fishmongers.

It appears that altogether there are 3232 estates on the Bákarganj revenue roll, but fifteen of these do not bear any revenue.

### COURT OF WARDS AND ATTACHED ESTATES.

The number of these is very small, and none of them possesses much interest or importance. The largest is the seven anas of Arangpúr pargana, which was attached by order of the Civil Court, and is under the charge of Mr Scott, the Sarbarakar or Manager-General. The most important ward's estate is that of the lunatic Jagat Narain Chakrabarti, who is a small shareholder in the Selímábád pargana, and resides at Raikátti. The estate is managed by his son.

# CHAPTER VII.

## *LAND TENURES.*

### I. TENURES-IN-CHIEF.

The tenures-in-chief of Bákarganj have been described in the chapter on financial history, and in the account of the different parganas, but before proceeding to describe the under-tenures it seems desirable to say a few words more about the zamindars.

The number of zamindaries in the district is reckoned to be 101,[1] but the number of zamindars is at least four or five times this number.[2] No notice is taken in the official registers of subdivisions of estates which have not been announced by the owners to the Collector, and there are many estates entered in one name, but which really belong to several families. In looking over the list of proprietors of zamindaries and independent taluqs, we find that most of them are Hindus of the Bráhman caste, and that there are comparatively few Mahomedans. The principal Bráhman family resident in the district is

[1] According to a return in the Bengal Administration Report for 1872–73, p. 74, there were forty-six large estates in Bákarganj, 664 of moderate size, and 4618 under 500 acres apiece. This includes the estates of the Mádaripúr subdivision, and I think exaggerates the number of large estates. At least it must not be supposed that each of these forty-six estates is in the hands of one man, or even family, for nearly every one of them is divided among several families. *N.B.*—The word "estate" includes all lands paying rent direct to Government, whether they be zamindaries, taluqs, or farms.

[2] According to census, there are 1963 zamindars (males only).

that of the Arangpúr zamindar, for the Tagore and Ghosal families are absentees. Some country-born Greeks, Armenians, and Eurasians have properties in the district, but no one of European birth and parentage holds land in Bákarganj.

The dearth of old Mahomedan families in a district which is so full of Mahomedans, and where so many of the parganas and villages have names of Mahomedan origin, is not a little remarkable. Khajah Ahsanoolah of Dacca is a stranger to the district, and his possessions in it have all been acquired by purchase in comparatively recent times. Even the Shaistábád family, though commonly considered the best in the district, has not been long settled in it, the present family having acquired the estate by marriage, and having originally belonged to Faridpúr. The Mahomedan families of Charamudi, Bamna, and Gyanpara are of no great standing, and do not enjoy much respect. The family which is really the oldest, is, I believe, that of the Mozamdars of Chákár; but they, as well as the old family who once held Nazirpúr pargana, have long ceased to be zamindars. It appears certain that Mahomedan families are less able to keep up with the age than Hindus, and that they decline more rapidly. Even those which still keep a footing in the district are for the most part in insolvent circumstances. It would be difficult and invidious to discuss minutely the causes of this difference between Mahomedans and Hindus, but I think something must be attributed to the practice of polygamy among the former. At least this seems to have led to the ruin of the Nazirpúr family, the last zamindar before the Permanent Settlement having left twelve sons by different mothers to dispute his succession. It is also a fact admitted by Mahomedans themselves that the

wealthy professors of their creed are more prone to idleness and dissipation than are Hindus.

### II. UNDER-TENURES.

Bákarganj is famous for the number of its under-tenures. It has been supposed that this is due to the litigious and intriguing character of the inhabitants, and no doubt this cause has not been without effect; but even the people most prone to litigation and intrigue seldom act from the mere love of these things, and we must, I think, search deeper for the efficient cause of so much sub-infeudation.

Undoubtedly the first cause is the physical characteristics of the district. This has acted in two ways: firstly, it has made the principal landholders absentees, and has thrown the direct management of the soil into the hands of the under-tenants; and secondly, it has made the latter insist upon permanency of tenure.

Bákarganj has never been a favourite residence of the wealthier classes. Its remoteness from Calcutta, its large rivers and the banditti who infested or were supposed to infest them, and above all, the jungle and the salt air, have made the upper classes shy of living in it. The great zamindaries of the district are held by absentees, and by absentees of the most pronounced type, for I believe that the present holders of the three largest properties in Bákarganj — viz., Khajah Ahsanoolah and the representatives of the Ghosal and Tagore families—have never even set foot in the district.

The zamindars who do live in Bákarganj are generally too poor to have much influence, and besides, even they live a long way off from portions of their estates, and owing to difficulties of communication, &c., seldom visit

them. In the cold season, when the *aman* harvest has been gathered in and the ryots are flush of money, the zamindars and taluqdars are in the habit of making progresses through their estates, and of collecting rents and presents. But for nine months in the year the under-tenantry are left to themselves and the land-stewards. Even the latter are not always present, for as they are generally Hindus, they do not like to live in the midst of a Mahomedan population. They go to their homes at the time of the *durga puja*, and do not return for two or three months. As, therefore, the zamindars cannot, or do not, live on their estates, they are forced, in Burke's phrase, to govern with a loose rein, and to allow the under-tenantry to create or acquire transferable rights. But apart from this, it is plain that when a country is covered with jungle, people will not settle in it, or undertake the cultivation of it, unless they get permanency of tenure. Therefore, as in old times, much of Bákarganj was covered with Sundarban jungle, and as also much of it consisted of newly-formed land, which could not be made productive until several years after occupation, the Government and the zamindars found it necessary to grant improving leases carrying permanent rights. Hence arose the system of jangál-buri taluqs, *abdas*, &c. The pargana of Buzurgumedpúr was entirely composed of such taluqs, and it is chiefly by the instrumentality of the holders of them that the revenue of the pargana has been raised from a few thousand rupees to upwards of two lacs. It is a common stipulation in improving leases that no rent is to be paid for the first two or three years, and that there is to be a progressive rate, or *rasad*, as it is called, until the full rate (*pura dastúr*) has been attained. The technical name for a reclaimer of jungle in Bákarganj is *abádkár*

—*i.e.*, clearer or cultivator—and his tenure is called *abádkári* or *abádi*. But the freedom from rent for several years is such a general incident of the tenure that the word *abda*, which seems to be a corruption of abádi, has come to mean rent free. Thus, to hold land abda, means in Bákarganj to hold it rent free, though the term is only applied to lands held temporarily rent free for purposes of cultivation.

As a proof that the system of under-tenures is the growth of circumstances, and is not to be ascribed to the chicanery of the Bákarganj ryots, I may refer to the island of Manpúra, which is a Government property, and which, up to the last five years, belonged to the district of Noakháli. Government acquired possession of this island about forty years ago, under a decree of the Resumption Commissioner. It was then nearly all covered with jungle, and the few cultivators who inhabited it appear to have been all of one class, and to have borne the name of jotedars. At present there are about 4500 inhabitants on the island, and there are four classes of persons possessing distinct rights in the soil. There are first the abádkárs or taluqdars, who pay the Government revenue; secondly, the howaladars; thirdly, the nim howaladars; and fourthly, the karshadars or simple cultivators.

"It is a natural consequence of hereditary benefices," says Hallam, "that those who possess them carve out portions to be held of themselves by a similar tenure." This result, which appeared in the feudal system in Europe, has not failed to show itself in India, for human nature is the same everywhere. The existence of a right generally leads to the exercise of it, and persons who acquire permanent and transferable interests in land soon begin to alienate them in whole or in part.

Another cause of sub-infeudation is that tracts of uncultivated land are often let out to several persons who club together to clear them. Thus the lease of a howala is often in the names of ten or twelve persons. At first they all cultivate the land together, and generally one of their number has a certain representative capacity, and is the man to whom the landlord looks for rent. But as cultivation advances, the lands become marked off into aliquot parts, two anas, four anas, &c., or portions of them are granted to inferior tenants, as nim howalas, karshas, &c. A ryot cannot cultivate more than a certain amount of land—say forty or fifty bighas at the outside—and if, therefore, he get a grant of jungle which is double or quadruple that size, he is obliged in time to let out a portion to some one. It is a mistake to suppose that the cultivation of jungle in Bákarganj has been accomplished by squatters. Mugs squat in the Sundarbans, and occasionally a Bengali may take possession of an uncultivated bit of land, but such instances are rare. Neither has the reclamation been accomplished by the zamindars or other large proprietors of land. As a rule, these men are absentees or indolent, and the main stress of the work of cultivation has fallen on the under-tenure holders or middlemen. It is the howaladar and the nim howaladar who have brought the Sundarbans and the chars of Dakhin Shahbázpúr into cultivation.

In consequence of under-tenures, we often find three or four persons holding different rights in the same piece of ground. It has been said that the number sometimes amounts to eight or nine, but I have never come across an instance of so many. It is quite common, however, to find three or four; and it is this complication which makes the taking up of land for public

purposes such a thorny piece of business in Bákarganj. At the top we have the zamindar or independent taluqdar, who pays the revenue to Government, and who is thus the tenant *in capite* of feudal law. After him come the ausat taluqdar, the howaladar, the nim howaladar, and the karshadar or tiller of the soil. The karshadar is the lowest in the scale, unless we add the borghadar; but there is more than one description of karsha-tenure. There is the *miras karsha*, or *miras malguzari*, as it is also called, which is a hereditary and transferable tenure, and is often underlaid by the *miadi* or temporary karsha. The incidents of a karsha are different also in different parts of the district. Thus in Dakhin Shahbázpúr a karsha is by local custom transferable by sale, and is sold in execution of decrees accordingly, whereas in Bákarganj Proper karshas are generally looked upon as not saleable. All over the district, however, ryots are in the habit of selling their holdings, especially their homesteads, and in practice these transfers are generally recognised by the superior landlord. The rent is commonly paid to a gomasta or tahsildar, and he is glad enough to get it, for often he has contracted to pay a certain sum to his master, whatever his collections may amount to; and if the transferee pays him the rent, and also gives him a *nazzar* or present, he seldom objects to the change of name.

It must not be supposed that because there are a great number of under-tenures in Bákarganj, there must be at least an equal number of distinct persons who hold these separate rights. It often happens that one and the same person holds three or four classes of rights in the same piece of ground; and thus, though it is common enough to find four or five gradations of rights in

one field, it is not so common to find that each of these rights is held by a distinct person. Thus the same person is often both ausat taluqdar and howaladar; and nearly all zamindars and taluqdars possess subordinate rights in their estates, and are their own ausat taluqdars, howaladars, and even karshadars. The existence of each of these rights is carefully kept up in the zamindari accounts, and leads to a very intricate system of debit and credit, or *jama kharach*, as it is called. Thus a zamindar will be found crediting himself with rent payable to him as zamindar by himself as howaladar, and again debiting himself as howaladar with the rent due to himself as zamindar. Nor is the system so superfluous or irrational as it at first sight appears. It arises in a great measure from the subdivision of property, and from the fact of many estates being held jointly — *i.e.*, *ijmáli*. Thus a person may have a two or three-and-a-half ana share in a zamindari, and under this there is a taluq or howala, the rent of which is payable to all the shareholders in the zamindari—that is, in the case under illustration, the person gets two or two and a half anas rent of the taluq or howala; but if this taluq or howala is sold by decree of court or otherwise, and the shareholder in the zamindari buy it, he acquires a new right, and one which may be very valuable to him. If the whole right in the taluq or howala—*i.e.*, the sixteen-ana right, as it is called—is sold, he becomes full proprietor of the lands comprised in it, and pays fourteen or thirteen and a half anas of the rent of it to his co-sharers in the zamindari, and pays the remainder to himself. It does not follow that because he has bought the taluq or howala, he gets khas or direct possession of the land; for there may be a nim howala or a karsha below the right he has pur-

chased, and if he wishes direct possession, he may have to go on purchasing the other rights in the land. It is the contests between shareholders in zamindaries about the buying or otherwise getting possession of under-tenures in their joint estates which lead to so much fighting amongst them in and out of the courts. Though we may deplore the circumstance, we can hardly say that it is absurd or unnatural. It is also this system which makes it so very difficult to carry through a bat-wara or partition in Bákarganj, or indeed anywhere in Bengal. At first sight it seems simple enough to divide a zamindari into three or four shares, but when we find that the zamindari share is by no means the only, or even the most valuable right which each shareholder possesses, the problem becomes much more complicated. The shareholders in a zamindari often make a rough kind of division of their shares, or a Mofussil batwara, as they call it — that is, their zamindari lands are often distinct, and their ryots are distinct also. There are often ryots who pay the whole, or the sixteen anas, of their rent to one shareholder, and who have nothing whatever to do with any of the other shareholders, and this although no legal partition of the estate may have taken place; but the relation of ryot and zamindar is never the only one which exists in a joint estate. Each share is dovetailed into the others by an intricate series of under-tenures, and it is the separation and consolidation of these subsidiary rights possessed by the shareholders which constitutes the difficulty of making a partition. The outside public cannot be expected to know much of such matters, and may therefore be excused when they denounce the delay in making partitions, and ascribe it to the trickery of the amíns and *insouciance* of collectors. But I have known a Com-

missioner who was no better informed, and who gravely observed that all which was required for the partition of an estate containing some thirty thousand acres was to make a map of it, and then to divide it off into three or four blocks, according to the number and extent of the shares. Truly this seemed simple enough; but suppose that one block had consisted of under-tenures paying a low and unenhanceable rent, and that another had consisted of ryotwari land paying the full pargana rate, and the tenants of which could be evicted, where would be the equality in value of the two blocks?

Although the system of under-tenures has mainly arisen out of the physical characteristics of Bákarganj, I do not mean to say that their number has not often been multiplied unnecessarily by the subtlety or tenacity of the Bengali. One use frequently made of the large number of under-tenures is to enable a man to retain his hold on a property after one or more of his rights has been sold. Thus we may say that the sale-law is one cause of sub-infeudation. Suppose, for instance, that a zamindar's right and title in his zamindari are sold for arrears of revenue, or in satisfaction of a decree, it might be imagined that this would terminate his connection with the estate; but, as a general rule, this would be far from the case. The *mazul*—*i.e.*, quondam zamindar—does not surrender his hold on the land so readily. If he cannot in any way impeach the sale by showing that he did not get notice of it, that the estate was sold below its value, that the decree was fraudulent, &c., or that the property did not belong to him, but was his wife's or his brother-in-law's, he proceeds to another battle-field, and claims to hold a nij taluq—*i.e.*, a taluq belonging to the zamindar—or a howala, or other under-tenure. Indeed,

the Bengali, and especially the Bákarganj Bengali, holds on to his land with a persistence which reminds one of the Athenian soldier who grasped the Persian ship with his right hand, and who, when that was cut off, seized it with his left, and when that too was lopped away, clung to it with his teeth. The last fight of all made by a dispossessed proprietor is generally that for the *khanabari* or paternal homestead, and is literally a fight *pro ará et foco*. The most serious riots in the district have their origin in disputes between the auction purchaser and the old proprietor, and the *casus belli* is then generally a dispute about an under-tenure. Such a riot occurred in the early part of this century, when the Tagores took possession of Idilpúr, and also when Ali Khan, the grandfather of Khajah Ahsanoolah, took possession of his share of Selímábád, &c.

Zimba.—A practice which gives rise to much sub-infeudation, and to many breaches of the peace, is that called *zimba*, and which seems, in name at least, peculiar to Bákarganj. Zimba literally means charge or protection, and the system of zimba, as it is understood in Bákarganj, means a practice by which a ryot, or other subordinate holder of land, transfers his allegiance from his proper landlord to a third party. This third party is called his *zimbadar*. Thus A. B. is a ryot having a right of occupancy in his land. He is oppressed by his landlord or is discontented with him, and so he goes to another proprietor and offers to come under his zimba. If this offer be accepted, he generally transfers his holding to his protector by deed of sale, and receives it back again by another deed. Thus the possession of the land does not actually pass, the ryot continues to hold his house and land as before, but pays his rent to his zimba-

dar, who in turn pays it to the real landlord. Should the latter refuse to receive it, it is deposited in court, or simply withheld till a suit is brought and a decree obtained. In the deed by which the ryot gets back his land he is generally described as getting the tenure next below that which he sold. Thus if he be a howaladar, he sells the howala and becomes the nim howaladar; if he is a miras karshadar, he becomes an ordinary karshadar. If in reality he have no transferable right, and be merely an occupancy-ryot, or even a ryot without the right of occupancy, he will still describe himself as an under-tenure holder of some kind—*i.e.*, a nim howaladar—and so get over the difficulty of his position. The system of zimba is especially common in ijmáli or joint estates, and the reason for this is intelligible enough. When a ryot has several masters he is often oppressed or harassed by them. He therefore finds it his best plan to come under the zimba of the most powerful or the most troublesome among them, as thenceforth he has only one man to conciliate. The system is a bad one, and nothing gives rise to more disputes. I am sorry to say, too, that it appears to have received a fresh impetus from the passing of the Registration law, and that many deeds which are pointed to as proofs of the increase of sub-infeudation are in reality merely paper transfers, and do not express any substantive change in the tenancy of the land. I may note here that the purposes of the Registration law are often perverted by persons who want to take possession of land which does not belong to them. The Bengali cannot get rid of the idea that a registered *kabuliyat* is evidence against third parties; so when two parties are fighting about, say, the possession of a newly-formed char, each of them takes a troop of his dependents to the register office,

and makes them register kabuliyats or leases for land which they have not possession of. It is by no means easy to punish such proceedings, for as between the parties there is no fraud or deception, and if no action is taken after the registration, it is difficult to prove that a third party has been injured. There is, I think, a defect in the Registration law on this point.

When a ryot gives his land in zimba he generally gives a present or *salami* to the zimbadar, and, I believe, he defrays all the conveyancing expenses—*i.e.*, the stamps, registration fees, &c. The proper landlord of the ryot, of course, opposes the zimbadari process as much as possible, for not only does he lose prestige by his ryot being no longer "his man," so to speak, but he loses certain incidents of homage. In fact, he henceforth gets merely the bare rent of the land, and loses the cesses paid by the ryot, such as marriage presents, fines for cattle trespass, &c., as all these are paid to the zimbadar. In Hallam's "Middle Ages" mention is made of the system of commendation, which he describes as a personal relation between lord and vassal, resembling that of patron and client in the Roman Republic. I think that this system must have closely resembled the Bákarganj zimba, and I would suggest that the word "zimba" might be translated "commendation."

Perhaps the description of one or two actual cases of zimba will put the matter in a much clearer light. I shall take the first illustration from the subdivision of Perozpúr, which, by the way, is the most troublesome part of the district, and is to the other subdivisions of it what Bákarganj is to the rest of Bengal. There is a village called Kal Megha in the Matbária thana, in the Sundarban estate of Gyanpara, and away down at the

mouth of the Bishkháli river. The land had long remained as a Sundarban forest, but some years ago the wealthy Hindu family of the Seins or Mahallanavises of Basinda acquired certain rights in the place, and set about reclaiming the jungle. For this purpose they brought in ryots from other villages and settled them at a considerable expense. Here I must make a digression in order to explain the process by which jungle is reclaimed, when done not by the middlemen or under-tenure holders acting independently, but by a zamindar or moneyed man. It then becomes a regular case of colonisation. The zamindar does not, as might be supposed, hire a number of labourers to clear the ground, but he acts somewhat as the New Zealand Government acts with emigrants. He induces ryots to come and settle by making them advances for the removal of their houses and cattle, by giving them rice, by establishing a convenient market for them, &c. In many cases he has to purchase cattle for them, and to build their houses. Further, he takes no rent from them for three or four years, and he promises them permanency of tenure at a moderate rent. When a ryot accepts such terms and comes down to the jungle, he generally leaves his wife and family behind him for a year or two, and puts up a small house where he and one or two of his brothers or friends can sleep. In this *doala* homestead—*i.e.*, subsidiary or second home—he lives during the working season, and only occasionally revisits his home. If he find the place unhealthy, or too much infested with tigers, or otherwise unsuitable, he abandons it; but if he think that it will suit him, and elect to remain, he gradually plants fruit-trees, &c., and eventually brings away his old house (roof and all being carried on boats), and settles in the new place with his family. In mak-

ing such arrangements regular leases or pattas are not given at first. This would be too expensive, on account of the registration and stamp fees; and besides, neither party can precisely say what the land is worth until after two or three years' trial. The practice, therefore, is that either no documents are given at all, or only a preliminary one on unstamped paper, and not hard and fast in its terms. This is given to the ryot, and is called an *amilnama*.

This practice was followed by the Seins in Kal Megha, but after the ryots had been settled for some years, and had cleared a good deal of land, the Seins delayed or refused to give them permanent leases. The excuse given by them for not giving them was that the ryots were threatening to be rebellious, and that they were afraid lest, by giving them permanent, and therefore transferable rights, they should be putting weapons into their hands, which might be used against themselves by the transference of their rights to a zimbadar. Disputes arose between the Seins and the ryots about this, and as the quarrel was fomented by one Sidam Mia, a Mahomedan taluqdar of the neighbourhood, a number of the newly-settled ryots went over to him and under his zimba, saying that they were nim howalas and not simple ryots.

The Seins seeing this, and fearing lest they should be suddenly dispossessed and deprived of the fruits of their labours and expenditure, hired clubmen, and endeavoured to bring the ryots back to their allegiance, and to keep Sidam Mia out of the village. The result was several affrays, in which firearms were used and one or two persons killed.

It might be thought that this was a dispute which could have been easily settled by the authorities, as Sidam

Mia was manifestly a usurper, and was trying to reap what he had not sown. But in fact the matter was not so simple. It is true that neither he nor the ryots could say that he had spent any money in improving the property, or could deny that the ryots had been brought in by the Seins, but Sidam Mia had, nevertheless, rights in Gyanpara. He was the superior landlord and paid revenue to Government, and he could and did say that the subordinate or under-tenure rights claimed by the Seins did not exist or were exaggerated, and that the clearings were part of his khas land—*i.e.*, were included in the land of which he had direct possession. For these reasons an attempt made by the magistrate to quiet the dispute by prohibiting Sidam Mia or his people from entering the village, failed before the Sessions judge, and the contest continued for several months.

At length Sidam Mia died, and though his claims were maintained by his family, they had eventually to yield to the longer purse of their opponents. Sidam Mia's share in Gyanpara was put up for sale in execution of a decree, and was bought by the Seins and others for some Rs.40,000, so that they have now both the superior and the subordinate rights in the estate.

An instance of zimba was nearly occurring the other day in the large Government estate of Tushkháli, which is also in the Perozpúr subdivision. This estate, which yields upwards of R.78,000 a year, was let in farm for twenty years to the Messrs Morrell. The ryots became discontented with the farmers because the latter wanted to raise their rent, and indeed had taken the farm at an advance of Rs.15,000 on the old rental, on the condition that they were to be allowed to enhance the ryots' rents. The ryots objected, urging that their dōls or leases were permanent, and refused to break them, as they

phrased it, by giving any higher rate. When, therefore, the farmers issued notices on them, and took other steps to raise their rent, the ryots went to various zamindars in the district—*i.e.*, to the Raikátti zamindars, to Khajah Ahsanoolah, and to Har Chandra Chakrabarti of Kajlakátti—and offered to make over their dōls to them and to come under their zimba. As an inducement to the acceptance of this offer they were willing to pay salami, &c. Had their offers been accepted, a serious disturbance might have occurred, but the zamindars were afraid and held aloof.

It is a melancholy fact that the more energetic and able a zamindar is, the more is he disposed to create disturbances with his neighbours and to thwart the authorities. Such a person is always thrusting himself into the affairs of other estates, and is a centre of misrule and disaffection. Doubtless this is in a great measure the result of the exclusion of such men from legitimate careers; and it must be said, too, that his interference is not always unneeded, and not always quite spontaneous on his part. If a zamindar has a reputation for ability and courage, the ryots of other estates come to him and beg him to assist them against their oppressors. If interference of this kind was pardonable or commendable on the part of the ancient Romans, who built up their empire in this way, we cannot severely blame a Bengali zamindar for acting in a similar manner. I do not mean to defend the zimba system, but I believe that it often serves to protect the weak against the strong, and that it will last as long as the administration of justice is weak, uncertain, and dilatory. The knowledge that his ryots will, if driven to extremities, accept the protection of a zimbadar, will often prevent a tyrannical landlord from oppressing them too much. In other

districts ryots run away when too much trampled upon; in Bákarganj they go to a zimbadar. If elsewhere zamindari management may often be described as oppression tempered by the fear of desertion, it may be described as being in Bákarganj oppression tempered by the fear of zimbadari. Oppression from their zamindar is not the only kind under which ryots have to suffer. They are often still more grievously oppressed by their fellow-villagers, and have resort to the zimbadari system to protect themselves against this form of oppression also. The following is an instance of oppression by fellow-villagers.

In the village of Phalaghar, near the Bákarganj thana, there was in 1871 a Hindu ryot who had a quarrel with his neighbours about a road. He was a boat-builder as well as a cultivator, and required access to the khál, which flowed within a few yards of his homestead. When he and his neighbour were on good terms, the latter allowed him a right of way across his homestead, but when for some reason or other they quarrelled, his neighbour would not allow him to use the road any longer, at least not for his cattle; it became, therefore, necessary that the boatbuilder should find a new road. I have seen the place myself, and can therefore say that the road was a necessity for Kamal and Golab, the two owners of the more remote homestead. When their neighbour Chandra Dali inhibited them from crossing his homestead, they tried to make a new road, a little to one side of the old one. Unfortunately there was a small bit of waste land in the new line of road, which belonged to Chandra Dali, and which, though it was of no use to him, he would not let them have. Here I should explain that the homesteads both of Chandra Dali and of Golab

and Kamal were included in a taluq belonging to a member of the De Silva family of Sibpúr. Kamal and Golab's homestead, however, was a nim howala, and included in the first instance in a howala belonging to one Raj Narain Bannerji, which again was included in the De Silva taluq. Chandra Dali was also connected with Raj Narain Banarji, as he was his karshadar; but I believe this was for lands other than his homestead. Kamal and Golab first tried to get the little bit of waste land from Raj Narain, but though they got a right in it, they could not dispossess Chandra Dali, who to make his position stronger, suddenly put up a small hut on the land and placed an old female relative in it to act as watchwoman. By the way, it is rather a favourite trick with Bákarganj people to make use of their poor relations as chaukidars and as signs of possession. They run up a hut in a night, put an old man or woman into it, add a few pots and pans, and then when the police come they are ready to swear that the hut has been on the spot and in occupation for several years. Kamal and Golab being unable to get their road amicably, went off some fifteen miles to a powerful zamindar at Madhabpásha, who had long been anxious to get a footing in the village of Phalaghar, and who was on bad terms with the De Silvas, and offered to come under his zimba. He agreed; a deed was executed, whereby the zamindar bought in the name of his brother-in-law, for Rs.25, a portion of Kamal and Golab's nim howala; and shortly afterwards the real consideration was paid by the zamindar's despatching a body of clubmen to the village. They arrived in the night, and early next morning (it was Christmas Day) they and a party of ryots proceeded

to make a road across the waste land; but, unfortunately for themselves, Chandra Dali and his relatives heard the noise of the workers, and rushed out to oppose them. A fight ensued, in which, as might be supposed, the professional clubmen were victorious, and in which two of Chandra Dali's party were killed and one severely wounded. This case is an illustration of the anarchy which often prevails in a Bákarganj village. Had De Silva or the Madhabpásha zamindar been good landlords, they might have arbitrated in the matter, and have satisfied both parties; but they preferred to indulge their natural animosities, and the above was the result.

It might be expected that I should give statistics of the number of under-tenures in Bákarganj, but, in fact, no trustworthy figures are procurable. The inquiries in connection with the road cess will doubtless give some information on the subject, though I doubt if even they will elicit complete information.

### III. LAKHIRAJ, OR RENT-FREE TENURES.

The number of officially-recorded rent-free tenures is only twenty-three, and of these several are of recent origin, having been created by the rule, which was for some time in force, of selling rent free the properties which yielded less than a rupee of revenue to Government. There are, however, 1143 lakhiraj sanads or grants in the Collectorate record-room, and these are probably valid, though their authenticity has never been formally recognised, and it is not known even whether the lands referred to in them are in existence or not. The number of rent-free holdings in Bákarganj is in reality very considerable, though in most cases the

quantity of land is so small that the Government officials did not inquire into the validity of the grant. Many of these rent-free lands are Bráhmuttar—*i.e.*, they are lands granted to Bráhmans. They are especially common in pargana Chandradwip, and are said to owe their origin chiefly to the liberality of Rajah Sheo Narain, who was a great patron of Bráhmans, and who ended by becoming insane and setting fire to his palace. In his liberality to priests he resembled that Scotch king who was described by one of his successors as a sore saint for the crown.

None of the lakhiraj tenures seems to be of any interest except the Srinagar holding of the Chandradwip Rajahs, and that at Sujábád, formerly possessed by some Afghan soldiers. Both of these have been described elsewhere.

# *PART II.*

## CHAPTER VIII.

### *THE PEOPLE OF BÁKARGANJ.*

#### I. GENERAL REMARKS.

The population of Bákarganj, according to the census of 1872, and after deductions on account of the transfer of the Mádaripúr subdivision, is 1,878,144; of whom 1,254,429 are Mahomedans, 615,269 Hindus, 4049 Buddhists, and 3264 Christians.[1] It thus appears that two-thirds of the inhabitants are Mahomedans. The Hindus are in a minority in almost every part of the district, but are especially outnumbered in the south and in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, where nearly the whole population is Mahomedan. The Hindus are most numerous in the northern and western thanas of Gournadi, Jhalukátti, and Sarupkátti.

Before proceeding to describe the inhabitants of Bákarganj according to the divisions made by their different creeds, it seems right to say something of their general characteristics, apart from the colouring which particular religions may have given to portions of them.

Carlyle says that the most important thing about a man is his religion; but he afterwards so qualifies this remark, so flattens out its point, so to speak, that it

[1] See note at p. 247.

becomes the mere truism, that the most important thing about a man is his character, or even the tautological statement, that the most important thing about a man is—what is most important about him. It seems to me that it would be truer to say that the most important thing about an individual man is the character of his parents, and about a people the race to which it belongs. Certainly I do not think, in looking at the Bákarganj people, that it would be correct to say that the most important thing about the majority of them is whether they are Hindus or Mahomedans. They were Bengalis before they were Hindus or Mahomedans: as regards the world in general, the most important fact about them is that they belong to the Bengali race; and as regards Bengal, that they are natives of Bákarganj. It is true that Bákarganj is not a natural division of country, and that it is not even an old artificial one. Still it is a large and tolerably compact tract of territory, containing nearly two millions of inhabitants, who must, from contiguity of place and other similarity of circumstances, have some characteristics in common. We find, accordingly, that by general consent of foreigners, whether Englishmen or inhabitants of other parts of Bengal, the people of Bákarganj have certain peculiarities which mark them out from the rest of their countrymen. These peculiarities are not, I am sorry to say, of an amiable description, and consist in the possession of superior craftiness and greater turbulence of spirit. Hence the frequency of remarks such as that every man in Bákarganj is a lawyer, nothing is impossible in Bákarganj, &c. It would be idle to attempt to deny altogether the truth of such remarks. Foreigners seldom or never abuse the people of any country altogether without cause; and it is better for the latter to accept external criticisms as

partially true, and endeavour to profit by them, than to get angry, and regard them as entirely false. What especially strikes foreigners is the litigiousness of the Bákarganj people, and no doubt this is a marked feature in their character. Cases, both civil and criminal, are more numerous and more intricate in Bákarganj than in other districts. Bákarganj ryots, too, are a byword for turbulence, and for the readiness with which they combine to oppose their landlords. Forgery and perjury are of frequent occurrence; and such is the insecurity of the relation of landlord and tenant, that a practice has arisen which is, I believe, almost peculiar to Bákarganj. I refer to the practice of zamindars, and other receivers of rent, taking *chaláns* from their ryots on the payment of rent; so that there are always two documents drawn up on such occasions, one being the receipt given to the payer, and the other the chalán given to the payee. The origin of this custom is the anxiety to preserve a record of title, chaláns being always filed in suits about land to prove possession by receipt of rent.

There is a famous description of the Bengali character by Macaulay, in which he says that what the Italian is to the Englishman, what the Hindu is to the Italian, the Bengali is to other Hindus. Looking at the characteristics of the people of Bákarganj as described by foreigners, we might carry on Macaulay's illustration, and say that what Bengalis are to other nations, that are the inhabitants of Bákarganj to other Bengalis. I may add that a Deputy-Magistrate, who had been long in the district, once localised the climax still further by saying that what Bákarganj is to Bengal generally, that the subdivision of Perozpúr is to the rest of Bákarganj.

As far as the degrees of comparison go, I think the

illustration a good one. If Macaulay's estimate of the Bengali character be correct, the Bákarganj people may be said to be Bengalis of the Bengalis, for they excel the rest of their countrymen in the points noticed by the essayist. But Macaulay's description is much too neat and epigrammatic to be true, and there are a great many lights and shades of Bengali character which he has not noticed. Assuming, however, his estimate to be correct, I think we may say that the people of Bákarganj are typical Bengalis, and may proceed to inquire how they come to be so. I am inclined to think that the answer is to be found in part in the facts that Bákarganj has been chiefly peopled by emigrants from the rest of Bengal, and that emigrants are generally people of marked character. It is the listless and sluggish who remain at home, preferring to bear the ills they have than to fly to those they know not of, while the active and enterprising endeavour to better themselves elsewhere. Just, then, as we find the Americans exhibiting certain of the qualities of the English in an exaggerated degree, so we may expect to find the Bákarganj people exhibiting certain Bengali characteristics with peculiar prominence. Again, we find that the people of Bákarganj have been less controlled and less subjected to extraneous influences than Bengalis generally; hence their characters have developed more fully and completely. The district has always been somewhat neglected and despised, and has lain apart from the stream of events. The people have been left to themselves amongst their jungles and swamps, and have practically enjoyed much freedom. If we ask Bengali gentlemen why Bákarganj people differ from the inhabitants of Nadiya or other more civilised districts, they commonly reply that it is because there are

so few of the upper classes in the district. No doubt this is a *vera causa*. Bákarganj landlords are nearly all absentees, and the professional, and even the trading and shopkeeping classes, are largely composed of foreigners. There is not a single resident in the district who has an income of £10,000 per annum, and I believe there are not ten who have an income equal to that of the district judge. Nothing shows more clearly the absence of the upper classes from Bákarganj than the smallness of the returns from the income-tax. Thus we find that when all persons who had less than Rs.750 a year were exempt, there were only 1567 assessable persons in the whole district; and that when the minimum was raised to Rs.1000, there were only 847. We find also that the scarcity of rich people was most marked in the south of the district, and that in the large subdivision of Patuyakháli, with a population of upwards of 400,000, there were only eighty-four assessees when the minimum was Rs.750, and thirty-four when the minimum was Rs.1000. In other words, out of 400,000 people there are only about thirty who are worth £100 a year. At the same time, there is probably less actual want and poverty in Bákarganj than in the rest of Bengal. The soil is fertile, and Bákarganj ryots are notoriously comfortable. They have plenty of rice, can catch fish in every ditch and water-hole, and have cocoa-nuts, betel-nuts, plantains, &c., in their orchards. There is little they need buy except salt, clothes, and tobacco. We may therefore apply Longfellow's description of Grand Pré to Bákarganj, and say, "There the richest is poor, and the poorest lives in abundance." This plenty, combined with the feeling of ownership and independence produced by the system of peasant properties, gives vigour and energy to the char-

acter. The effect of the inaccessibility of Bákarganj on the disposition of the people has already been touched upon, but the subject calls for further elucidation. Bákarganj is difficult of access from Calcutta, for though it is only 180 miles distant, there is no land route, and boats take six or even ten days on the journey. The route, too, is through the dreaded and inhospitable Sundarbans, which, in the minds of the timorous Bengalis, are still haunted by dacoits and wild beasts. Hence we find that Bákarganj has been little visited by the great of the earth. Besides this external inaccessibility, Bákarganj has very few roads, and it is consequently exceedingly difficult to travel rapidly or with comfort. The islands of the district are surrounded by large rivers which are really formidable during the rains, and they are seldom visited by strangers, except in the cold weather. The south of the district especially is intersected by rivers and creeks, and as its climate during and immediately after the rains is considered unhealthy, it is generally abandoned for the greater part of the year by every one who can get away from it. It is in this part of the district, where the people have been much left to themselves, that we find their peculiarities most strongly developed. Not only are they separated from the outer world, but they are also isolated from one another, so that each person's individuality gets full scope. Villages in Bákarganj, and especially in the south, are very different from villages in Behar or the north-west, or even in Bengal generally. The houses are much more scattered, and there is little of collective village life. Each house stands by itself on its mound, surrounded by a thicket of fruit-trees, and there is often no other house in sight or nearer than several hundred yards. The intervening space, too, is generally a swamp

across which it is toilsome and difficult to walk. In such villages the system of village police is almost non-existent. Mr Reilly, in an interesting passage of his report on the Bákarganj police, has touched upon this peculiarity of life in the south of the district, and assigns to it the frequency of serious crime.

I have said that Macaulay's estimate of the Bengali character is not a correct or complete one. I may here briefly state how it errs, in my opinion. It does not do justice to some virtues possessed by Bengalis—namely, temperance, frugality, and patience. Neither is it quite just in the matter of courage, for though the Bengali is cowardly in some respects, he is not altogether timid. For example, he is probably more courageous with regard to wild beasts than most Europeans. The inhabitants of Bákarganj are hardy boatmen, and often cross rivers in rough and dangerous weather. The most serious charge of all brought against Bengalis is that they are liars. On this head I may quote from a lecture which I delivered in Scotland some years ago: "As regards the charge of the Bengalis being liars, people who abuse them of course make a great deal of what Lord Macaulay has said on the subject in his essays on Clive and Warren Hastings. Now Lord Macaulay was, as all the world acknowledges, a very brilliant writer, but his eloquence and love of paradox were apt to lift him off his feet. He was a Scotchman by origin, and therefore he had to a certain extent the Scottish intellect, which, like the French, is deductive and generalising, and apt to draw large conclusions from a scanty induction of facts. . . . At the same time, I am not here to-night to defend the Bengalis, but to tell the truth about them as far as I know it, and therefore I must admit that they are rather addicted to falsehood. I think that the ex-

tent of their lying propensities has been exaggerated, and that a great deal of what we are apt to consider deliberate falsehood on their part proceeds from nervousness, from a want of precision in thought and expression, and from our ignorance and impatience. Still it is not to be denied that lying is the great vice of the Oriental character, just as harshness and want of feeling are probably the most distinctive vices of Western nations; and it is possible that in both cases many centuries will elapse before such characteristics be obliterated."

The following remarks may also be quoted: "The charge of ingratitude brought against Bengalis hardly deserves a serious answer. In the first place, it is not true that they are destitute of a word expressive of gratitude; and in the second place, even if the dictionary did not give such a word, every one who knows the natives knows that they have the sentiment in their hearts, and that they show it in their actions.

"The general character of the Bengali is amiable. He has no large sympathies and little vigour of mind, but he is gentle and affectionate, and very charitable to the poor. He is particularly fond of children, and a Bengali servant makes a capital nurse for his master's children; he is so patient with them, and so willing and delighted to sit with them and amuse them all day long. Bengalis, indeed, are said to spoil their children by over-indulgence, and certainly they seem to indulge their whims to almost any extent. I remember to have seen a common Bengali peasant ploughing his field, which happened to be at the time under two or three inches of water, while his little child was perched on his shoulder. On my asking why he had the child with him, I was told that it cried at being left behind

when his father went out to plough. So the father had taken him out with him, though he would have to bear his weight the whole forenoon in order to keep him out of the water.

"One of the charges most frequently brought against the Bengali is his fondness for litigation. A wealthy native, it is said, plumes himself on having two or three heavy law pleas on hand, much as a wealthy Englishman plumes himself on the possession of a yacht or a picture gallery. Nor is the poorer native backward in his liking for the same kind of sport; nothing seems to delight a Bengali peasant so much as the having an opportunity of stating his claim in a court of justice. The great subjects of the lawsuits are disputes about land; for, as a rule, the commercial classes keep out of the courts, and, moreover, the Bengalis are much more an agricultural than a trading people. Land in India is not the property of a few, as it is in this country, for the system of peasant proprietorship is in vogue, and, except in the case of the inhabitants of great towns, almost every householder has his small piece of land. Sometimes he holds the land rent free, but generally pays rent for it, either to the British Government or more commonly to some superior landholder, or zamindar as he is called. The amount of rent depends a good deal upon the custom of the district, and cannot be increased at the mere will and pleasure of the zamindar. Neither can the tenant, or ryot as he is called, be evicted from his holding as long as he pays the customary rent, unless the zamindar can prove that certain changes have taken place in the value of the produce, &c., which make the old rent too low to be fair and equitable. Such proof is rather difficult, and leads to tedious and expensive litigation, and so ryot and zamindar gene-